

伪像报告

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虚伪聚钱®

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Chapter 1 — Mai Minghe: I Want to Pick More Daisies

When Mai Minghe woke, the room was dark, and through the gap beneath the curtains there was still nothing but night.

She slept lightly, waking several times each night — but the reason she woke tonight was different. A small, hard sound had pulled her out of sleep, rising above the steady whoosh-whoosh that filled the room like background noise.

What was making that sound?

Drowsiness still clung to her, and for a moment she couldn't quite place it.

The metallic scraping and clinking continued until, with a sharp snap, the lock cylinder gave, and the door was pushed open with a long, creaking groan. The hinges hadn't been oiled in years; they were stiff and dry as an old man's joints, and they split the silent night open like a wound.

Ah. Someone had picked her front door.

If her mother ever found out, there'd be no end to the scolding — a girl living alone, and she couldn't even wedge a chair against the door at night?

Her mother had never trusted the world. She checked the gas four or five times before leaving the house, always glanced at the back seat before getting into a car, and had never once allowed her daughter to nod or smile at a stranger.

Mai Minghe had always thought her mother was a little too anxious. It hadn't occurred to her that someone would actually break into her home one night.

She couldn't make out what happened next very clearly, but through the blur of half-sleep, a figure walked in. A beam of light swept back and forth along the crack beneath the door — a flashlight.

Unfamiliar footsteps moved dully through the living room, punctuated by the occasional creak. Mai Minghe knew that sound: the wooden floorboards just outside the kitchen door. A pipe had burst there one year, and the boards had warped from the soaking, and ever since they had been voicing their sharp, unsolicited opinions.

A burglar in the house was really quite a novelty.

She closed her eyes again and listened closely to what the burglar was doing.

He opened the door to the room next door first — a narrow little room that had never really been used for much. It had been painted as a nursery once, then recast as a study, then turned into a wardrobe room, though none of those purposes had ever truly taken hold; now it was just a storage room thick with dust.

One glance would tell you the room was piled floor to ceiling with junk, nothing worth rifling through. Sure enough, the footsteps retreated almost at once, and the door was shut with a dull thud.

In truth, you could search the entire building and probably not find anything of value.

Things did go missing in this subsidized housing block — that was common enough. Once, Mai Minghe had left her door unlatched, and by the time she noticed, a pair of ankle boots had vanished from the shoe rack by the entrance. She'd been so furious she'd gone door to door asking around, and gotten nowhere. But losing things to neighbors was one thing; it was rare for an outsider to actually pick a lock and go to all this trouble to steal from people who had nothing to begin with.

It was funny, really — such a trivial thing, and she still remembered it perfectly. Those boots had been calf leather, a rich smooth brown, glossy and sharp-looking. She'd never found another pair she liked as much.

Whatever he wanted to take, he could take it. She didn't have anything worth fussing over.

The burglar turned toward the bedroom doorway. The door swung open, and the flashlight swept in, finding Mai Minghe at once.

The fierce white light blazed through her closed eyelids and lit up her face. She lay still, eyes shut, feigning sleep.

A stranger's voice let out an involuntary "Huh?" — as if genuinely startled.

Mai Minghe held herself still and said nothing.

The burglar's footsteps tapped into the room. He made a circuit of the bedroom, didn't even bother opening the nightstand drawer, and went back out.

What kind of thief went about it so carelessly? Mai Minghe almost felt anxious on his behalf. You had to have some patience with a thing, some tolerance for the trouble it took.

A minute or two passed. He came back in and approached the bed; the warm, living heat of another person hovered above her.

"Hey," a man's voice said, and a hand gave Mai Minghe's bony shoulder a nudge. "Hey — wake up."

There didn't seem to be much point in pretending to sleep anymore.

What did he want to wake her for? If he was looking for something valuable, couldn't he just look? Not content with stealing — now he wanted to be lazy about it too. People these days, really.

Mai Minghe opened her eyes. A dark figure was crouched over her beside the bed.

The flashlight hung at the bedside, its beam pointing downward, so the burglar's face was lost in shadow. Only at the edge of the light could she make out a pale throat, bobbing up and down as he spoke.

"Don't be scared — I just want to ask you something. Is there someone here named Mai Minghe?"

"...That's me. Do we know each other?"

The man drew a breath and straightened up, looking over the shape beneath the blanket.

"You — you're the one?" He seemed reluctant to accept it. He raised the flashlight and swept it across Mai Minghe's face several times, quite without ceremony.

She hadn't looked in a mirror in a long time. She didn't know what she looked like now, but it couldn't be good.

"Is something wrong?" she asked quietly.

The man stood there with his mouth half open, as though he was still digesting something.

He didn't want her to be Mai Minghe — that much she could see. Because he asked again, slowly, as though afraid she hadn't heard: "Mai — as in the character for wild wheat. Mai. Ming. He."

"That's me," Mai Minghe said, with a small smile. "There's no one else."

The man stared at her.

After a few seconds, he asked: "How old are you, Auntie?"

How old was she? Even she had to think about it.

She couldn't say when it had started, but she had long since stopped keeping track of her age. Sometimes she even made the mistake of thinking she was still a young girl.

A year was just one year — it didn't sound like much. But a year was made of countless tiny moments, as many and as fine as snowflakes falling from the sky; and without your noticing, they had piled into a whole lifetime.

Reach out and grab a handful of snow, and you couldn't say when any flake of it had fallen. A length of life floated up to the surface, and she had already forgotten how long ago it came from.

The social worker had said that at her age — eighty-six — Mai Minghe's mind was still fairly clear, unlike some elderly people...

"Eighty-six?" Mai Minghe asked the social worker she was remembering. "You must have it wrong. I'm not that old."

Quiet settled back over the room, and the steady whoosh-whoosh rose up again.

The burglar seemed to hear it for the first time. He pointed at the thin plastic tube tucked into Mai Minghe's nose. "Is that... are you on oxygen?"

"Hm?" She forgot about it sometimes. "Oh, yes. Dreadful nuisance."

The burglar sighed. He set the flashlight on the bedside, and its circle of light bloomed against the opposite wall, dividing the room — a ring of bright, vivid luminance, and beyond it the dim, heavy dark.

"How silly of me — I forgot to ask," said Mai Minghe. "Do you drink tea?" It had been so long since anyone came by that she'd nearly forgotten how to be a host. "It's a bit hard for me to get up... but there's tea and biscuits in the kitchen. Help yourself."

The burglar shifted uncomfortably, as though he hadn't expected any of this.

"No, it's fine," he said, hesitating for a moment before adding: "Do you — would you like some? I could bring it to you."

Mai Minghe declined and thanked him. The homeowner and the burglar exchanged polite pleasantries for a little while.

The burglar clasped his hands, stared at the television in the corner of the room for a long moment, and addressed it: "Are you not well?"

"I'm fine. I can still get up and walk on my own."

"...What about meals? Does your son or daughter bring them?"

"I don't have any children," she said with a small smile. "And I don't eat very much — it doesn't take much to manage. The social worker brings me vegetables and eggs every now and then."

"A social worker? You have no family in Blackmoor City?"

"I've gotten used to it," Mai Minghe said. "I never had many relatives or friends to begin with, and the ones I had all died before me. Dear, do you want to watch television?"

The burglar seemed to find the question absurd. He was quiet for a moment, then suddenly pulled out his phone, glanced at it, and walked briskly out of the room.

"Hello?"

So he'd gotten a call.

"Yes, I've found her... No, I haven't done it yet." The burglar paused here. "Listen — did you know she's an old woman? Eighty-six years old. It wasn't in the file."

The other person's reply was brief, because the burglar spoke again almost immediately.

"I know," the burglar said, making no effort to lower his voice — probably figuring there was no need. "But... does it have to be hers? She's not the only one with a passage. And we don't even know what her passage is like... even a young person would have a hard time of it. What if she can't hold on and dies?"

The person on the phone was not pleased; their voice rose loud enough that Mai Minghe could almost make it out from where she lay.

The burglar endured the tirade in silence for a while, and at last said, like a student who had done something wrong: "No... I understand. I'm sorry. I'll get it."

Sometimes Mai Minghe would be startled by her own hands.

Thick, folded skin, layer upon layer draped over each bone, the tendons and veins raised and visible, almost without warmth — so unlike the hands she remembered as hers. They felt like they belonged to someone else.

With that hand that no longer felt like her own, she groped beneath the blanket and found the pendant against her chest, and closed her fingers tightly around it.

This time, the burglar came straight in and said: "I'm sorry, Auntie. I need to take something from you."

She could just barely make out his face — a decent, open sort of face, twenty-something or thirty at most, still a young man; you'd never guess he was someone who meant harm.

"What do you want?" Mai Minghe asked. "I don't need most of it anymore — take whatever you like. There's a silver brooch in the drawer..."

"No, I don't want your belongings," the burglar interrupted. "I need to take something from inside your body."

"Is it an organ?" Mai Minghe asked, curious. Her organs didn't seem like they'd be worth much to anyone.

"No — no, it isn't. Don't ask. You wouldn't understand even if I explained."

"Then... will I die?" Mai Minghe asked. "You said as much. Just now."

The question caught the burglar off guard. He was silent for two seconds before saying: "I don't know... possibly."

Mai Minghe lay quietly and looked at the cracks in the ceiling.

"If you need to take it, then take it," she said softly. "Only... before you do — could you grant me one last wish?"

At some point the burglar had moved to stand beside her.

"What wish?"

"I used to work at a library. The pay was very little, but I loved it, and I was happy there... One day when I was leaving, the librarian told me there was an old book that had been cleared out — they hadn't been able to sell it at a discount, so they offered to let me take it home."

The burglar's hand came to rest on her pillow.

Near his feet there was a dark, hulking shape — some kind of machine, apparently; she had no idea when it had been brought in. She was only noticing it now.

"I looked and saw it was a collection of poetry. I took it home and flipped through it for a little while." Mai Minghe murmured. "I put it down when I was done and, later on, even the book itself disappeared somewhere. But for some reason... in recent years, I keep thinking about one of the poems inside."

"Which poem?"

"You young people all have one of those... clever phones, don't you?"

"Smartphones," the burglar corrected.

If she had a grandchild, they might correct her the same way.

"They say you can find anything on them?"

"...More or less."

"Could you look it up for me?" Mai Minghe asked. "I want to hear that poem one more time."

The burglar looked down at her, and for a moment seemed at a loss. He pulled a tissue from the box on the nightstand and pressed it into her hand. When Mai Minghe stared at it, bewildered, he said: "All right, all right — don't cry. I'll find it. Do you remember the title?"

She was crying?

So even at this age, she wasn't ready to die.

Or perhaps — at this age — she still hadn't had a chance to really live.

"It's called... something about Daisies." Mai Minghe deliberately held back part of the title.

There was so much on a smartphone — finding a specific poem wasn't easy, and Daisies was such a common image in poetry. It took a long time, as she'd expected.

After finding several poems that weren't right, the burglar finally lost patience: "Auntie, if you can't remember the name, that's not my fault. I still have to get back and report in — you —"

"I remember now," Mai Minghe said quickly.

This young man who had come to take something from her was likely the last person in her life who could help her hear a poem one more time.

Even if she could delay no longer, even if she had to face death head-on — at least she could listen to a little poetry first. That much was still good.

"'I Shall Gather More Daisies'... I think that's the title."

The young man glanced at her, said nothing, and tapped at the screen a few times with his fingers.

This time, he found the poem Mai Minghe had been turning over in her mind — and he found it quickly.

"I found a reading video for you," he said, setting his phone down on the edge of the bed.

In the silent room thick with the smell of medicine and decay, the ad before the video burst to life — cheerful and loud, announcing a special deal at Little Caesars Pizza.

"It'll start after the ad. You just listen — I'll keep working while you do."

He bent down and pulled a tube from the dark, hulking machine.

...If I had my life to live over,

I would try to make more mistakes.

I would relax.

I would be more supple.

I would be sillier than I have been on this trip.

Mai Minghe felt something warm and wet spreading beside her ears.

She had lived like her parents — a lifetime of anxious, exhausting calculation. When wartime inflation hit, she planned every meal with painstaking care; in peacetime, she kept the family accounts every single week. As a child, her family ran a little shop, and no matter how desperately she craved it, she never once dared steal so much as a piece of candy from the shelf.

As she grew older she came to many crossroads, their shoulders bright with wildflowers, and she never set foot on any of them.

People are strange — everyone knows they only get this one life, yet every single day is lived as though there is still infinite time, as though there will always be another chance.

The thief pulled back her blanket and laid a cool tube against Mai Minghe's chest, and only then did she dimly register that the thing looked a bit like an old-fashioned vacuum cleaner.

"What's this?" The thief picked up the pendant resting on her chest, gave it a glance, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to answer, nudged it aside from the mouth of the tube. Young

people never recognized it — never knew what the thing was for.

Thank goodness he didn't.

Amid the poem, he pressed the mouth of the tube against Mai Minghe's skin-and-bones chest. He switched the machine on, and a low hum unlike anything she had ever heard slowly coiled through the room.

...If I could do it again, I would travel lighter, wander farther, try more things.

If I could do it again, I would run barefoot through the long stretch of spring and autumn.

I would try playing hooky,

I would not work so hard for good grades — except by accident.

I would ride more merry-go-rounds.

I shall gather more daisies.

In the very last moment before death's darkness closed over Mai Minghe, she heard it faintly — the front door of the apartment being thrown open, and then the urgent stamp of footsteps, and voices, rushing in all at once.

Carried for years, and at last delivered — an ugly little thing...

"I Shall Gather More Daisies" is a real poem. The poet wrote it when she was eighty-five — one year younger than my daughter. Actually, the inspiration didn't come from the poem itself; I had already started writing when the poem suddenly came to mind, and it felt just right.

Goodness, it's been so long since I updated and even longer since I rambled at you all — I'm almost embarrassed. I don't even know what to say.

Thank you for coming back.

Chapter 2 — Mai Minghe Rescued from Hallucination?

"You live alone,"

The social worker unfolded a small brochure and showed it to her. "If you fall and there's no one around, it's dangerous. Best to get one of these to hang around your neck — it won't get in the way. What do you think?"

That had been several years ago.

Mai Minghe still remembered the pamphlet's illustration. The product name was blunt and to the point: "Life Alert."

In the picture, a white-haired woman lay sprawled on the floor, accompanied by two lines of small text: "Help! I've fallen and I can't get up!"

Her older cousin had shattered her pelvis in her eighties and never got out of bed again. Once you couldn't leave the bed, your days were numbered.

What year had she passed? Mai Minghe couldn't remember anymore.

The legs that had once carried her leaping onto rooftops and running wild — in the blink of an eye, she now had to be wary of them betraying her every time she tried to get out of bed.

The body she had lived in her whole life had slowly become a stranger to her; she was like a stiffening wheel, each turn slower than the last, powerless to reverse the slide.

"The Emergency Response System runs twenty-four hours a day, three hundred and sixty-five days a year," the social worker explained, worried she couldn't make out the text on the brochure. "No matter what the emergency, you press it and someone comes — let me see — oh, they guarantee a response within thirty minutes at most, and there are participating hospitals nearby."

Mai Minghe took the brochure and studied the pictures for a moment.

She had scrimped and saved all her life, yet now money had somehow lost its weight; prices were just little curved symbols on a page.

"I'll take this one," she said, pointing to the third model. "This one looks the best. Like a pendant necklace."

The social worker stifled a laugh. "Sure — you'll look great wearing it."

Though it looked nothing like one, she wore it as a necklace anyway; she had worn it that way for years, until the night the intruder walked into the living room to make a phone call — and she pressed the Life Alert for the very first time.

The thief probably hadn't expected that the "necklace" on her chest was an alarm — the young and the old lived in two worlds that were nearly sealed off from each other. Unless you had regular reason to deal with elderly people, you rarely knew what their lives looked like, let alone the things they saw and used every day.

From the moment she had made the thief search for a poem... she had stalled with every trick she could think of, and a good ten minutes had passed.

No one had come yet, and she was running out of steam.

For reasons she couldn't explain, the cold tube defied gravity — with no one holding it, it stood perfectly upright on her chest. The machine hummed steadily, the recited poetry grew fainter and farther away, and she sank into rolling waves of dizzy blackness, deeper and deeper with every pass.

From deep within that darkness, fragments rose like shards of a broken dream — hallucinations.

Strange. They said that when a person was dying, the memories of a whole life would flash before their eyes — but what Mai Minghe saw was another version of herself, a tube connected to her own chest just the same, walking step by step toward the television, then suddenly lunging forward and crashing headlong into the screen.

She was startled by her own actions and heard a dim, murky thud somewhere inside her chest.

With her eyes half-open and half-shut, the hallucination and reality overlapped; the self in the vision hurled herself again and again at the old television in the corner of the room, and the screen bloomed with spiderweb cracks over and over again.

The hallucination was finally shattered by a sharp, commanding voice — a stranger's low, rough tone shouting: "What are you doing? Who are you?"

Mai Minghe jolted, and her eyes fluttered weakly open.

In her blurred vision, a jet-black, glossy tube stood upright on her chest, as though it possessed more vitality than she did, pressing her heavily down into the bed.

An instant later, the tube vanished.

The thief snatched the tube behind his back, and despite his panic, his wits were sharp — he turned the question on the two people who had just burst into the bedroom: "Who are you? Why are you barging into my grandmother's house?"

Two people strode in through the doorway, snapped on the light, and drove the night away; the room blazed white-bright, revealing a bedroom thick with decay, the smell of medicine, cracks crawling up the walls, and the steady whoosh-whoosh of the oxygen machine.

They were both in blue-and-white uniforms — nurse aides.

"Your grandmother?"

The male nurse aide glanced at Mai Minghe, then turned a skeptical eye on the thief. "Her? She's your grandmother?"

"I'm two generations mixed — it doesn't show as much anymore." The thief seemed to register the difference in their skin tones and ethnicities, and he recovered quickly. "See — I have black hair. And who are you people?"

"We're emergency-response nurse aides. We came because we received an alert signal — we thought there was an emergency." The other voice, a woman's, explained. "According to our records, she lives alone."

The thief had composed himself entirely.

"Yes," he said, giving Mai Minghe's arm a gentle, reassuring pat, then speaking to the nurse aides: "You responded very quickly — thank you for coming so fast. There's been a small misunderstanding. I'm in Blackmoor City on a business trip and I'm staying with my grandmother for the time being. She's getting on in years, her mind isn't as clear as it used to be, and she forgot I was coming — she must have hit the alarm because she didn't recognize me. She's fine."

The female nurse aide stepped closer to the bed, lifted Mai Minghe's eyelids, checked her over, and asked softly: "Ma'am, are you all right?"

Mai Minghe opened her mouth and tried to say something, but only the faintest thread of breath slipped between her lips. The nurse aide had seen enough to be unsurprised that she couldn't speak, and began listening to her heartbeat.

"Would you mind showing me some identification?" The male nurse aide still sounded a little uncertain, turning to the thief.

"Of course," the thief said, and bold as you please, right in front of the nurse aides, he kicked the black device with its attached tube under Mai Minghe's bed with his foot, muttering as he did: "Why is the vacuum cleaner left here of all places... Just a second — let me go to the next room and get my wallet. My driver's license is in there."

She was lying in a hospital-style care bed fitted with four wheels; the space underneath was open and empty — just right for storing things.

"Oh — the phone," the thief had only taken two steps before he turned back, gave the female nurse aide who was still examining Mai Minghe a smile, and said: "Almost forgot. My grandmother sometimes gets frightened for no reason — you have to put on some poetry and music to settle her down."

The female nurse aide's gaze crossed over Mai Minghe to sweep once across the phone screen, and her expression eased another notch, visibly relaxing.

Mai Minghe thought: a thief who pries open doors and slips into people's homes at night, playing poetry for the owner — who would ever believe that? He looked every bit the devoted grandson.

Since she wasn't dead yet, that must mean the thief hadn't managed to take whatever it was he wanted from inside her, right?

Right — otherwise he wouldn't still be here playing the doting grandson.

If the nurse aides had come even a few minutes later, though, he would have succeeded.

Nobody knew that death had just been sitting right beside her, leaning over and gazing down at her face; she had never been this close to death before, and this was the first time she had ever experienced a dying hallucination...

Wait — the television!

Even Mai Minghe herself hadn't expected it: the moment she thought back on the hallucination, an urge came out of nowhere — an urgent, irrational need to roll off the bed and go touch the television.

She had to get over there. She had to get over there now...

Wave after wave of urgency crashed and broke inside her, until Mai Minghe was so desperate she nearly cried out.

The dark, unlit television screen had become the only thing in the world with any weight to it, pressing heavily into her field of vision, drawing her toward it; the room, the nurse aides, the thief — they were all flat as paper, as though they might any moment float up off the floor.

Mai Minghe strained to raise her hand toward the television.

"Ma'am, what is it? What do you need?" The female nurse aide followed the line of her raised hand, looked back, and asked: "Do you want to watch television?"

The door to the storage room next door opened and then closed again, as though the thief really had gone in to fetch something. Just as the nurse aide was asking her question, he happened to return, handing his ID to the male nurse aide; the latter looked it over, and when he spoke again, his posture and tone had both loosened.

Mai Minghe let out a small sound through her nose — a syllable of negation — her hand still pointing at the television.

"I'll switch it on for you," the female nurse aide said, kindhearted despite her puzzlement, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to answer, she turned on the television.

A daytime news commentary program was airing on replay; the host was going over and over the sudden death of Blackmoor City tycoon Wellesley the day before, cataloguing his business miracles and his charitable work.

"No... no." Mai Minghe finally found her voice again, which was quietly reassuring — good, she could speak; her strength was coming back.

The thief shot her a quick glance.

He turned back to the male nurse aide at once, picking up where he had left off: "...My grandmother is getting on in years. The older she gets, the more muddled she becomes, and the more stubborn on top of it. There's no family in Blackmoor City who can look after her..."

Such a young face, such an endless stream of lies.

Telling them this person wasn't her grandson would probably accomplish nothing. An ordinary thief wouldn't stay on the scene to negotiate; from the nurse aides' perspective, if anything, she was the one who looked like she had dementia — not him.

Never mind. The television was more important, more urgent than he was right now.

"Help... help me over there," Mai Minghe pointed at the television and said softly to the female nurse aide: "Please."

The thief glanced at her again, then at the television set.

Before he could say anything, the male nurse aide's question seized his attention: "When we came in, you were bent over holding some kind of tube. What were you doing?"

"You don't have to go all the way over there — you can see the television just fine from here." The female nurse aide seemed a little reluctant.

The thief was explaining: "Grandmother woke up calling in the middle of the night, so I got up and came to check on her, and found the vacuum cleaner hose had fallen onto the bed."

"Please," Mai Minghe gripped the female nurse aide's hand tightly, fixing her gaze on those brown eyes, and implored: "Help me over there. Please. I... I just want to sit over there for a little while."

She was acting more and more like a confused old woman.

"All right, I'll help you." The female nurse aide gave in. "Can you get up?"

"Yes. Yes, I can."

The thief glanced at Mai Minghe once more, then moved over of his own accord with every appearance of concern, taking her other arm — which also gave him a convenient excuse to break away from the male nurse aide's questioning. "Grandmother, what do you want to go over there for? Just take a quick look, and then you have to come back to bed, all right?"

Mai Minghe ignored him. Such a decent-looking young man — what on earth was he doing with himself?

Supported by the two of them, she shuffled haltingly to the television set; her own pallid, ghost-like half-reflection floated on the dark surround of the screen, then vanished as the broadcast cut to a shot of the Wellesley Family Estate.

She understood now.

So there really had been a reason for the hallucination — just as she'd thought.

No wonder she had felt such desperate urgency to get over here. Ha — she should have worked it out sooner; at her age, the mind just wasn't what it used to be.

"I'll go get a chair," the female nurse aide said, and let go of Mai Minghe.

That left only the thief holding her. He loosely cradled her withered arm, as if afraid to grip it too firmly.

"If everything's all right, then we'll be on our way." The male nurse aide stood in the doorway and turned to the thief: "You'll be able to get her back to bed yourself in a moment?"

The thief exhaled with relief and nodded repeatedly. "Of course — sorry to have made you come all this way..."

While he was talking, Mai Minghe suddenly pulled her arm free, let her body tip backward, and toppled toward the television screen.

She should have thought of it sooner — her hallucination had been telling her exactly how to save herself.

Fall against the television right in front of the nurse aides, and they would have no choice but to take her to the hospital, no matter what the thief claimed his relationship to her was. Once she was in the hospital, there would be people everywhere, and she would be safe.

The thief snapped his head around at the edge of her peripheral vision, but he was a beat too slow, too late; Mai Minghe heard the heavy, dull crack of her skull striking the television, and then the room erupted in startled cries and rushing footsteps.

The female social worker seemed to be calling out something from a very great distance, but Mai Minghe couldn't make out the words —

"Where did she go?"

Posted yesterday

But I didn't expect to open the book

We're only two chapters in — no need to put me in debt just yet; let's see a bit more first. What if it gets boring later? It's not like Qidian lets you get your tips refunded, right?

The same goes for 95, 秋水不染尘, 相声福晋, 绾瑾, 颖佑, 西下有木名栗, 039追女媧?, 卡夫卡, and everyone else — are you all angel investors or something? I'm overwhelmed with gratitude...

To be honest, the book launches on the 12th, and I have a long trip to take on the 14th... My stockpile of chapters definitely won't survive the bumps of the road *plus* bonus chapters from tips — looks like I'll be clacking away on my keyboard on the airplane again.

P.S.: I've seen some readers asking why this is posted on the male-readership platform when it's also part of a Strong Female Lead special feature. The editors have their reasons — a significant portion of male-platform readers are actually women who don't visit the female-readership platform, so a Strong Female Lead special feature on the male side is meant to draw them in. Think of it as poaching readers for the female platform... kind of (?)

Chapter 3: Sweet Illusions in Mai Minghe's Hospital Room

The world spun wildly around her, and Mai Minghe instinctively grabbed at a white shape nearby — but it wasn't enough to catch herself, and she crashed down onto the cold tile floor, letting out a hoarse groan.

Oh no — had she broken something?

The pain burst across her vision in dizzy blotches, and she couldn't even tell which bone it was that might be the death of her — one fall was all it took to shatter her to pieces, to scatter her across the floor like broken crockery.

A fall like this ought to be enough to make her nurse aides rush her to the hospital; yet she waited through several ragged breaths, and no nurse aide came hurrying in, and no one asked, "Are you all right?"

What was going on?

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes and looked more carefully — and froze.

...This wasn't her room.

The space around her was dim and hazy, but through the thin sliver of white light leaking under the door, she could just make out that this was a very large room. Directly in front of her and behind her stood a narrow, empty bed apiece; what she had grabbed, it turned out, was the corner of a bed sheet.

She let go of the sheet and looked left, then right.

A row of wheeled care beds, each with a small nightstand alongside it, each partitioned off by a hanging curtain — this was obviously a hospital ward. She'd been admitted enough times to recognize one at a glance.

Strange.

How had she ended up in a hospital ward? Her nurse aides must have brought her, surely?

But how had she managed to forget the entire process of being brought to the hospital? It was as though it had never happened — as though someone had gouged a black hole straight through her memory.

Pushing through the panic and the pain, no matter how hard she thought, the last moment she could actually recall was still herself slamming into the television; she remembered the agony as the world tilted around her, and then — the very next instant — she was falling onto the floor of a hospital ward.

It was almost as if she had fallen directly from her home into the hospital — but that was impossible.

Had she blacked out at the time, and that was why she couldn't remember?

"Is anyone there?" Mai Minghe called out in a raspy voice. "Nurse? I've fallen..."

In the cold, silent ward, her cry for help was like a splinter of ice, sinking slowly into a frigid river until it was as though it had never existed at all.

Whether from pain or cold, she couldn't stop shivering in wave after wave of tremors. If this kept up, something terrible would happen — she had to call a nurse right away. That's right, the head of a hospital bed usually had a call button.

Mai Minghe struggled to push herself upright, trying to stand, but the pain in her leg bones wouldn't allow it; her hands and feet were weak and unsteady, and she slipped, nearly falling again.

With no other option, she could only inch her way toward the nightstand, prop herself against its edge, and stretch her arm out as far as it would go until her fingertips just barely found the call button.

"If I were you, I wouldn't press that."

A man's voice came out of nowhere, and the shock of it detonated in Mai Minghe's chest; blood surged straight up, as though it might burst through the walls of her skull.

She steadied herself through the dizziness, turned her head toward the sound, and only then noticed that behind her there was yet another hospital bed.

The curtain around that bed was drawn — though not all the way — leaving the neighboring patient's feet visible.

Those feet were bare, nothing on them at all, white as snow dusted with thick powder, toes curled ever so slightly, perfectly, utterly still.

Mai Minghe felt her chest loosen with relief — thank goodness, there was someone else in the room.

"Are you — are you a patient here too?" she asked, her breathing still uneven; even as she spoke, she reached toward the call button again.

"You really want to call the nurse?" the patient behind the curtain asked in return.

"Yes... I've fallen. I don't have a choice."

Under ordinary circumstances, in the middle of the night, she wouldn't have called a nurse over something minor if she could help it — she understood the concern the patient next door was hinting at.

She pressed the call button, and nothing happened — not a single sound rang out in the room.

"Look at that, you pressed it anyway."

The neighboring patient seemed to know nonetheless, and began to laugh — a stiff, flat sound, as though they were deliberately contracting their diaphragm one pulse at a time, each burst measured out to precisely the same length.

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and slowly slid down to sit on the floor, every part of her going slack and heavy; all the while, she kept a quiet sidelong eye on that curtain.

"Won't listen to advice, will you... People really do get more stubborn as they get older. I was only saying it for your own good."

"What do you... mean by that?"

The other person laughed again, two crisp, rigid bursts, and said nothing.

Something felt off — she just couldn't put her finger on why.

Mai Minghe was still debating whether to ask again when, from the dead-silent corridor outside the door, a broadcast suddenly tore through the air at an ear-splitting volume — an electronic female voice, loud and reverberating, permeating the very panels of the ward door: "Room Three, Bed 03 calling for a nurse. Room Three, Bed 03 calling for a nurse!"

The broadcast startled her so badly it hurt — her hand flew to her chest and pressed down hard; one part of her sagged with relief that someone was coming, while another part couldn't suppress a creeping unease.

...That was strange. As a rule, did pressing the call button trigger a broadcast announcement? This loud, in the middle of the night — weren't they afraid of disturbing people's rest?

Was this some new policy hospitals had adopted?

The broadcast cut off.

In the silent room, for a moment there was nothing left but the trembling rise and fall of Mai Minghe's breath.

"Please be advised," — the broadcast blared to life again with the same tremendous volume, startling her all over again — "an entity impersonating a nurse will arrive in Room Three within five seconds. Commencing countdown: five — four — three —"

Mai Minghe went blank.

She must be going deaf and losing her mind — surely she had misheard, and the broadcast hadn't actually said "an entity impersonating a nurse"?

The patient in the next bed started laughing again — that chopped, segmented giggle.

"What the broadcast just said..."

She hadn't even finished her question when — bang — the ward door was slammed into the wall with a tremendous crash, the sound slamming against her chest and setting a deep, dull ache echoing through it.

The door flew open and white light from the corridor poured in; silhouetted in that light stood a thin, elongated shadow, impossibly tall, its head cut off by the door frame.

The shadow torqued its right shoulder, stepped forward with its right foot — as though the joints of its limbs were misaligned and stiff — and lurched crookedly through the doorway one step, head still left outside.

That was not a nurse.

The thought fed another surge of pain radiating outward from the left side of her chest, her entire left arm feeling as though someone had seized the tendons and was wrenching them out — and quickly, she realized she couldn't breathe.

"Oh? This is what turned up?"

The patient in the next bed laughed in that contracting, pulsing way, while the snow-white feet beyond the curtain remained perfectly motionless.

"Can't say you're unlucky — what answered your call wasn't a Resident. But can't say you're lucky either... because right at this particular moment, you've gone and had a heart attack, so you're not going to make it regardless."

The shadow twisted its left shoulder, stepped forward with its left foot, and its head swayed and scraped along the wall as it entered; body tilted at an angle, it took another step toward Bed 3.

From somewhere far down the corridor beyond the open door, someone roared in fury: "Who's closest? ...Get to Room Three, now! Don't let the one who pressed the button get away — how dare they steal from us!"

...What was happening?

Would she survive today?

The shadow had the light behind it, and no matter how much Mai Minghe squinted, she couldn't make out its features. It walked with the same arm and leg moving together, and yet despite what looked like only two or three steps, it had already reached the foot of the bed, boxing her in between the two beds.

She wanted to ask who it was, but she couldn't speak anymore.

Someone was sprinting down the corridor toward them — the thudding footsteps growing louder and louder, until she could almost feel the floor shaking — yet the shadow paid no heed to the commotion outside and swayed steadily closer, looming into her field of vision.

Was this... a person? she wondered in a dim, muddled way, on the edge of death. It couldn't be, could it?

Before she had even understood what was happening, this life of hers was about to reach its end.

The shadow slowly bent down toward her.

Even as her consciousness blurred and faded, Mai Minghe finally saw clearly the first face she had encountered since entering this hospital.

Beneath a wild tangle of dark hair, rising from the neck, was an oval shape — smooth and hard, a mirror — and below the mirror, nothing but darkness.

It was not a person wearing a mirror as a mask.

Where a face should have been, there was not the slightest contour of feature or bone — only a mirror in its place, grown out of the surrounding flesh, aimed squarely at Mai Minghe.

Her own aged, withered face stared back at her from the mirror's surface, and in that moment, what seemed to be bending down toward her was Mai Minghe herself.

Was she in the middle of a dream? A mirror for a face, a heart attack... it was all a dream, surely.

And yet, even on the verge of death, she had managed to see something this... remarkable.

Dream or reality, this was the first time in her life she had ever glimpsed something beyond the ordinary — and it would be the last.

Mai Minghe's face made no expression, but the old face in the mirror smiled faintly — the way a person smiles when they have come to the end of their options, when there is nothing left to do but smile.

The reflection opened its mouth, lips parting and closing, speaking soundlessly to the Mai Minghe on the other side of the glass.

If I could live my life once more...

I would ride the carousel to my heart's content,

I would go everywhere, try everything,

...I would pick more Daisies.

Mai Minghe couldn't move at all — whether her will had been suspended, or whether her aged, exhausted heart was simply too tired to be roused, and was already drifting toward sleep.

The moving lips in the mirror grew harder and harder to make out, blurring into illegibility; the shadow continued its slow advance, and finally swallowed her whole.

...If you were given the chance to do it all over again, what would you do to make this new life worth living?

The wild, coarse black hair pressed against Mai Minghe's forehead; she was steeped in thick darkness and could see nothing. Two arms — grotesquely long — wound around her body, coil

after coil, holding her fast, pulling tighter and tighter, as though to snap every bone inside her one by one —

"Let go of me —"

On the verge of having the breath cut from her chest, Mai Minghe finally struggled, and shoved with both hands — but instead of the resistance she expected, her hands met nothing.

She hurried to steady herself and scrambled up from the floor, only to find the space before her completely empty. The shadow had vanished.

Wait...

With a delayed jolt, Mai Minghe became aware of something.

She had just leapt to her feet — easily, cleanly, without the slightest effort.

Mai Minghe raised a hand and pressed it to her chest; the pain was as though it had never existed. Deep in her chest, a steady, familiar rhythm beat on.

Her hand... seemed somehow different.

Mai Minghe held up both hands and found that the skin was full and smooth, the nails translucent and healthy, not a single fold of extra skin in sight. She looked down and stared blankly at her own legs below the hem of her sleep trousers — even and firm, clean and strong.

She must have lost her mind.

Youth — so this was what it felt like. An illusion so sweet, so fierce, so swelling and brimming-full that it left a person at a loss.

For a moment she forgot everything else, and ran her hands desperately over herself: fingers plunging into thick, abundant hair; arms and thighs solid with muscle she hadn't felt in decades; her back straightened, her height seemed to rise — Mai Minghe let out a short, breathless laugh, her voice trembling.

A voice she hadn't heard in at least decades — young and clear and bright — flowed out into the cold air of the hospital ward.

From somewhere on the far side of decay and darkness and ash, she had been released — she didn't know how — and had been born into the world a second time. No — wait, was any of this real?

"In here!"

A sharp shout rang out from the doorway, and Mai Minghe startled, snapping her head up.

Her vision was no longer blurred and gray — even in the dim light, she saw clearly: a man had burst in through the door, his face tight with wariness.

"There's a woman in here, but no sign of the Artifact."

The man fixed his eyes on Mai Minghe and called back to his companions, then turned on her: "Which House Faction are you with? You've got the item, haven't you? You actually dared to intercept an Artifact that Mr. Wellesley requested?"

"What?" Mai Minghe asked blankly, her head crammed so full of bewildered, tangled confusion that his gibberish of a question had to seep through the gaps before even a fragment of it reached her brain.

The man had been about to step inside when his eyes suddenly swept to something beside her, and he stopped dead.

"Get in here, all of you," he shouted back toward the door. "There's a Resident in Room Three!"

A Resident? What was he talking about?

From that brief glance just now, it seemed like something was in the room — not far from him at all.

Mai Minghe turned his gaze in a daze, only to find that the originally empty Bed No. 3 beside her had its curtain drawn — he had no idea when that had happened.

The curtain wasn't pulled all the way shut, leaving exposed a pair of feet so pale white they looked as though they'd been dusted with powder; the toes were canted outward, left and right, frozen still, not moving a hair.

...Huh? Wasn't he just on the bed next to her?

When had he moved over to Bed No. 3?

"Calling you 'old lady' doesn't quite fit anymore," the patient behind the curtain said with a laugh. "I should be calling you 'young miss' now. Young miss, that thing you just picked up — it's quite a rare find. How about letting me take a look?"

I'm boarding a flight today, which means the pressure to update is on — I'll have to type away on the plane. Here's hoping the person next to me isn't one of those screen-peekers again. There was this one time I was writing an apocalypse story on a flight, and the guy in the seat beside me — then the guy in the seat beside him — suddenly grew five centimeters of neck, craning it over like a heron, and twisted his head around to ask me: "You writing a novel? What's it about?"

Makes you wonder if nearsightedness just isn't widespread enough these days.

(Why am I always on planes, always traveling far from home — truly an unsolvable mystery...)

Chapter 4: Mai Minghe Seizes Her Second Life

By any reasonable measure, the real threat should have been the three to five hostile, broad-shouldered strangers who'd just poured in through the doorway — right?

No matter how you looked at it, they were far more dangerous than some patient lying in a hospital bed.

And yet, somehow, Mai Minghe couldn't tear her eyes away from the pair of white feet peeking out from behind the curtain. Her heartbeat thundered in her ears like a crack of lightning, her palms cold and slick with sweat — and she hadn't spared so much as a single glance at the strangers.

She was wedged between the patient in bed 03 and bed 02, the nightstand and the wall pressing at her back. The strangers blocked the only way out ahead of her. There was nowhere to go.

She stole another look at the patient in the neighboring bed.

Compared to a moment ago, those feet looked somehow different — she couldn't say exactly how — but the sight of them now triggered something raw and instinctive, something biological: a revulsion so complete she nearly wanted to open her mouth and retch up everything she'd seen, every breath of air that had touched those feet, along with everything inside her.

She glanced up again, and the strangers seemed to share the feeling. For all their bluster when they'd charged in, their eyes were now drifting blankly somewhere above the bed — not one of them willing to look down at the feet lying there. At first glance, they looked for all the world like a group of blind men who'd just had their sunglasses yanked off simultaneously.

Mai Minghe wiped her nose.

Maybe the fear and tension had grown so overwhelming that her nervous system was desperate for release. Maybe the intoxicating surge of reclaimed youth carried a wild, heady magic that even terror couldn't fully extinguish. Or maybe it was simply that the people across from her looked utterly ridiculous — whatever the reason, she suddenly couldn't hold it in anymore. She burst out laughing.

"How did you do it?"

She reined in the laughter, not wanting those people to think she belonged in a psychiatric ward. She turned to the patient in the neighboring bed and said, "I don't know what it is, but one look at you and my guts start turning. You should moonlight here at the hospital — as a stomach pump."

The red-haired man across the room, who seemed to be in charge, said nothing, but his expression communicated his assessment of Mai Minghe in full — not quite right in the head.

"Miss,"

The male voice from behind the curtain was like a bag of rocks wrapped in thick, clinging phlegm — indescribably uncomfortable to hear. "This is your first time in the Nest, isn't it?"

Since a moment ago, Mai Minghe had been collecting unfamiliar terms one after another: a figure disguised as a nurse, Hunters, Artifacts... and now, a new addition — the Nest.

"This isn't a hospital?" Mai Minghe asked.

It was a question, but in her heart the answer was already perfectly clear: of course this wasn't a hospital.

She had ended up, somehow, in this place called the "Nest" — and that "somehow" seemed to have everything to do with her crashing into the television.

"Oh, but it is a hospital," the patient behind the curtain replied, in a tone that was almost warm. "A hospital inside the Nest is still a hospital."

Mai Minghe stalled for time, thinking aloud as she spoke: "You say this is the Nest, but you don't look much like a hen to me."

A sound escaped from the red-haired man's nose — something he'd tried and failed to suppress — and he covered it with a cough.

"Doesn't even know what the Nest is," someone by the door muttered to a companion, voice low. "Really is their first time in. No wonder they're still in their pajamas."

"But if it's their first time," another murmured, "how could they possibly have grabbed an Artifact?"

"Wait and see," the red-haired man instructed. "Stay ready. If she can't hold on, we'll have to take it from the Resident."

As they spoke, they treated Mai Minghe as though she barely existed — or rather, as though she were something that was about to stop existing.

In the span of a minute or two, so much had happened that she could barely make sense of it. All she could do now was hold on tight to two things.

One: she had entered the Nest, and her youth had been restored. Two: the thing that had restored her youth appeared to be what both sides were after.

Even without knowing anything else, she knew she was like a child wandering through a night market with a fortune stuffed in her pockets — and that was not a good position to be in.

Behind the curtain, silence. Two bluish-white bare feet rested with their toes hooked over the footrail of the bed.

"What is it you want?" Mai Minghe asked the curtain, eyes fixed on those feet, knowing the answer full well. "How about this — you tell me what's going on, and I'll give you whatever you need. Nice and civil. Much better for everyone."

The patient behind the curtain considered for two seconds.

"Feel around on your body," his voice had calmed somewhat — less unpleasant to hear than before, though still offering no explanation. "You should be able to feel something. Take it off and give it to me."

Mai Minghe reached inside her pajamas and felt along her lower back and abdomen — the moment her fingers made contact, she flinched.

Something faintly raised against the skin, ice-cold, like strips of ribbon or binding — coiled around her torso in layer upon layer, so that reaching in felt for all the world like running her hand along a massive snake wound tight around her body.

Right — that black, shadowy arm from before had been doing exactly that, wrapping around her in coil after coil.

"Found it," the patient in the next bed hissed suddenly, phlegm churning wetly in his throat. "Give it to me."

Mai Minghe traced the edge of the "snake-band," and it seemed almost reluctant to part from her skin — she had to press with real effort before she could work a fingertip between the band and her body.

"Alright, alright, I've got it, I'm getting it." It could indeed be removed — one lift of her hand, and she'd already pulled the "snake-band" up a little.

She remembered something else she wanted to ask.

"I had a heart attack earlier, and it stopped when this thing arrived. If I take it off, will the attack start again?"

"Sharp mind for someone your age. I don't think so. What it reversed was aging, not disease — the illness disappeared as a side effect, and it won't necessarily return along with the aging. "

The patient behind the curtain's voice was thick and syrupy. "Of course, I could be wrong. But besides optimism, you have no other choice. Now take it off."

As he said, she had no other choice.

"Lucky for me, I've always been an optimist." Mai Minghe exhaled and began at her lower abdomen, working the "snake-band" loose inch by inch, following its coils all the way around to her back, peeling it free from her body.

The tail of the jet-black "snake-band" slipped softly out from her pajamas and hung dangling in the air, swaying gently back and forth as though it were alive.

"Wait — don't give it to them," the red-haired man suddenly barked, lunging a step forward, both arms thrown wide. "Give it to me. If it comes for me, it'll leave you alone!"

He'd used the pronoun "it"?

The thought flickered through Mai Minghe's mind and was gone — no time to dwell on it. She had already recognized a lifeline: in this razor-thin sliver of an opening, she might be able to escape the ward alive. She seized the moment and called out to the red-haired man: "Catch!"

Then she swung her arm up, drew the shadow from behind her, and flung it toward his outstretched hands.

It might have been her imagination, but for one fleeting instant Mai Minghe could have sworn the patient behind the curtain in the neighboring bed had also been drawn away — just for a heartbeat.

Smack — the shadow dropped into the red-haired man's hands, and in the same instant Mai Minghe had already seized her chance: she threw herself over bed 2, rolling across the mattress and dropping down on the far side. A young person's body was so strong, so quick, so perfectly

balanced — the movement flowing and effortless, so utterly exhilarating that for one brief moment she almost forgot she was running for her life.

The shadow sat soft and yielding between his palms, ringed by a circle of faces staring fixedly down at it.

"A pillow?"

The red-haired man blinked when he saw what it was, then hurled the pillow — the one Mai Minghe had snatched from bed 2 — onto the floor and snapped, "Do you have a death wish? You want to die at a Resident's hands?"

Mai Minghe had no time to answer, for she'd only just found her footing when she turned and saw that the patient had followed — the curtain around bed 2 had been drawn shut.

But not fully.

The curtain seemed to have been pulled a little wider; at some point, a pair of calves had slipped out from beneath it, both knees pressed tightly together, bent over the edge of the bed and hanging down.

The patient lay flat on his back, only his legs dangling free — in itself, unremarkable. What was not unremarkable was that those bare feet, bluish-white and bloodless, planted squarely on the floor, had rotated at the ankle to face Mai Minghe directly.

It was too much like an absurd dream. If she'd woken up in a hospital bed the very next moment, she would not have been surprised.

"Get back,"

The red-haired man's face was taut. He and the others behind him retreated from the front of bed 2.

Even the air seemed to gradually tighten, to thin — as though they were wild creatures long accustomed to haunting this place, and had sensed the danger a step ahead of Mai Minghe, who understood nothing.

She thought for a moment, then called over to the patient in the neighboring bed: "Did you come into the hospital for a broken ankle?"

As she spoke, she became vaguely aware of a sensation at her waist, like something pulling taut and stretching.

"Or... you really aren't human?" She shouted toward the red-haired man: "Hey, kid — what is it if it's not human? Is it actually a chicken?"

Everything was so impossible that she'd somehow gone past the point of being shocked — she just wanted to understand what was happening. After all, nobody can afford to be startled too many times in a row.

The red-haired man didn't answer her.

He and the others behind him were all staring at the dangling calves and the floor beside bed 2, as if Mai Minghe had already been erased from the situation — she just hadn't been informed yet.

The curtain rustled with a dry shhhh; someone was slowly pulling it open.

Mai Minghe did not want to see what lay behind it — nothing good could be waiting.

She dropped her gaze immediately. When her eyes fell on the pair of feet in front of her, she noticed that the neighboring patient's left foot had stepped forward at some point — she had no idea when.

She herself hadn't moved at all, and yet her own left foot had also stepped forward.

Like two old acquaintances who had just found each other, walking toward one another across the distance.

No wonder her waist had felt like it was being stretched taut...

Strange — why had she taken a step just from seeing the other pair of feet, her own foot moving beyond her control, mirroring the other's motion — no, this wasn't the time for wondering.

Even with her head bowed, she could sense in her peripheral vision that the curtain had been drawn fully open.

Lying on bed 2 beside her, shrouded in dimness, was a long, dark human silhouette.

Mai Minghe drew a long, deep breath.

If this had been the old Mai Minghe, she might have kept the peace, put self-preservation first, and handed the "snake-band" over. The first time you live your life, you're always afraid that one wrong move will lead to irreversible, unbearable consequences — that you'll ruin everything you have.

Then you grow old, and you find that the decades you've lived have been filled with nothing but loneliness, regret, and wishes that have long since expired — and it hasn't been so wonderful after all. Opportunities stop coming. Your strength runs out.

This "snake-band" could be the last adventure of her eighty-six years of living. But it could also be the very first choice of the life still ahead of her.

She would try.

Mai Minghe knew that pressing the call button would produce no sound to break the dead silence in the room.

"Ward 3, Bed 01 calling for a nurse!"

A woman's voice — loud, nearly piercing — exploded without warning from the intercom and shattered the stillness of the room.

Before anyone had time to react, Mai Minghe pressed the call button again, and again, and again.

The intercom seemed to go into a frenzy, its announcements growing more urgent one after another as they blared into the corridor: "Figure disguised as a nurse arriving at the ward in five seconds — second figure disguised as a nurse, arriving — third figure disguised as a nur— fourth figure disguised as a nurse, arriving at the ward in five seconds!"

Somewhere in the midst of the escalating announcements, Mai Minghe thought she dimly heard the red-haired man shout "Are you insane?!" — and then came a rapid flurry of footsteps retreating, as though the group, seeing things had gone badly wrong, bolted from the ward ahead of everyone else.

She never once lifted her head.

Mai Minghe sensed the dark shape beside her rising, joint by joint: thighs lifting off the mattress, hips suspended halfway in the air, while the upper body still lay flat on the bed.

In the dim residual light, that head turned toward Mai Minghe, and spoke in a voice that bore no resemblance whatsoever to a human being's: "For an old lady, you've got some real nerve."

At that very moment, something heavy was suddenly hurled across the room and crashed down hard between her and the patient in the next bed — a thunderous, muffled boom — the bedside cabinet shattered into pieces on impact. The shadow tumbled to the floor, and when it

scrambled upright against the wall, it turned out to be the red-haired man; finding himself wedged squarely between the patient and Mai Minghe, he cursed under his breath.

Mai Minghe didn't look at him.

She kept her eyes fixed on the ward doorway and said quietly, "Take a closer look. I'm not an old lady anymore."

Not now. Not tomorrow either.

She was going to claim her second life — truly claim it, on her own terms.

By the time you're reading this chapter, I should be on the plane — this one was set to send on a timer. Having chapters in reserve means having confidence! You can actually schedule posts! Back when I was writing the apocalypse story, it was feast and famine all the way!

Unfortunately, my stockpile, generous estimate, will only last a little over a week... Hopefully I can hammer out at least one chapter on the flight, so once I land I can start releasing extras to pay off my debt.

Speaking of debt — dear readers, aren't you all moving a little too fast? The Artifact Report was barely just born, and you're already stuffing in red envelopes. What if the kid grows up into a hunchback of Notre Dame situation? Isn't it a bit early?

It feels like every time I blink, I owe a little more...

Oh lord, boarding time is almost here — the line at the gate is already stretching forever, and here I am sitting cross-legged typing away. Just wait until I've landed, and we'll sit down and properly count up exactly how much more I owe.

So what if I'm a pack mule? I'm a century-old establishment! I gather wealth with my donkey tail!

Chapter 5 — Sydney Ginn, the Hunter Hounded by a Stalker

Sydney Ginn stood before her own funeral portrait, ears buzzing.

A funeral wreath was wedged right in her doorway. The moment the door swung open, there it was: her own face, smiling and blurred, staring back at her. The black-and-white portrait had been crookedly nailed to the wreath's center, and across it, a single line of vicious red letters — "BITCH" — slashed her smile in two.

It was the first time she had ever seen, in real life, the kind of wreath used at Asian funerals. Even as fury and outrage surged through her, some small corner of Sydney's mind marveled at how authentic it looked — exactly like the ones on television — and wondered absently where on earth he'd had it made.

As for who had left it there, she didn't even need to wonder. She already knew.

Sydney kicked the wreath aside, slammed the door, and headed for the elevator, pulling out her phone as she walked.

"Get up here right now. Come see what's been left outside my door."

She had lived in this building for three years, and this was the first time she had ever raised her voice at the building manager with such force. She'd always been too uneasy to be rude before.

"What gives you the right to charge such astronomical rent and management fees? This is supposed to be the most prestigious address in Blackmoor City? Your security people — did you borrow them as mummies from the national museum next door? Are they all dead? I told you people, there's been a stalker following me lately. Why wasn't security tightened? How did he even get to my front door?"

When Sydney had first moved into this building, she'd been racked with self-consciousness.

By any normal trajectory, someone like her — born into an ordinary immigrant family, no impressive credentials, a perfectly unremarkable job — should never have cleared the application process, no matter how many lifetimes she spent saving up for rent. This building was a century-old landmark, officially listed as a historic site, and it simply wasn't meant for people like her.

The layered barriers of class and social networks made it nearly impossible even for newly minted tech millionaires to lease a unit here, let alone buy one.

Not long after she moved in, she encountered a woman in the elevator — gracious, warm, striking up a friendly conversation — and Sydney had felt a quiet little glow of pleasure. Then, just before the elevator reached the lobby, the woman smiled and asked, "Which household are you working for? We happen to be interviewing at the moment."

It took several seconds before Sydney understood: the woman had taken her for a maid.

Their clothes were not so different, yet somehow, others could tell at a single glance that she did not belong to this world. The building manager on the phone was no exception.

"Miss Ginn," he said,

in a tone of near-sympathetic condescension, "I'm truly sorry about this. But you may not be aware — our policy is to avoid interfering in our residents' personal affairs as much as possible. That has always been our practice here.

"The people our residents generally associate with are all respectable, well-known individuals; something like this is entirely unprecedented. According to security, the man said he wanted to give you a surprise, and he was carrying flowers, so we had no way of knowing that you and your boyfriend might have had some kind of romantic dispute..."

"It isn't a romantic dispute — it's stalking and harassment!" Sydney snapped, too furious to even register the implication buried in the word "respectable." "And he's not my boyfriend. What he was carrying was a funeral wreath!"

The man had dated her a few times, had visited the apartment before, and had been let in with her permission. It was only after he saw her home and her life that he began pressing her constantly for money and gifts. When she finally decided to cut off contact, she had never expected her simple refusal to ignite such savage, uncontrolled hatred.

She had never imagined that the word "no" could unleash something so fierce.

"Of course, of course — I'll have someone remove the wreath immediately. Security isn't like you; they wouldn't know that kind of flower arrangement, so I do hope you'll understand. That said, Miss Ginn," the manager continued, "I'd like to ask you to try to have a calm conversation with him and let things settle down. After all, our residents here tend to prefer a quiet, low-profile environment, and this sort of disturbance is rather unwelcome..."

"So I'm the one who should apologize?"

Sydney was so furious she couldn't make out another word the manager said. She ended the call and gave the elevator door a solid kick.

When she left the building, she waved off the doorman's offer to hail a cab and drifted, distracted, out into the mid-morning blaze of Blackmoor City's streets.

She could file a police report, apply for a restraining order — but neither was a sure thing.

There was every chance the police wouldn't act until after she'd already become a victim. A restraining order might deter a rational person; against someone unhinged, it was worth next to nothing.

For most women, the options amounted to reporting it, staying vigilant, fleeing, and praying. But what that Anthony didn't know was that Sydney's real options extended far beyond any of that.

She walked for a while, made up her mind, and flagged down a taxi.

The timing worked out perfectly: by the time she reached the Buluan district, "Between the Glare" had just unlocked its doors.

The bar's entrance was tucked behind a short flight of stairs that dropped from the sidewalk into the ground, invisible to anyone walking past. As far as Sydney could remember, the sign light had never once been on — which meant, she supposed, it hardly mattered whether anyone on the street could see it.

She pushed open the faded wooden door, and to the dry, creaking protest of ungreased hinges — eek, eek — she stepped into a cramped and shadowy basement.

In the murk, chairs sat upside-down on tabletops, and cardboard boxes were stacked in the booth seats. The air was stale and cool, drifting with dust, the smell of old liquor, and a faint trace of vomit.

"You're here early."

The back door swung open and a man peered in, then ambled behind the bar. He had the face of a Shar-Pei — eyebrows and eyes all drooping — but like a dog, he somehow managed to look friendly.

He switched on the TV for Sydney and jerked his chin toward the bar. "Have a seat. I'm still tidying up."

The TV mounted in the corner above the bar flickered to life with the midday news. At the Central Island Zoo in Blackmoor City, a baby elephant had just been born — and the female anchor was beaming.

"Anything come up?" Sydney settled onto a stool and asked. "I'm planning to head out in the next day or two."

"There's a crew that's short a person — looking to hire an experienced Hunter with no House Faction ties. I thought of you right away."

The Shar-Pei face stayed low behind the bar; he seemed to be on his knees scrubbing at a cabinet door, the cloth rasping steadily as he spoke: "Not much pay — three thousand. They head out next week. And naturally, whatever comes out of it won't be your business."

A few years ago, three thousand dollars would have lit her eyes up like flashlights. These days, it wasn't nearly enough to make the trouble worth her while.

"I can't work with a group right now — I've got something personal this trip. Any other contracts?"

"Then there's nothing—"

He had barely started the sentence when the TV suddenly let out a sharp, urgent da-da-da-ding of breaking-news music. Sydney glanced up at the screen.

"We have just learned," the anchor announced, her expression composed and grave, "that Wellesley, founder, major shareholder, and CEO of the Qunmu Consortium, was found dead this morning at his Upper District estate. He was fifty-nine years old. The cause of death is believed to be sudden cardiac arrest. Police have launched an investigation... Mr. Wellesley also served as a state legislator and prominent philanthropist..."

Sydney blinked. "He's dead?"

The Shar-Pei face lifted above the bar and studied the screen. "You knew him?"

"Not directly. But I have a client who'd been in contact with him. I thought there might be a deal in it someday." Sydney said it, then let the dead richest man in Blackmoor City go just as quickly. "No other jobs at all?"

"You could wait a few more days — something might turn up." The bartender went back to polishing the beer taps. "When are you thinking of going?"

Sydney took out her phone, meaning to check the time, and found over twenty text messages waiting — all from an unfamiliar number. She didn't even have to open them. Through the preview alone, she could see it all: desperate pleading, filth, curses, threats.

She had already blocked four or five numbers. It hadn't slowed him down in the slightest.

"I'm going tonight. No contract, that's fine." She put the phone away, and her voice went flat. "There's a problem I've got to deal with — nothing huge, just deeply unpleasant. I need to go in and bring something back. That's the only way to sort it out."

The bartender nodded. "Same drink as usual? Or are you taking it home?"

"Yes," she said — and just the mention of it, Sydney was fairly sure, had drained the color from her face. "I didn't bring a container. Just pour it into whatever plastic bottles you have."

The moment she thought about that drink, her stomach began to revolt even before a single drop had touched her lips — her guts twisting and writhing as though they desperately wanted to heave themselves out of her body in advance.

No matter how many times she went through it, Sydney could not make herself tolerate alcohol. She had been forcing it down for years now, and she was beginning to feel like one of Pavlov's dogs. Sometimes just catching a whiff of booze on a stranger was enough to make her legs go weak and her head swim with nausea.

"Your mix is the only one that gives me the effect I need. When I've tried other things, my mind goes numb all right, but my limbs turn heavy and dead, and the moment I close my eyes I'm out cold. That's not blunting the edge — that's gambling with my life."

The bartender's expression flickered with a brief smile. "Still not the most efficient method, though. I'll keep an eye out — see if something pharmaceutical turns up."

If she could take a single pill and get the same result, that would be ideal. Until that day came, she had no choice but to steel herself and drink it down.

If she still wanted to keep living the way she lived.

When night fell, Sydney changed into running shoes and athletic wear, and pulled her hair up into a tight bun.

She packed her usual gear into a bag — not an ordinary backpack, but the kind of half-body expedition pack hikers used, big enough to swallow a sleeping bag whole.

Though she didn't intend to stay long, Sydney wasn't about to take chances: she brought a hunting knife, a compact ladies' pistol, and a can of bear spray.

What a pity that real-world laws tied her hands — none of these could be used on a stalker directly. She had to go the long way around.

The clock on her phone ticked over to 9:43 PM.

Messages kept flooding in one after another, each from a different number, stacking up at the bottom of her screen without a single one swiped open. The unread count had already climbed to 129.

She had figured it out a few hours ago: the stalker had posted her number across dozens of yellow websites. The messages that poured in after that were not only revolting — there were too many numbers to ever finish blocking.

She simply shoved the phone to the bottom of her pack. Out of sight, out of mind.

Night had stained the entire floor-to-ceiling window black. She sat on the floor before it, suspended in midair, floating between the skyscrapers of Blackmoor City and its countless scattered lights.

The neon glow, brilliant as scattered diamonds, would blaze on through the small hours and into the break of dawn. The largest, most luminous metropolis in the world never slept, never stilled.

The drink the bartender had prepared for her — she forced it down sip by grimacing sip until it was gone. Soon her consciousness began to burn light and loose, her blood bubbling and churning in her veins; even in the silence of her apartment, she seemed to hear a low hum from somewhere far away.

The primal terror forged by a million years of evolution was not something that repetition could tame or overcome.

Without flooding herself with alcohol — without dulling her mind into a soft, blurred haze — Sydney couldn't even summon the will to walk to the edge of her own balcony. She had always had a crippling fear of heights; at amusement parks, she wouldn't set foot on a roller coaster.

She gripped the balcony railing, trembling, drew a breath, and stepped up onto the chair she'd placed there.

The expedition pack dragged heavy on her shoulders, and as she braced herself and swung up to sit on the railing, it snagged and scraped against the metal. The lurch nearly sent her heart and stomach shooting up her throat together; it took everything she had to steady her breathing, and her palms were slick with cold sweat.

Even drunk, she didn't dare look down. She fixed her gaze on the city skyline and held it there.

In the distance, rivers of headlights flowed between the buildings, blurring into bright smears of color through a veil of drizzle. The fine, cold rain slanted down in dense needles against her skin, and Sydney felt a creeping worry that it might shock her sober and strip away the blessed numbness she'd worked so hard to earn.

...Time to go.

She sat on the railing with her back to Blackmoor City's neon glow, watching her own reflection in the glass door and the dim living room beyond it.

"I'll be back before you know it," Sydney Ginn murmured to the apartment. "Wait for me."

She closed her eyes, leaned back, and fell — straight down into the cool early-November night.

*I'm back, everyone, and the very first thing I did was eat until I couldn't see straight — god, I felt like someone just let out of prison, eyes practically bloodshot from the sheer joy of it — wait, no, that's nonsense, the very first thing I did was sit down and hammer out chapters, I swear!

Hehehe, I dropped in four chapters and already swapped away from Mai Minghe — sorry about that. It's just that introducing the worldbuilding requires multiple perspectives, and leaving readers confused for too long isn't great either. I won't be switching POVs that often going forward.

I should've given you a heads-up at the end of the last chapter, but I forgot... A donkey's memory is bad enough, but mine's even worse — you all have hippocampi, I've got a hippdon'tcampus. Pirated readers are out of luck, but paying readers can definitely forgive me (...right?).

I've always thought one of the biggest reasons western fantasy is hard to get into is the names... so I gave all the Western characters in this story names that Chinese readers can actually remember. Sydney Ginn, for example — if I'd called her "Xini Jie," who on earth would know who

that is, am I right? I picked up this trick back when I was writing Milady, and it works great — four-point-eight stars on the reviews.

*Why am I sticking this rambling nonsense after the actual chapter, you ask? Because I ran out of space in the author's note and I simply couldn't bear to not ramble. Besides, this chapter's free, so you can't accuse me of padding the word count.

Let me see which of you impatient little grandmas has come to collect a debt from me this time...

All right — I gloriously owe Tianxia one bonus chapter (how does it always end up as less free time for me?), I owe Mofashi Huiyu one big fat bouncing baby of a bonus chapter (didn't I just say stop being so eager?! I genuinely feel bad!), and I owe Yingyou one big fat baby too (I'd be better off staking out the maternity ward at People's Hospital to snag one — faster that way)... What are you all doing? You're already here, you didn't have to bring gifts (。

Thank you Tangmian Ye, Shi Zhi Youling, Please Call Me Ah Qi, and o Jin o — (should I just pool together one baby for the four of you? Take it home, cut it into four pieces, and share — my stockpile of saved chapters is already trembling with cold just thinking about it)

Thank you Peng Xiaoxi, Pupu Haha, Mi Miemie, Mo Yuan Reads As Black Bird, Flying Sky Bandit, Deyun Fujin, Kafka, A Shi qwq, San Xi Yi, Yuki Akinana, Qingqing Jiu, Me and Honeydew Melon Are Sworn Enemies (Melon!), Jianglu Jing Lufu, and Today I Had a Roasted Sweet Potato — why are you all in such a rush, grandmas? Can't we just let this relationship of ours flow like a gentle stream? What if it turns out not to be good? I'm already second-guessing myself.

Counting the grandmas from before, how many bonus chapters do I owe now? Five?

...Five???????

.....?????????

"Time flows ever onward" — and by "that which flows away," do you mean my stockpile of saved chapters?!

Chapter 6: Sydney Ginn's Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion

She had lost count of how many times she'd fallen from a great height.

Sooner or later, caught between the combined forces of alcohol and the fall, her heart would slam against her sternum one final time — and then Sydney Ginn would cease to exist.

But at least this time, she was still alive; even if her heart was pumping blood so wildly that it crashed through her skull in waves, sending her reeling with dizziness.

The heat of the alcohol broke through her pores as sweat, the burning-needle sensation on her back fading into a cool, clammy dampness.

Sydney Ginn might never stop fearing the fall — but after so many jumps, she had at least learned to hold back the screams when she landed. There was only her breathing now, ragged and heavy, almost like sobbing; fear was a centipede, crawling and scratching at her chest and throat.

She had landed in the same old place again.

The room carried the smell of old dust, the kind that brought to mind cardboard boxes left out for years. It was dim and cool and dark, but the darkness wasn't thick — more like a curtain drawn halfway, the kind you could push aside with one hand and find someone hiding behind it.

Sydney Ginn didn't move.

The alcohol swelled through her like a tide born inside her body, still rocking and pushing at her.

Someone up there must have been watching over her — no matter what angle she jumped from, she always landed on her feet, like a cat blessed by heaven.

She crouched in place for a few seconds, then extended her right hand into the darkness, groping for the wall. Every time she landed, the alcohol made her unsteady on her feet, and she would brace herself against the wall to her right — if anyone shone a torch and looked carefully, they'd probably see the wallpaper gone shiny where the oils from her hand had soaked in, over and over.

Her hand had barely brushed something smooth and square and plastic when she yanked it back as if shocked, cursing under her breath, a fresh prickling of goosebumps erupting across her skin.

...You could never be too careful, she thought. Last time she was here, the light switch definitely hadn't been on this wall.

Thank god she hadn't pressed down on it — the switch had been just sitting there, practically begging to be flipped.

Sydney Ginn moved slowly to the corner and felt around until she found the tap in the same spot as always, then turned it on. She cupped her hands and drank several large mouthfuls; the tap let out two grinding squeaks as she turned it back, and then silence returned.

Unlike food, water inside the Nest was generally safe.

Sydney Ginn fished a squashed fried doughnut and a can of coffee out of her bag.

Before the jump: drown the fear in alcohol until it goes numb. After landing: use fried food and coffee to flush the alcohol out as much as possible — every single time Sydney Ginn entered the Nest, she had to go through the same ritual.

She leaned against the corner of the wall and forced herself to eat everything despite having no appetite whatsoever, then carefully packed the empty can and paper bag back into her rucksack.

Never leave personal belongings behind in the Nest — not even garbage. That was lesson one for any Hunter. When she'd first learned it, Sydney Ginn couldn't even remember anymore.

Across from the sink stood a locked storage cabinet.

She fumbled in the dark through several attempts before finally getting the key into the lock; from behind the silently swinging cabinet door, she felt around and pulled out a radio — cool and heavy, solid and square.

The hiss and crackle of static rose up out of the darkness and settled beside her; as she turned the dial searching for the frequency, the static gradually resolved into a man's voice.

"Welcome to Nest Radio 173," the man's voice said, low and unhurried, as though he were about to tell a story. "This is the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion. I am your host."

No name. Only "your host."

His — or perhaps its, since no human could survive living inside the Nest — entire identity seemed to exist only in relation to the radio station.

No matter when Sydney Ginn switched the radio on, the first words she ever heard were always "Welcome to Nest Radio 173" — as though the host were waiting at any moment, and a listener switching on the radio was the very thing that switched him on.

"Today is Monday, November 16th, 2026."

Time inside the Nest moved in step with the outside world — Sydney Ginn glanced at her phone and confirmed it.

On the phone screen, over a hundred ugly unread messages sat frozen in place; no signal, no new texts coming through.

"First, let's bring you the Nest news."

In the darkness, Sydney Ginn listened and waited for the coffee and food to kick in. This hideout should be known only to her — no need to worry about anyone barging in.

In a place like the Nest, where a single moment of distraction could be the difference between life and death, she was sitting perfectly still listening to the radio — when she thought about it, even she found it a little funny.

She was a solo Hunter, without the backing of any House Faction, and the Artifacts she'd managed to get her hands on in the past had all been low-grade junk. By rights, she had no room to be picky — she should take any Artifact she could get and sell whatever she found.

But this one radio — this, she would never sell to anyone. It was her lifeline.

"...We trust that all Residents who truly love the Nest will be absolutely delighted. A great threat to the Nest had barely begun to take root before it was swiftly extinguished through the combined efforts of all parties. We hope you will share this good news with your loved ones — assuming you haven't already served them for dinner."

Sydney Ginn listened with half her mind elsewhere. Honestly, she hadn't really followed it; she had no idea what "great threat" even referred to.

The broadcasts weren't made for humans. The host's audience was the Residents of the Nest, which meant that out of any ten sentences he spoke, eight of them went completely over her head.

As long as it seemed to have nothing to do with her, Sydney Ginn couldn't be bothered to think too hard about it; the curiosity she'd had when she first got the radio had evaporated completely after she'd nearly died once because of it.

She understood maybe half of what she heard, and she listened anyway.

"A Toyota vehicle with license plate MKA-388 has been parked outside the Buluan Community College Station branch of the public library for more than seven days. The vehicle's owner is requested to move it promptly, or the library will be adding your name to its list of grievances."

That license plate sounded like a genuine Blackmoor City plate... surely no Hunter had actually driven a car in here?

Left that long without moving — the owner was probably already dead.

The thought passed through her mind and left no mark.

Being an Artifact Hunter meant racing against the dark; the Hunters swallowed by those black waves sank into the depths of the Nest forever, and by now no one could even count how many there had been.

Sooner or later, she would sink too. She just didn't know yet what shape her grave would take when it appeared before her.

"...And now, traffic conditions and map information."

Sydney Ginn snapped to attention; the fog of alcohol cleared considerably in an instant. She quickly pulled out a pen and a fresh Blackmoor City tourist map, clamped her phone between her teeth for the faint glow of its screen, and spread the map out on the concrete floor.

"First," the host said, as if he too understood the importance of what followed, slowing his cadence: "Streets Five through One Ninety remain unchanged and can be accessed normally today."

She let out a long breath of relief.

Whether it was a good thing or a bad thing was hard to say, but the Nest seemed to have a life of its own, always shifting slowly, always mutating.

Before she'd gotten the radio, every time Sydney Ginn opened her passage and fell into the Nest, she had to steel herself mentally — even a location she'd explored a hundred times over, the next time you came back, you might still push open a door and step into a room you'd never seen before in your life.

The Nest resembled Blackmoor City's layout, but in a warped, subtly deformed way — as though the Nest were a skewed and distorted mirror image, twisted by light and shadow, something that did not belong to this world bleeding in through the uneven gaps and the dark between the cracks.

Was this the fracture lines of the universe? The legendary underworld? The delusions festering inside a madman's skull?

Sydney Ginn had come here more times than she could count and still had no answer.

She had listened to the broadcasts long enough to piece together a few rules of thumb.

"Construction work / renovation / refurbishment currently in progress" — that phrasing meant the area was actively changing.

"Attracting a large number of visitors / a recommended weekend outing destination" — never go anywhere near it, not even the surrounding areas; give it a wide berth in all directions.

"Remains unchanged, accessible as normal" — exactly as it sounded: as long as you already knew the terrain and had mapped out the risks, you could still trust what you'd learned the last time.

The thing Sydney Ginn needed to deal with her stalker was hidden on 99th Street, which happened to fall within the zone with no unusual changes; if everything went smoothly, the trip from her landing point to 99th Street would take just two days — she'd collect what she needed and be back in Blackmoor City.

Two days... she couldn't help letting out a short, self-deprecating laugh.

By straight-line distance, the two points were fifteen kilometers apart at most — but in the Nest, covering fifteen kilometers in two days was considered remarkably good going.

By the time the traffic and map report was finished, Sydney Ginn's map was covered in loops and circles of all sizes, along with annotations like "DANGER!!" and "go straight" and "there's a bus, but don't talk to the driver."

Based on the experience she had bought with her life, time and again, the broadcasts could be trusted.

If she ever decided to retire, this radio could probably fetch her at least a million dollars.

But Sydney Ginn knew she couldn't retire — even with a million waiting for her, she couldn't bear to give up being a Hunter. There were too many things in this world worth going after; her appetite was too vast, and the money she needed was far more than a million.

"He should be so lucky," Sydney Ginn muttered, growing more irritated the more she thought about it. "Some rat crawling out of whatever gutter — and I have to go bring back an Artifact just to deal with you..."

She put away the map and the pen, and was just about to reach for the radio on the floor — it was playing "Nest Top Hits No. 1," and today's entry wasn't actually that bad, something like howling wind tearing through a forest shot through with faint, piercing human shrieks — when the "music" abruptly stuttered and stopped.

Then again, with something like piercing human shrieks, who could ever tell which one was supposed to be the ending.

"What a soothing and melodious song," the host murmured. "I've just received a call from a listener, and I'll be inserting a brief special bulletin."

Sydney Ginn's breath caught.

A "special bulletin" — since she'd had the radio in her hands, she had only heard one twice.

The first time, a special bulletin had led her to a fixed, hidden, private hideout all to herself — the very small room she was sitting in right now.

She hadn't even known before then that a human being could bind themselves to a fixed location inside the Nest.

Every time Sydney Ginn had opened her passage and fallen into the Nest before that, she'd appeared where everyone else did — the public entry points: City Hall, the "Between the Backlight" garden, Saint Louis Hospital, and areas like those — surrounded by Hunters and Residents and god knows what else, she hadn't even dared to stay in one place long enough to finish a cup of coffee.

The second time, the Artifact she'd obtained through a special bulletin had bought her that apartment in Blackmoor City — the kind of place an ordinary person could never get close to in a lifetime. On top of the purchase price, the buyer had signed an open-ended contract: for as long as Sydney Ginn lived, she would always have the right to live there.

And now the third time had finally come.

For a moment, the only thing left in Sydney Ginn's world was the radio on the floor. She forgot to breathe. Every last bit of her attention condensed into a single hook, snagging tight on every word as it came through.

"...After entering through Door D of the Museum of Modern Art, take the elevator on the left down to the first basement level."

The host's voice poured slowly out of the radio, tracing the interior of the building in her mind like a blueprint. "Remember — you must take the first elevator on the left. If the doors of any other elevator open, do not get in. Do not look. Whatever happens, act as though you know nothing."

Although the radio's audience seemed to be Nest Residents, there were always these little details that made Sydney Ginn feel the host was giving instructions to her specifically — or rather, to whatever Hunters happened to be listening.

"'Candle Tears,' in the exhibition hall on the first basement level, is something you'll want to keep in mind. As far as I know, it became an Artifact not long ago... Some might say it is one of the most powerful Artifacts to have existed since the Nest came into being."

The host paused, as though he had sensed the rapid thudding of Sydney Ginn's heartbeat.

"To anyone who wants to go and investigate — take my advice. Human fate is as thin and frail as a worn cotton cloth. The world is full of floods — too many, too unpredictable — crashing forward without mercy. People can only be torn apart and swallowed up in the churning currents, flung by forces far greater than themselves toward a future they cannot see clearly.

"And Artifacts... are mountain torrents and tsunamis, are storms and towering waves. They are the genie that grants your wishes, and the deity that ignores your pleas..."

He trailed off there, as though what came next was too difficult to say, and stopped despite himself.

The darkened room fell silent for a moment; the host had no breath — Sydney Ginn had long since realized that.

In the room there were only four or five sets of breathing, including her own, rising and falling together in the dark.

"Dear listeners, that's all for today's broadcast. Please take care of yourselves — until next time."

Sydney Ginn stood frozen for a few seconds, then snatched up the radio and packed it away again. Groping until she found the door handle, she eased the door open a crack and slipped out.

The Museum of Modern Art lay in the direction she was already headed.

First go to the museum and take a look at the Artifact the broadcast mentioned, then head to Ninety-Ninth Street to get what she needed to deal with Anthony...

A day or two's delay was no big deal.

Sydney Ginn actually only has one chapter — there's nothing extra saved in the drafts.

I've seen people asking what Mai Minghe's English name is. Mai Minghe is ethnically Chinese, so her Chinese name is just Mai Minghe — but of course she has an English name too, and honestly it's one of my proudest creations, so lovely that I almost regret giving it to her: River Rye.

I really want to take it back for myself lol.

What's wrong with that — shouldn't a daughter pay a little tribute to her mother?

For minor supporting characters like that nuisance Anthony, I'm not going to bother giving them Chinese-style names. If readers can't remember them, so be it — coming up with names that sound good and distinctive is genuinely exhausting.

Typing on an iPad away from home is absolute misery, ugh — it's really affecting my output.

Now I want an e-ink tablet again lol.

Chapter 7 — Sydney Ginn: The Hunter's Life Is No Easy Thing

Night in Blackmoor City was night in the Nest.

Wind fell through the cracks between heaven and earth and tossed the hair across her forehead. If she squinted, peering out through the shadow of her own lashes, Sydney Ginn could almost lose track of whether she was in the Nest or in Blackmoor City.

An abandoned, deserted Blackmoor City — a city of warped shadows where every detail grew more unsettling the deeper you looked: at the intersection ahead, the green traffic light had gone dark and a purple one blinked in its place, on and off, on and off; the surface of the empty road was seized and released by that violet light, seized and released, seized and released.

Only sound was truly honest. She couldn't hear any car engines, any tires rolling over asphalt, any horns blaring. No conversation, no dogs barking, no livestreamer narrating into a selfie camera. At this moment, the only sound Sydney Ginn could hear was footsteps — one after another.

A soft "tap" — her left foot touching down. Before she could even lift her right foot, she heard another "tap."

The footsteps behind her had been following her for several minutes now.

Whoever it was didn't seem much like a Hunter. When Hunters crossed paths in the Nest, they kept their distance — wary, guarded, sizing each other up from afar. The constant threat of extreme danger kept every nerve stretched wire-tight; nobody wanted to stir up extra trouble.

Not a Hunter, then. Which meant it was a Resident.

Should she pretend she hadn't noticed?

Sydney opened her phone camera, held it flush against her chest, and tilted it just barely over her shoulder — a quick, inconspicuous snap.

She picked up her pace to open some distance, then darted a glance at the screen.

In the photo, a warped, grinning version of Sydney Ginn's own face was staring back at her.

The teeth were white and enormous, packed so densely they were nearly overflowing the mouth, the lips barely able to contain them all. The thing seemed to be resting its chin on

someone's shoulder, throwing up a "yeah" sign with its fingers.

Sydney recognized those shoulders in an instant. They were her own.

What rotten luck.

"Get lost!" Sydney snarled under her breath without turning around. The hunting knife already in her hand swept backward in a wide arc, trying to force the thing back a few steps. "Who do you think you're underestimating? You think I'm not long for this world?"

Not a sound from behind her. A few seconds of silence — and then she heard her own voice, letting out a low, soft "hee hee."

...So it wasn't going to leave on its own, then.

Rotten luck aside, her luck wasn't entirely bad — whatever had latched onto her wasn't especially dangerous.

This type of Resident was common in the Nest. They would fix on someone and twist their own face into a copy of that person's — though the result always came out slightly wrong. An extra eyeball in the right socket, or a single black hole standing in for both nostrils, or, as in this case, a mouth crammed with more teeth than could possibly fit.

They would trail behind their chosen target wearing that person's face, and while the effect was deeply, crawlingly unsettling, there was no immediate threat of harm.

It was only when the target met a violent death that one of these Residents would pounce — writhing against the corpse, sucking at it — and when it finally lifted its face, the transformation would be complete, indistinguishable from the original. Some people said they perhaps longed to return to the world of the living, which was why they wanted to disguise themselves as humans and slip back into Blackmoor City in someone else's place. That was just rumor, though; no need to take it as gospel.

In other words, they were the vultures of the desert, endlessly circling the skies above a dying animal.

This particular Resident had probably caught a whiff of the alcohol on Sydney's breath and noticed the faint unsteadiness still in her stride, and decided she wasn't going to last much longer.

Its technique wasn't up to par with its peers, either — a proper "vulture" could tail someone without the Hunter ever catching on; this one was stomping around like it had bricks for feet.

Still, harmless as it was, having that thing's face hovering perpetually over her shoulder was irritating enough on its own.

She cocked her ear and tried to gauge the distance behind her by the rhythm of the footsteps, weighing up whether she could create an opportunity to shake it loose — and then a thought crashed into her head without warning: Something's wrong.

Sydney's whole body jolted. She slammed to a stop, didn't wait to get a clear look at the ground ahead, and threw herself sideways off the path — her back struck the iron railing with a sharp clang.

That noise — who knew whether it would draw other Residents now...

But that wasn't what she needed to worry about right now. She had nearly fallen for the vulture Resident's trap.

"Sydney Ginn" was still standing just a step or two away, watching her. The lower half of its face was all smile and teeth. But the eyes were sinking deeper and deeper, growing blacker and blacker, until they looked like holes some child had jabbed into a lump of dough with their fingers.

Sydney did her best not to look at it, and swept her gaze instead over the ground she had almost stepped onto.

A hopscotch grid drawn in chalk stretched down the full length of the sidewalk — so long the far end was out of sight.

The chalk had faded, swallowed by the sickly amber of the streetlamps and the shadows cast by the roadside trees. If you weren't looking carefully, you'd never notice it was there.

The first row had four squares. The first three were blank; only the last one, at the edge, had anything written in it: "Right foot."

"Son of a bitch. It was waiting here for me all along."

Sydney wiped the cold sweat from her neck with her sleeve and swore quietly at the other version of herself. "No wonder your footsteps were so clear — you even made sure to step in the gaps between mine, just so I'd hear you..."

It had been deliberate.

It had wanted Sydney to focus all her attention behind her, to occupy her mind entirely with the question of how to shake off the vulture — and there were only so many ways to do that.

Whichever way she chose, she would have broken into a run and planted her foot straight into the chalk hopscotch grid.

And if she hadn't stepped into the square marked "Right foot" with her right foot — her problems would have gotten very large, very fast.

"November 17th, the Nest, Colorado Avenue. Hopscotch grid drawn in chalk has appeared here."

Sydney opened her voice memo app and rattled off a brief account of what had just happened, then added: "The 'vulture' Resident did not directly harm a person, but demonstrated behavior consistent with luring a target into a trap... This is a new behavioral pattern. Worth noting."

She hadn't joined a Hunter House Faction, so naturally her ability to gather and track Nest intelligence was no match for the systematic, organized operations of Faction Hunters.

But she had her own way of getting by: she would bring any valuable information she collected to the Backlight Bar, where the owner — whose face looked like a Shar-Pei — would repay her with a different set of intelligence in exchange. He was like a human information bulletin board, or a primitive version of LinkedIn.

She put away her phone and looked around. She nearly sighed.

To her right was a row of stone-brick townhouses, each with a short staircase climbing up to the front door. The stairs were separated from each other by patches of trees; the railing she had just crashed into stood just outside the nearest cluster.

Never mind that she was trying to get to the Museum of Modern Art — even if she weren't, there was no way she was just wandering into a Nest building without good reason.

To her left, the road was wide open. She could step off the sidewalk and follow the roadway to bypass the chalk grid entirely — under normal circumstances, that would work fine. But not right now, because the traffic light was still purple.

"If it weren't for all this garbage, fifteen kilometers would not take two whole days to walk..."

Muttering, Sydney stowed her knife and phone securely, adjusted her hiking pack, tightened the hip belt, and stepped her right foot into the first square.

She stood in the square on one leg. The last traces of the alcohol still in her system rolled through her ankles like little waves; Sydney was dripping with cold sweat, wobbling, one hand braced against the railing.

The square said only "Right foot" — she absolutely could not put down her left foot without permission.

The smile on "Sydney Ginn's" face froze, locked in place — and then, starting from the cheekbones, it slowly began to warp. One cheekbone pushed further and further outward while the other slid gradually downward.

Had it given up, seeing she hadn't taken the bait?

Usually, when a vulture saw that a takeover was hopeless, it would abandon its target's likeness — either morphing into someone else, or retreating into the shadows and disappearing.

Watching your own features, your own face, melt and slide off another face like a summer ice cream cone — according to other Hunters, it was an unexpectedly awful feeling.

"Clear off, and I won't kill you."

Sydney tossed out the empty threat, turned back to the grid, switched to her left foot, and hopped forward onto the middle square of the next row. The moment she landed, the hiking pack dragged her down with a brutal lurch — it felt for all the world like someone had jumped onto her back.

Her arms pinwheeled like a windmill for several frantic rotations before she finally steadied herself, and somewhere inside she had already killed that harassment-obsessed Anthony ten times over — of course all the bad things were his fault.

Though if something good came of this trip — like getting her hands on a rare Artifact — that would naturally be entirely to her own credit.

The moment the purple light went out, she would find her chance to jump down off the sidewalk.

The first four or five rows of squares were still somewhat reasonable: sure, carrying a pack that weighed over ten kilograms while still half-drunk and hopping forward one-legged was grueling work, but at least it wasn't beyond her.

Somewhere around an indeterminate square, the text in the boxes stopped being just "left foot" and "right foot."

"Left hand," read one square.

The squares flanking it on either side were filled with penalties: "unconsciousness," "lose all red blood cells produced in the past year," "visit Colorado Avenue No. 87."

Thank goodness there was a utility pole right beside that square.

Sydney managed it with agonizing difficulty — one arm clamped around the pack, both feet braced against the pole, body inverted, left hand pressed flat into the square. She felt like a circus performer, one leg stretched out into empty air, her entire body a trembling, lopsided Y-shape, before she barely managed to get her foot onto the next square.

"Exchange food for the right to stand," announced the next square.

That, at least, was nothing. Sydney's pack was well stocked with snacks — good ones, too.

She stood in the position she'd purchased with a beef sausage, letting her shaking limbs rest for a moment. When she finally raised her head, she stopped short.

Every single square she could see from here to the limit of her vision was packed with the same three characters, written over and over.

Copied copied copied copied copied copied copied copied copied.

...All of them were penalties?

Copied? If she stepped on one, what would happen —

Sydney went rigid. She turned her head slowly, and there on her own shoulder, she found herself looking at the side of a face — cheeks full and puffed out like dumplings.

She had no idea when it had crept up on her again, silent as a shadow.

She was only about a hundred meters from the traffic light now, but the purple glow kept blinking on and off, with no sign of going anywhere.

The road to the Museum of Modern Art had barely begun, and already it had ground to a halt.

Sydney thought of "Nest's Current Top Hit No. 1."

She had to admit — only that one "song" could truly express and give voice to how she felt right now. Sung aloud, it would be nothing but a string of long, raw, wordless human howls.

Only six days in and I've already slipped — I couldn't hold the 10:15 update schedule anymore... But hey, I posted today! Deal with it!

Spent the whole time hunched over the keyboard and now my neck is killing me (at home my monitor is on a stand, right at eye level, so it doesn't strain my neck at all).

I don't have much neck to begin with — what am I supposed to do if I lose what's left of it.

Feeling a bit dizzy and rough, let me go eat something first, and then I'll get around to compiling everyone's names from the comments...

(Let me know when you think would be a good time to inform my mom that she's suddenly acquired a lot of new moms.)

Chapter 8 — Sydney Ginn's Blackmoor City Transportation & Tourism Map

"What I'm about to say may be hard to believe. I can barely believe it myself.

"I'm still standing inside the chalk-drawn house, and I have nowhere to go. I can't back up — I tried. Two rows behind me there's a square that says 'left hand.' On the way in, I managed a one-armed handstand off a utility pole, but going back the other way, I can't reach the pole anymore."

Hauling a heavy pack while doing a one-armed handstand on her weaker left side — Sydney Ginn simply couldn't manage it. Hunters had a passage and could enter the Nest, but that didn't transform them into something superhuman or bless them with supernatural strength.

To make matters worse, the Resident's breathing floated just beside her ear the whole time, and at the very edge of her vision there was always her own face — her face, subtly twisted, like a reflection watching her from somewhere deep underwater.

She had been gripping the hunting knife again for a while now.

Sydney closed her eyes, then opened them. To the left, the street was still silent and still — sliced open again and again by purple light, gutted, like wet viscera laid bare under an X-ray.

"It seems like Hopscotch and the 'Vulture' Resident have developed some kind of... cooperative arrangement."

Sydney murmured into her phone's voice memo app: "I can't think of a better explanation than the two of them working in concert."

The "Vulture" had tried to herd her into the chalk-drawn house, and the chalk-drawn house had returned the favor — once she had gone in deep enough that retreat was impossible, it had written "copied" as the penalty in every square ahead of her...

If she had actually stepped on one of those squares, the Resident trailing behind her would probably have become a second Sydney Ginn.

And what would happen to her — the original?

The original host hadn't even died, yet the "Vulture" would already have become the target itself. She had never heard of anything like that.

"Maybe I'm overthinking it... The traffic light on the street hasn't changed color in nearly ten minutes. It's been purple the whole time, keeping me stuck on the sidewalk. Could it really be part of this trap too? I find that hard to imagine... Unlike Residents, other things have no intelligence. How would they coordinate?"

The information recorded in the voice memo served more than one purpose — beyond being exchangeable as intelligence later on.

If she could never leave the Nest and ended up dying here, she could at least comfort herself with the fantasy that someday a Hunter would find her phone.

Who she was, where she died, what her final moments were like — none of that would sink with her into the depths of the Nest.

Perhaps somewhere in the world there was another person who would hear her last few words and know that a Sydney Ginn had once existed. Even if the next second, like cloud-smoke scattered by the wind, her name dissolved from that person's mind the moment they turned away.

Sometimes she found it strange herself: she was someone overflowing with desires, someone who loved to enjoy life — and yet she was ready to die at any moment, in any place.

Perhaps you couldn't become an Artifact Hunter without that kind of resolve.

She put her phone away and looked at the traffic light again.

She didn't really need to look up to know the purple light was still on — but what else could she do besides stare at the traffic light over and over?

The alcohol had mostly worn off, yet her energy and strength seemed to have evaporated along with it, seeping out through her pores, leaving behind a body that felt loose and heavy. The muscles in her legs trembled, as if they couldn't get a proper grip on her bones.

The square said "exchange food for the right to stand" — it said nothing about sitting, so Sydney didn't dare sit down. Her pack, which weighed a good ten kilograms, she kept balanced on the tops of her feet rather than let it touch the chalk drawing.

"Just you wait," she muttered to the Resident beside her. "I refuse to believe the purple light will stay on for seven straight days."

The Resident didn't respond. It probably knew, as well as she did, that Sydney was just bluffing — even with food and water, standing without sleep for seven days straight would kill a

person.

Well, that was exactly why most Hunters, after going solo into the Nest a few times, ended up filing applications with the major Hunter House Factions. Even someone like Sydney Ginn — who hated taking orders and couldn't stand being managed — found herself thinking, with genuine feeling: it would be so good to have a partner watching her back right now.

She stood in her one square of the chalk house as the night wind grew steadily colder. The longer she stood, the more she felt the sheer absurdity of her situation pressing down on her — what on earth was she doing?

She'd fallen from a great height once already, just to end up here, standing like a human post?

Sydney racked her brain for a while, turning over options like climbing a tree or walking a tightrope — each shot down in turn by reality — until finally, out of sheer desperation and a what-do-I-have-to-lose attitude, she even screwed up her courage and shouted "Is anyone there?" twice into the air. Whether she was lucky or unlucky was hard to say: nothing whatsoever came out of that row of stone townhouses.

She had tried a good handful of ideas, and now she was back to her old occupation of standing there like a human post.

It would have been nice if there'd been an announcement to warn her — had she known, she would never have taken this wretched road.

She said it, but she knew perfectly well it wasn't realistic.

If the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion introduced road conditions on every single path inside the Nest, by the time it finished broadcasting she would have long since made it back to Blackmoor City with nothing accomplished.

The thought of broadcasts made her think of her map — the one covered in her own annotations. Wait, what if those notes could actually come in useful?

Sydney flicked a glance at "Sydney Ginn."

The Resident was still standing a couple of steps away, but it was getting more and more unsettling to look at. While she'd been glancing away, it had mimicked Sydney's own expression — black pupils rolling hard to the right, whites of its eyes flipping forward, staying stuck there for a long moment before rolling back.

And that was her face. Nightmare fuel for a week, at least.

Sydney pushed the hunting knife back into the sheath at her hip, pulled the map from her pack, and shook it open. In the flickering purple light and the murky yellow pool of the streetlamp, she read through her annotations carefully.

A few minutes later she looked up from the map, turned to the Resident beside her, and snapped out a sharp, bright curse: "Fuck your mother!"

"Sydney Ginn" apparently didn't realize it was being cursed at. It kept staring at Sydney with intense, entranced focus, and then its lower lip suddenly drooped crookedly, as if it were trying to copy the shape of her mouth.

"Get over here!" Sydney had found nothing useful on the map, and her temper was running hot. "Everyone says Residents can't be killed — so you won't mind if I stick you a few times, will you? Get over here!"

"Sydney Ginn" didn't budge.

The angrier she got, the more she seethed. She pressed her lips together, worked her tongue around for a moment, gathered up a big mouthful of saliva, and spat — a sharp "pteh!" — right onto the chalk square at "Sydney Ginn's" feet. Whatever punishment that square dished out, it wasn't her problem since she was the one who'd spat.

Unfortunately, the square wasn't about to be washed away by a mouthful of spit — not that it would've been that easy — and the frothy wet mark blinked out in an instant, as if the paving stones had simply absorbed it, leaving the chalk drawing beneath exactly unchanged.

The result was that "Sydney Ginn" began to mimic her again, pressing its own lips tight together, its tongue apparently starting to stir behind them.

"Oh, for the love of —"

Sydney finally felt a jolt of genuine alarm. She hurriedly raised her pack to use it as a shield against the Resident's spit — but thankfully, the Resident's internal anatomy seemed to work differently. When it opened its mouth, there was only a dark, dry hollow inside, and nothing came out.

The little episode ended, and she was still no closer to a way out.

Sydney stared at the line of text reading "Blackmoor City Tourism Transportation Map," utterly at a loss. Though her eyes lingered on the map, her thoughts had drifted far away, wandering aimlessly to somewhere unknown.

When she came back to herself, she realized she had been staring at several rows of small print in the lower-right corner of the map's reverse side for quite a few minutes now.

Sydney slowly narrowed her eyes.

The tourism transportation map was packed with supplementary information — national emergency numbers, police hotlines, tourism website addresses, travel insurance details — and somewhere among those dense rows of small print, her gaze snagged on one particular item.

The taxi service hotline for Blackmoor City.

Of course, that was a phone number from the human world.

She was currently inside a delirious, nightmarish mirror world, one where even her phone had no signal...

A mirror world...

The yellow taxis — one of Blackmoor City's most iconic sights, the yellow taxis that had appeared in countless films and TV shows — would they cast their reflections in the Nest as well?

The thought was like a hand pressed against the back of her skull, impossible to ignore.

Sydney half-laughed at herself for letting her imagination run wild, for being ground down by her predicament into wishful thinking — and yet she reached for her phone again, as if her hand had moved on its own. The upper-right corner, of course, read "No Signal."

She hesitated — and then, at last, she punched in the hotline number digit by digit and pressed call.

No harm in trying. And even if it didn't work, was she really worried about being laughed at by "Sydney Ginn" standing next to her?

In the taut silence of her waiting, out of the night sky sliced into black and purple, came the sound: "beep — beep —"

"Hello," a woman's voice said. "Do you need taxi service?"

She stood with her mouth half-open, speechless. Was this a hallucination?

"Do you need it, or not?" The woman's voice was unhurried, matter-of-fact, like a machine asking a straightforward question.

"I — yes, I do!" The words were barely out of Sydney's mouth before a new wave of alarm hit her. "Wait — what are the conditions for getting a taxi? What do I pay with? I have to pay, right?"

"Of course. Please note the following passenger guidelines," the woman's voice said evenly. "One: tell the driver your destination. Two: do not look at the driver. Three: sit in the back seat. Four: lower your head and extend it into the space between the driver's seat and the front passenger seat. Five: recall a recent experience in your mind. Six: do not panic when the driver collects the fare."

"...Recall?" Even with all her time in the Nest, Sydney was still sometimes left dumbfounded by its strangeness.

"That is correct. Please note the following fare requirements. One: the recalled experience must be from within the past one month. Two: the scenes and events in the recollection must be continuous. Three: the experience being recalled must have lasted at least three minutes when it occurred. Four: the driver accepts only the first experience that surfaces spontaneously in your mind — deliberately selected or filtered memories are not accepted."

"Is that everything? Just the memory — nothing else? I'll arrive safely at my destination and be able to get out safely?" She was terrified the other party might be playing word games, so she tried to plug every loophole she could think of.

"Correct."

"That's completely fine," Sydney breathed out a long sigh of relief. "Send a car over right away!"

Never mind the past month — even looking back ten years, there wasn't a single memory she would rather die than give up. And for just three minutes, at that.

"I'm on Colorado Avenue," she gave her location, then suddenly thought of something and quickly asked: "Can you have the driver open the car door for me when they stop?"

She looked down at the square beneath her feet, then at the street beside it, measuring the gap with her eyes. That distance — she could make it.

The only problem was that "landing" would be considerably harder than a normal landing; she couldn't come down on the sidewalk, and she couldn't come down on the road either — she'd

figure out the specifics once the car actually arrived.

It all went smoothly, almost dreamlike. The woman's voice answered with a single "yes."

Sydney felt salvation crash over her all at once; her heartbeat went light and giddy, nearly soaring out of her chest. She hung up. In the reflection on the screen, half a face pressed close to hers stared back at her.

Did it sense the duck was about to fly out of reach just as it had nearly made it to its beak? Was it getting desperate?

"Back off,"

Sydney used the same method as before, slashing the hunting knife through the air in several wide loops to drive the Resident back a few steps — and then, when she came back to herself, she was sitting in the back seat of a taxi.

...Huh?

The taxi accelerated smoothly, gliding steadily through the purple traffic light. The numbers on the meter didn't move. A human-shaped silhouette sat in the driver's seat, one leather-gloved hand resting on the steering wheel.

"...Where are we going?"

The question had barely left Sydney's mouth when she realized she was breathing hard, her heart hammering — as if she had just burned through a burst of intense physical exertion.

"Museum of Modern Art," came the reply — it must have been the driver speaking, yet no matter how she listened, the voice seemed to come from somewhere beneath her feet.

Sydney decided not to look down.

She had no memory of how she'd gotten into the cab, but a little reverse reasoning made it easy enough to figure out: the first experience that surfaced in her mind must have been the one that had just occurred at the moment of boarding — the process of giving the driver the address and having her memory taken from her had already been handed over as the fare.

Not bad, actually; if anything, she'd turned disaster into luck — she could ride all the way to the Museum of Modern Art in one go.

She turned around and glanced back at the other "Sydney Ginn" she was steadily leaving behind.

Even at a growing distance, she could tell the Resident was furious beyond measure: it flailed its arms wildly, like one of those long inflatable tube men outside car dealerships thrashing up and down, and every so often it threw its head back and let out a long, drawn-out howl — yet another new behavior to add to the list.

Hopscotch, the Resident, the taxi — everything she'd encountered tonight was fresh intelligence.

The Nest seemed to be changing; she just didn't know whether the change was still within normal parameters.

But Sydney Ginn couldn't summon the energy to write any of it down just yet. She slumped in her seat and let out a long, slow breath.

Before the next crisis could start gnawing at her, she just wanted a proper moment to recover.

I'm dying — suddenly going back to churning out a daily word count is a bit much... after all, my one-week stockpile took three months to write.

My update pace is probably way out of place for a male-readership platform — is there a disability-friendly channel out there somewhere? Maybe I should move there.

Chapter 9 — Goodbye, Sydney Ginn

"Thank you for riding,"

The driver's silhouette hadn't moved once — the single absolutely still thing in a vehicle that had been moving the whole way. "You have arrived at your destination."

Sydney Ginn stood on the street beside the Museum of Modern Art; there was a solid thud, and the car door folded shut behind her.

She turned her head on instinct, just in time to catch the taxi's red taillights drifting into the fog that seeped up from the depths of the night and the white steam curling off the sewer grates, blurring away into nothing.

...She felt like she'd forgotten something.

Sydney stood in the middle of the road and watched the red taillights until they vanished entirely into the dark — into the fog-blue and smoke-white — without knowing why she kept staring.

She knew, of course, that a stretch of her memory had been collected as the fare and was gone for good no matter how hard she reached for it.

But what Sydney felt she'd forgotten seemed to sit outside that missing stretch — as though something she ought to have noticed had slipped right past her. It was the feeling she sometimes got before leaving the house, a nagging suspicion that she'd left something behind, like a patch of cloud had settled over part of her mind and wouldn't be parted, hiding whatever moon lay behind it.

In her experience, thinking harder at a time like this was entirely useless; you had to walk out the door and wait for the moment you actually needed the thing before it would smack you — one sharp slap to the thigh, sudden clarity.

Oh well. She'd climbed out of that car with all her limbs attached and her head still sitting on her neck. If she really had forgotten something, it clearly wasn't anything life-or-death. It would come back to her eventually.

She pressed herself against the glass of Entrance D and peered inside first, then began easing the door open centimeter by centimeter.

Unlike Blackmoor City, almost nothing in the Nest was ever locked. If you ran into a door that wouldn't open, it usually meant a Hunter was inside — as though the faint comfort of a lock became something to cling to desperately for anyone who'd ventured into this strange and treacherous place.

After all, people can't survive without at least the illusion of safety. If everyone knew exactly what was happening in the world at every moment, probably no one would dare step out their front door.

Sydney held the door with one hand but didn't go in. She waited a few seconds; when silence held on the other side, she eased herself forward one step, setting her foot down as quietly as she could manage.

Even this late at night, half the museum's lights were still on, and the corridors, galleries, and elevator lobbies were all soaked in a white glow that looked almost antiseptic.

Perhaps because it was a museum of modern art, the lighting design and architectural style had a way of making everything feel vast and cold. Walking between the stilled white walls and the white light, she felt almost too alive — too warm, too much, utterly out of place.

Following the directional signs, she found the elevator lobby quickly enough.

The broadcast had given three key instructions: one, "take the first elevator on the left"; two, "do not look at the other elevators"; three, "go to the basement level" — none of it complicated. Lucky thing she hadn't paid away this particular memory as her fare, or she'd really have been stuck.

Sydney pressed the button, took up her position in front of the first elevator on the left, and fixed her gaze firmly on her own nose, her mind turned inward.

This wretched place — sometimes it was utterly predictable; when a crisp ding shattered the stillness, of course it was the elevator on the right that arrived first.

Dead silence clenched for one held breath, and then, like a zipper being drawn open, the elevator doors began to part.

Sydney didn't look, but every single hair on her body had risen into a tiny antenna. She kept her eyes locked on the closed doors directly in front of her, and through some wordless instinct felt certain the elevator on her right was not empty. Something was in there.

Whatever came out, she had already made up her mind — it didn't matter if it was a Resident or a shower of banknotes flooding out of that right-hand elevator. She would not turn her eyes. Not even a twitch.

"Oh, thank goodness — there's someone out there..."

A woman's voice threaded out of the elevator like a length of silk drawn by an unseen hand, trembling in the air. "Listen to me, I came down from the third floor — something very serious happened up there..."

Don't talk to me, Sydney told herself silently. I'm deaf and blind.

On the display panel of the first elevator on the left, a bloodred "28" glowed. The building above ground had all of three floors.

"Don't be frightened,"

The woman's voice, thin as a thread of silk at first, was gradually thickening, as though a voice could have roots. Or perhaps the woman herself was crawling out of the elevator inch by inch, the source of the sound drawing steadily closer to Sydney.

"I'm a Hunter too — came in from Blackmoor City, looking for an Artifact I'd hidden here... but after I came in, I lost track of the time... What's the date today? The day I came in, Reagan was giving his election victory speech."

I'm blind and deaf, I'm deaf and blind — Sydney recited it to herself like an incantation, over and over.

She shifted casually half a step to the side — but not too far back, in case the doors opened and she couldn't throw herself in fast enough.

"Don't get in that elevator,"

Now that the voice was closer, it no longer sounded like silk. It had become something thick and burbling, filthy water gurgling up from the mouth of a drain. "I never should have listened to the host... the first two times she made me think I'd struck gold, and the third time she led me straight to my death. Lucky I was quick enough..."

The moment the words "the host" reached her ears, Sydney very nearly didn't manage to suppress the urge to spin around. She kept her gaze nailed to the elevator doors in front of her, but her heart lurched as though it had been jabbed with something sharp, hammering so hard it was

almost beyond her control, and all she could hear was a dull, rhythmic pounding inside her own skull.

She was staring straight ahead into nothing, not daring to drop her eyes — and yet a dark shadow was slowly rising from the floor, climbing until it hovered at the level of her chest, as though tilting its head to listen.

...Did a racing heartbeat count as a response to the woman?

Sydney didn't dare make any move. Her own breathing and the dark shadow at her chest held each other in a frozen standoff in the cold, quiet elevator lobby — until at last another ding rang out, shattering the stillness.

The leftmost elevator's doors opened.

Wait — the woman was right in front of her. She'd have to go around it to reach the doors. But if she went around it, did that still count as ignoring it?

But she couldn't very well walk straight through it either.

Sydney watched the doors part slowly, revealing the empty elevator car inside; and just as she stood there unable to make up her mind, she felt the dark shadow at her chest suddenly flinch sideways and draw back.

"Hateful..." the woman muttered, as if to herself.

Sydney had a personal rule: when something good happened to her, she never stopped to ask why. Good things were fragile. They couldn't survive being stared at too closely.

The shadow stepped aside and she immediately lunged into the elevator, hammering the door-close button again and again with both hands — thwack thwack thwack — like she was trying to punch through the panel. The whole time, she kept her gaze angled away, not once looking toward the doors outside.

Even without looking, she caught something in the very corner of her peripheral vision — a dark shape on the floor, its limbs swinging against the ground, like some enormous lizard slowly crawling away.

Not until the elevator doors were fully closed and the car was muttering and humming its way down to the basement did Sydney finally let go of the breath she'd been holding clenched in her chest.

So far she had followed the broadcast's instructions to the letter. Surely nothing else would—

"...The first two times she made me think I'd struck gold," the woman's voice echoed unbidden in her head, "and the third time she led me straight to my death."

Sydney rubbed the corners of her eyes and decided to push that irritating, distracting thought down for now.

The Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion was a broadcast for the Nest's Residents to hear — there was nothing surprising about a woman like that knowing who the host was.

Compared to the lizard-like Resident in the elevator lobby, she trusted the broadcast host at least a little more; though that "trust" held three parts doubt, three parts wariness, three parts scrutiny.

The next few minutes, however, seemed to prove the broadcast host hadn't said a single false word. In the dimly lit ground-floor exhibition hall, she found the piece called "Candlewax" almost without effort — honestly, it would have been harder to miss it.

Sydney stood before the exhibit, struck dumb.

Because the piece called "Candlewax" was a massive white candle — nearly as tall as she was, dozens of meters long — lying horizontally on the floor.

Were it not for the waxy, milky-white smoothness of its body and the arm's-length black wick drooping from one end, it could easily have been mistaken for a giant's roof beam. The candle rested on a row of iron frames built specially to hold it, and beneath the frames sat a line of metal troughs whose purpose she couldn't quite determine.

"This thing is an Artifact?"

The candle was enormous. Sydney walked around it for a while and still hadn't made it all the way around. "Hard to say how powerful it is, but the size is really something else..."

This big — how was she supposed to haul it back on her own? Could she cut off a piece?

She couldn't even tell what the Artifact actually did, which meant she had no idea whether cutting it was an option.

Ordinary exhibition pieces always came with a brief introduction to the work and its creator; from experience, if there was any detailed information about an Artifact, it was usually tucked in there.

Sure enough, when Sydney walked around to the other side of the candle, she found the write-up for "Candlewax" covering half a wall, top to bottom.

"Some say time is like flowing water; others say time is speed. But artist Judy Picault believes time is wax... The time we are living through now is a candle in the process of melting — an illusion that its form is still in our hands. But once this moment, this hour has passed, it becomes hardened candlewax, locked forever into the shape of history.

"...The artist's interpretation of time ultimately took form in the piece 'Candlewax.' The enormous candle the viewer sees represents a long, primordial stretch of time.

"It is an interactive artwork. Visitors may build a fire beneath the iron frame, heat the candle, and watch it gradually deform and drip its tears of wax."

Among the rows of neat black-printed sentences, there were passages of handwriting crammed in between — crooked and unsteady, as though whoever had originally typeset the "Candlewax" introduction had deliberately alternated between one passage of clean, rational print and one passage of unraveling madness.

"it's an artifact an artifact an artifact an artifact the artifact that melts time"

"melt time and you set history free from its cage!! look at your own history quick be careful not to accidentally kill your past self what if I put myself inside, next to your past self"

The next passage returned to normal.

"Once heated to transparency, observers will notice the material the artist has embedded within the wax. These represent historical events that occurred within the primordial span of time. By reheating and reshaping the wax — altering the objects within — visitors may change 'the history that was.' The artist believes..."

She couldn't read any further. Sydney turned to look at the enormous milky-white candle behind her, and for a moment had no idea how to process the shock.

You could melt and reshape this candle to change time — no, to change history?

Was she reading that correctly?

If she was, then its reputation as "one of the most powerful Artifacts in existence" was entirely deserved.

She needed to read more carefully about exactly how to use it — and ideally try it herself once. She also needed to find out what effect it might have on the future.

She had to get a basic understanding first before she could think about next steps. Cutting off a piece to take back was probably out of the question; even with another Hunter's help it couldn't be moved, because everyone's passage was different — you couldn't return together. That meant the only option for now was to hide it somewhere...

That was the last thought passing through Sydney Ginn's mind before she turned around and a hunting knife was driven into her throat.

Half a year off and everything else is more or less fine, but my writing speed has practically gone into reverse... I've noticed there's a kind of fierce, absolute beauty in all of you. I don't really look like someone who can churn out twenty thousand characters a day and clear her debts in a month — but the way you all invest in me is so unflinchingly decisive that I stand here trembling on my donkey legs, humbled and terrified.

For instance, Wanjin... if you won't look out for yourself, then I will — can't we just let this bond of ours simmer nice and slow? Alright, that's a sixth chubby baby I owe you. And then there's 95 — she really isn't my alt account, I have no idea what potential she saw in me, but she's thrown in people, money, effort, and backup. Alright, there's another chubby baby...

Buwenhuakaijichu, Lao — do you really not know what I'm like? — and Tall Fish, always siding with the underdog, Linze, Shimomudige, you're all Lao's readers, we really can take it slow, it's not right for me to keep shearing the same flock of sheep, is it?

I also want to thank Haiyan Qifeng, Love Letter W0ZV, nestea, Fengyin (you two seem like new readers? or just the quiet type?), Dongxie (somehow you feel like a matching set?), Banxia sis, Jianbing Fujin (would you please for the love of god stop), Kafka, Qiti, Junmi xi, Xuanfeng Feewan, Qiwu, Tail's Leave Note (pretty sure you flipped that around), and everyone else for all your support and encouragement... I feel like I've worn the word "thanks" smooth in the Chinese language. It's not like I've written anything worth all this — how could I possibly deserve it!

Seven — SEVEN chapters updated aaaaaaah

Might as well just go catch all seven Calabash Brothers while I'm at it

PS: This one definitely won't drag on as long as Doomsday did! Even an eighteen-year-old values her life, you know! Two or three years, I say with all the reckless confidence of youth.

Chapter 10: A Gathering of Heroes at Mai Minghe

Mai Minghe had never heard of the Nest, and knew nothing of what a "Resident" was or how dangerous one might be.

But she figured that no matter how bizarre things looked on the surface, nothing could ever truly defy its own internal logic.

The hospital inside the Nest seemed to operate on the same principles as a real one: press the call button, and a "nurse" would come — or rather, someone masquerading as a nurse would come — and whatever came would have its eyes fixed on the person who had pressed it.

The only difference was that nurses in real hospitals came to care for their patients; as for what the "nurses" here intended to do... she stopped herself from thinking it through.

If she couldn't escape this room, she was about to find out firsthand — why waste the mental energy?

To get out, she needed to create a few evenly matched rivals to compete for the attention of the patient in the next bed.

There was one truth that held whether you were inside the Nest or out: only when multiple blades clashed and crossed could gaps appear between them; a single blade, undistracted, would cut straight through her without hesitation.

The real question was: could she actually slip through those narrow gaps between the blades?

Evidently, the red-haired man had already grasped the thinking behind her pressing the button.

The moment he steadied himself, he drove his foot hard into Bed No. 2 — the unlocked wheels scraped and ground across the floor, sending the patient and the whole bed crashing into the cabinet and the other bed behind it. Amid the collision, he bellowed without looking back: "Even if you wanted to leave bait for the Artifacts, you didn't need to press the damn button four times!"

He had a point; honestly, Mai Minghe was feeling a little regret about that herself right now.

She had just rolled off the hospital bed again, hoping to use the moment the red-haired man had cut between them to drop down on the far side of Bed No. 1 and make a run for the door —

but she had barely begun swinging one leg across the mattress before she froze completely.

On the other side of Bed No. 1, a nurse was already standing there.

All she could see in her field of vision was the hem of a pale nurse's uniform.

She went rigid on the bed, staring at that strip of fabric — and realized that in no more than a few seconds, the room had filled with people.

One by one, humanoid shadows rose from the floor like a forest growing up from the ground — far more than four of them — standing silently in the dim ward.

In her peripheral vision she couldn't make out any faces, only the vague shapes of heads: round, bloated, and identical, every single one of them turned toward the one corner of the room where two living, breathing people still remained.

How had so many of them come?

"...You're all so warm-hearted. I'm actually feeling much better," she said flatly. "Why don't a few of you head back?"

As the "nurse" beside the bed slowly tilted its neck down toward her, Mai Minghe shut her mouth.

A torrent of fragmented, terrifying guesses tore through her mind — but she hadn't anticipated that when the figure lowered its head, she would find herself looking at a perfectly ordinary, healthy face.

"Where does it hurt?"

It was a young, soft round face. It — or should she say "she"? — spoke with a slightly drawn-out Southern accent, the kind that suggested someone who had just started work and hadn't yet shed the speech of home.

If she focused only on the nurse's large eyes with their gently drooping outer corners, and ignored the bloated round heads crowding her peripheral vision, ignored the spindly black shadow behind the red-haired man slowly unfolding to three or four metres tall, Mai Minghe might truly have believed everything that had just happened was a hallucination — a dream she'd had while lying in some ordinary hospital bed.

"Get away from that nurse!" the red-haired man suddenly shouted.

Mai Minghe startled, and her eyes darted instinctively toward him — somehow the red-haired man had plastered himself halfway up the wall, like a knockoff Spider-Man who hadn't quite mastered his powers and was managing his limbs with considerable awkwardness.

The moment he scaled the wall, what had been hidden behind him was exposed: the spindly black shadow, its head brushing the ceiling, was moving toward Mai Minghe one step at a time.

On either side of the bed stood a Resident; the only way out was the foot of the bed —

It was as though heaven had heard her thoughts and decided to grant her wish in the most perverse way possible: at that moment, something cinched tight around Mai Minghe's ankles, as if a hand had grabbed hold and then wrenched downward with sudden violence; she was dragged helplessly across the bed, the nurse's face and the ceiling sweeping past in a blur as she was hauled straight toward the foot of the bed.

Cold sweat and hot sweat broke out together; Mai Minghe flung her hands out frantically and seized the bed rail, but all she got for it was skin scraped raw and burning — it did nothing to slow her momentum.

Whatever had clamped onto both her feet beneath the bed and was dragging her toward the foot possessed a strength no human could match — never mind Mai Minghe; even a Marine would have been no match for it. In desperation she cried out: "My ankle!"

The nurse tilted her head.

"My ankle hurts!"

In the span of those few words, the better part of Mai Minghe's body had been hauled off the bed, her feet nearly touching the floor.

The spindly shadow that had descended from the neighboring bed was standing at the foot, waiting for her.

Unlike what she'd planned, it had no interest in where she was being dragged — because as she was pulled from the bed, her pajamas had ridden up, exposing her abdomen and the loops upon loops of "snake-wrap" coiled around it.

The spindly shadow reached a hand toward her stomach.

"Oh?" said the young nurse, her Southern drawl warm and unhurried. "If the ankle's gone, then there won't be anything left to hurt."

Every word a well-bred young lady should never say made a full lap through Mai Minghe's mind.

At the same moment, the spindly shadow made contact with her abdomen.

The instant those ice-cold fingertips touched her skin, Mai Minghe nearly lost consciousness.

It was as though her skin fibres, blood vessels, and fascia had all been seized by that chill and twisted, wrung, and knotted together — knot after knot tightening at once. Her mind could not bear the agony of every nerve ending coiling in on itself, and darkness was already blooming at the edges of her vision.

The little nurse wasn't stopping the spindly shadow, her ankle was about to be lost, and all the while she was still sliding toward the floor —

Just when Mai Minghe thought all hope was gone, in a flash of lightning, she heard a shriek erupt from beneath the bed.

The feeling that shriek stirred in anyone who heard it was almost impossible to describe: for the closest comparison, imagine discovering that your winning lottery ticket had fallen into the toilet — that churning, gut-wrenching sensation of watching a jackpot swirl away with the flush was roughly what it felt like to hear the shriek from under the bed.

But whatever the feeling, her feet were finally released.

The little nurse made a small "hm?" sound. She had been standing beside the bed just moments before, and without anyone noticing she had drifted to the foot of it, bending down to examine Mai Minghe's ankle with an appraising look.

"There's something on your ankle," the little nurse said. "I didn't get all the way through just now — let me try again."

As it spoke, it raised its hand — and for the first time, Mai Minghe saw clearly what that hand was: extending from the wrist was not a hand at all, but a dense thicket of thick, gleaming silver needles bristling in every direction.

In that instant, she understood.

The nurse had been jabbing needles at her ankle — but there were hands gripping her ankle, so the needles had driven straight into those hands instead.

Mai Minghe understood, but she was propped on her elbows on the bed with both feet on the floor, and even with nothing restraining her she could barely hold herself up and keep from sinking to the ground entirely — there was no chance of moving, let alone running, because the spindly patient was standing right in front of her, body bent half forward, its long fingers peeling away the "snake-wrap" strand by strand.

Every point of contact sent that agonizing tangle of blood vessels and nerves twisting through her body — she could barely breathe, let alone walk or flee.

"My stomach," she managed, staring at the countless densely packed needle-tips, forcing the words out one by one. "My stomach hurts now... stick it in my stomach..."

The little nurse seemed blind to the other Residents, or at least regarded them with complete indifference; it glanced down at Mai Minghe's abdomen, swung the needle-cluster high, and drove it down.

The spindly patient finally stopped peeling away the snake-wrap. It flung its arm in a sudden sweeping arc at the little nurse — the arm unfolded joint by joint through the air as though it had hidden an unknowable number of segments — and though the motion sounds slow in the telling, in a single blink it had dragged a bed curtain out of nowhere and interposed it between the little nurse and her bristling needles.

What kind of absurd method was that?

Mai Minghe had no intention of sitting there to find out whether the little nurse could push through from behind the curtain.

She seized the moment, leapt to her feet, ducked past the spindly patient, and ran flat-out toward the door — from the moment she had first seen the little nurse to now, no more than a few seconds had passed, and already it felt as though she'd spent half her life.

"Keep going," said one of the round-headed shadows, standing motionless in the dimness.

Like I need your encouragement.

"Duck," said another round-headed shadow, still perfectly still, its voice flat and uninflected.

Who in their right mind would duck right now —

Mai Minghe skidded to a sharp stop, folded at the waist, and dropped into a crouch. She immediately felt something rake the air just above her head — and then something hit the door

frame with a heavy thud.

She was only five or six steps from the door, but she had no choice but to glance back; unwillingly, she stole a quick look — there seemed to be a pale white hand embedded in the door frame, trailing an impossibly long arm.

Cracks had spread across the wall around the frame in a web of fractures.

If she hadn't ducked, that hand would have caught her square in the back of the skull and smashed her against the door frame like a fly.

Well. It turned out she really did need the round-headed crowd's encouragement after all.

"Hey!" Mai Minghe ran toward the cluster of motionless round-headed shadows and called out: "What's going on with all these big heads?"

From somewhere behind one of the round-headed silhouettes, a shadow suddenly shifted; Mai Minghe had just taken fright when she heard it hiss through its teeth, as though swallowing pain, and say: "I've never seen Residents like this. I have no idea."

Apparently the red-haired man had climbed down from the wall at some point — looking as though he'd been hurt in the process; likely trying to avoid the spindly patient, he too had moved toward this cluster of round-headed silhouettes near the center of the room, with a few figures standing between him and her.

Mai Minghe very much wanted to keep asking — what Residents had he seen, and what exactly were Residents anyway — but now was obviously not the time: the spindly patient had already turned its head in their direction, and its crown was dragging along the ceiling with a hushed, rasping sound.

As though terrified of the thing getting too close, the red-haired man ducked quickly in among the round-headed silhouettes; his face had gone ashen and was sheened with sweat, and he edged sideways through the crowd in small, careful steps toward the door, not daring to brush against any of the round heads.

Mai Minghe followed his lead and hurried into the forest of round heads herself.

The moment she saw them clearly, she felt as though her internal organs had lost all support and plummeted to the bottom of her stomach.

The reason she had thought them identical was that in the dimness each head had seemed swollen and bloated and enormously round; but up close, the round-headed figures were men and women, young and old, each with a different face.

Their originally normal human skulls, however, had been fractured — every bone of the skull and face separated from the rest — and then a mass of something like pressurized gas beneath the skin had expanded outward, inflating the shattered bone and skin together into a perfect uniform sphere. The individual fragments of bone were still discernible beneath the skin, calling to mind the continental plates drifting across the surface of the earth.

The eyes — one on either side — were each set into the flanks of the skull as though two blisters had grown from the skin itself, swiveling to follow Mai Minghe's steps; the nasal bone had been split straight down the center, wrenching two slanted, elongated nostrils across the face.

The mouths, at least, were normal; but around the corners of each mouth and across every inch of each face ran long, deep grooves the color of dark bruising — the marks of skin stretched until its fibers tore.

A sudden guess surfaced in Mai Minghe's mind. "Could it be that these were people, originally?"

The red-haired man stepped around the last round-headed figure, cleared the crowd, and was already striding toward the door. "Sorry — you're the Residents' target, and there's nothing I can do about it. If I ever manage to come across your body afterward, I'll bring it back to Blackmoor City."

He certainly wasn't the target; he was nearly at the ward door now, and the spindly patient paid him no mind whatsoever.

The nurse was still standing vacantly behind the curtain, nothing but a pair of shoes visible beneath the hem; and the two hands stretching out from under the bed had gone perfectly still.

Only the slender patient prowled slowly back and forth before that cluster of round-headed silhouettes, as though biding its time for a chance to strike at Mai Minghe.

"It can't get in," said one of the round-headed figures standing to Mai Minghe's left, almost as though offering reassurance.

The one on her right said, "We'll all surround you,"

A round-headed figure behind her finished the thought: "and walk with you toward the door — you'll be able to get out."

Whatever their ugly appearance, these things had hearts that were unreasonably kind, and the idea wasn't bad either — Mai Minghe lowered her head, staring at the floor, as a thought that had flickered through her mind not long ago surfaced once more.

However strange and fantastical the surface might be, nothing could ever violate the inner logic by which it operated.

She snapped her head up and called out, "Young man, stop right there — don't go outside, whatever you do!"

Honestly, I had a perfectly comfortable home in the women's fiction section and had no real desire to wade into men's fiction... Sure, the numbers on Qidian's women's side aren't great, but it suits a small crowd of readers carving out their own little corner, and the atmosphere is pretty easygoing — everyone's stats are about the same, and there's no real difference between ranking first and ranking tenth. Just one big happy circle.

Men's fiction is a whole different animal. It feels anxious, high-pressure — like everyone's holding their breath to grind out ten thousand characters a day, go viral, and knock the king off the throne. Begging for votes, begging for tips, rush the plot, skip to the good part... I don't have those tools. Looking at all the rankings, charts, and vote counts, well — it's like getting swept into a roaring torrent, and it wouldn't be the least bit surprising to sink to the bottom at any moment.

I still hope to take my time and polish this as best I can. I also hope everyone will feel free to demand I take days off — I will absolutely oblige, every single time.

Chapter 11 — Mai Minghe Plays Rock-Paper-Scissors

In truth, Mai Minghe never really expected that the red-haired man would hear her shout and immediately pull back from the door.

When the way out was right there in front of him, who would hold back from taking that last step?

What happened next, then, caught her completely off guard: the red-haired man snatched back the foot he had just been swinging into the corridor — so abruptly that he nearly lost his balance — braced one hand against the wall, hopped back two steps on one foot, and stopped somewhere between the doorway and the round-headed figures, cursing under his breath.

"How did you know?" His gaze swept past one round head after another and settled on Mai Minghe.

The room was packed with Residents ready to tear them apart, yet at this particular moment there was a hairline gap between the blades — a rare chance to exchange a few words.

Mai Minghe answered immediately: "I don't know exactly what's going on. I just know we can't go out there. What did you see? You didn't stay back just because some old lady told you to, did you?"

"Don't go pulling the elder card on me." The red-haired man wiped his face irritably. "There's a Resident at the door."

The ward door gaped wide open, revealing a bright, empty corridor; under the corridor lights, there was not so much as a shadow on the floor tiles.

"Really? That's something — can it turn invisible?" Mai Minghe exclaimed in genuine surprise, then couldn't help musing aloud, "So they actually cracked that? I remember back around '75 or '79, some scientist said they could use certain electromagnetic waves to—"

"Stop rambling on about all that nonsense," the red-haired man cut her off, his expression darkening further. "How did you know we couldn't go outside?"

Mai Minghe glanced first at the elongated patient.

In her youth she'd stood five foot eight, yet even so she could only see the elongated patient's navel; the hospital gown was far too short for it, bunched up around its chest, and on its abdomen

gaped a dark, hollow hole — she didn't dare look any longer and quickly averted her eyes.

Mai Minghe hadn't forgotten that inexplicable step she herself had taken toward the door.

The elongated patient was still reluctant to give up, but as the round-headed figures had said, as long as she remained surrounded by them, it seemed to lack the nerve to come inside.

She had a moment to breathe — she just didn't know how long it would last.

"These things came here to hurt people, didn't they?" Mai Minghe explained. "They were so eager to help me get out that it had to mean going out was exactly what I shouldn't do."

The red-haired man paused, as though her words were a handkerchief stuffed straight into his throat. "...That's it?"

"There are a couple of other reasons too," Mai Minghe said, a little sheepishly. "I don't know whether you'll buy them or not. You seem familiar with the Nest — take a look. Don't the faces of these big-headed ones have all sorts of lines running across them?"

The red-haired man gave a nod — only half his attention was on Mai Minghe; the other half kept circling warily between the round-headed figures, the elongated patient, and the empty doorway.

"Same principle as stretch marks," he said quietly, "except they've spread onto their faces."

For someone who didn't look like a married man, he knew a fair amount about that sort of thing; Mai Minghe found herself thinking of how, in the old days, a man who knew too much about women's bodies always seemed to carry some faint air of shame about it.

Young people today seemed different — though she wondered how much had really changed.

"Exactly. Their heads have been stretched like a belly at full term — stretch marks on something like that are no surprise. But those lines only appear when living human skin is pulled until the fibers tear.

"I thought to myself: the Residents in the Nest aren't human, so why would they go to the trouble of growing stretch marks? If the big-headed ones were once living people... then what on earth turned them into this?"

A bubble-like eyeball swiveled over and looked at her.

The red-haired man stared at the doorway and nodded. "That makes sense. It means whatever turned people into these Residents hasn't shown itself yet — it's lurking somewhere."

Invisible as it was, the thing was right there at the door; thinking of it that way, no wonder the round-headed figures were clustered in the center of the room, leaving the doorway conspicuously clear rather than blocking it.

If Mai Minghe hadn't pressed the call button four times, if the thing hiding at the door had been the only Resident she'd summoned, she would surely have skirted the shadowy figures in the room and made a straight dash for the exit — and in those circumstances, she would very nearly have run straight into that thing's arms.

From below the ceiling came the elongated patient's voice: "Had enough of your little deduction game?"

The voice oozed into her ears like something viscous, and Mai Minghe felt wave after wave of dizziness wash over her, her stomach heaving with nausea — expelling pathogens and toxins that had invaded the body was pure biological instinct.

The elongated patient slowly bent at the waist; its face was about to slide out of the dimness and into the light spilling from the doorway.

The red-haired man suddenly cried, "Don't look at it!" — Mai Minghe immediately wrenched her gaze away and ducked behind one of the round-headed figures, her heart hammering again, her mouth dry and bitter in a way she couldn't say how long had been building.

"Give it to me,"

The elongated patient was bent double, its skull hovering above Mai Minghe, its voice reverberating as it dripped down around her — almost enough to make one imagine the sound was laced with mucus and shredded flesh.

Its hand circled above the crowd several times as though reaching for Mai Minghe, yet never actually stretched down; it only shrieked: "Give it to me! Give it to me give it to me give it to me give it to me!!"

Mai Minghe hunched over as stomach acid surged up beyond her control, splashing onto the floor.

Dizzy and weak-kneed, she reached out and grabbed the arm of one of the round-headed figures; the round-headed figure immediately let out a low, humming groan and murmured, "It hurts... it hurts so much..."

Your skull's splitting in two and you don't call that pain, but someone grabs your arm for a second and suddenly it hurts?

Mai Minghe caught her breath, straightened up, and let go; the round-headed figure fell silent.

"Damn it — this thing is dead set on getting the Artifact." The red-haired man stood against the wall, staring at the elongated patient. "Residents that actually want Artifacts are pretty rare inside the Nest, and you had to run into one of the stubborn ones."

Even without looking at it or going near it, just listening to the elongated patient's incessant screaming was more than she could bear; if Mai Minghe kept vomiting like this, she'd be dehydrated and unconscious before long — completely at its mercy.

The red-haired man clearly had experience, and probably a way of dealing with this. She was just about to ask what they should do when he spoke again: "...Rock-paper-scissors."

What?

A rustling sound came from below the ceiling — even the elongated patient seemed to turn its head toward him.

"Are you chanting a spell?" Mai Minghe asked with a pained smile.

"No — I just suddenly thought of the game." The red-haired man pressed himself against the wall, standing well away from Mai Minghe and the Residents. "Think about it: why does the tall one want to grab you, but won't actually reach down and do it?"

"It... has a reason not to?"

"Right — it doesn't dare touch the round-headed ones. They said themselves they counter it. So it's not going after the Resident at the door either, because if it turns its back, the round-headed ones can pile onto it." He went on: "I don't know exactly why. Then the tall one counters you — that much is beyond doubt—"

By that point, Mai Minghe had understood.

"Like rock-paper-scissors, where everything beats something in a cycle," she said, tentatively reaching out toward one of the round-headed figures. "Which means... I counter the round-headed ones?"

The moment she touched its arm, the round-headed figure immediately began to buzz and moan, its legs even starting to tremble and knock together.

"I can't figure out why they're afraid of you either," the red-haired man said.

"It's not fear, exactly..."

The elongated patient laughed in disjointed, stuttering bursts, as though it had realized it could torture Mai Minghe with nothing but its voice — and it had to be said, it had found exactly the right angle.

"These humans — after the thing at the door catches them, it pumps its bodily fluids into them, fashions them into flesh-tentacles, and stands them upright on the ground one by one, specifically to be used against other Residents."

Mai Minghe wanted to hear more, but she wasn't sure her insides had enough left to keep giving.

While the elongated patient spoke, she stood half-bent, feeling as though some great beast were writhing in the pit of her stomach and trying to force its way up through her throat; all she could do was curl and spasm like a shrimp — there was absolutely nothing else she could manage.

"A person must be kept alive to serve as a flesh-tentacle. When another living person agitates them, the anesthetic effect of the bodily fluids is diminished, and the flesh-tentacle risks regaining consciousness, detaching from its host, and dying." The elongated patient explained this with something almost like patience. "When you touch them, you're essentially waking them back up — dragging them into an unimaginable agony."

"Be quiet," said one of the round-headed figures at the front, in a flat, expressionless tone.

Mai Minghe was in perfect agreement with it — please, just stop talking.

"So that's where we stand. A deadlock." The red-haired man let out a small, cautious breath. "If the flesh-tentacles attack the tall one, they have to move — and the moment they move, they expose you. If the tall one seizes the opportunity to grab you, it can use you to wake the flesh-tentacles and make them detach and die, and they'll both take heavy losses in the end. But none of that has anything to do with me, so getting dragged into this really is a rotten piece of luck."

From the humans to the Residents, not one of them paid him any attention.

...He'd probably already worked out a plan to slip away while the Residents were busy coming after her.

Mai Minghe was furious, nauseous, and envious all at once, and would have given anything to trade places with him.

"We can take a lesson from the human spirit of negotiation. You give me the person," said the elongated patient, utterly indifferent to whether Mai Minghe was about to heave her stomach out entirely, "and I give you the Artifact."

This was bad.

"How do we make the exchange?" one of the round-headed figures asked.

"Have the flesh-tentacles part," said the elongated patient. "I'll take the Artifact off her, then throw her to the door — throw her right into your mouth."

"You'll guarantee it?"

"Of course. I have no interest in her."

The round-headed figure was silent for a moment, then answered: "Agreed."

Mai Minghe felt very much not agreed.

But cold sweat was soaking through to her back and she had no idea how to stop this. Even if she could counter the round-headed figures, what good did that do? Was she really going to destroy the only moat she had left?

Before her eyes, the round-headed figures were already parting, and for the moment all she could do was scramble along behind them — wherever they retreated, she retreated too, until the whole scene looked horribly like a deadly game of duck-duck-goose.

"If you'd just handed me the Artifact from the start, I might even have let you stay a living old woman." The elongated patient was utterly unbothered by the small delay and resistance, and laughed in a flat, even tone. "Instead you had to go and be clever, and now you'll pay with your life..."

She had barely heard the first half of its sentence before she was bending involuntarily, wracked by another round of dry heaves. She had already brought up everything there was to bring up; her vision swam, her mind grew foggy, and she was dimly aware that the round-headed figures around her were hastily drawing back.

No — she had to stay with them—

Before she could straighten up, the elongated patient had already reached down one hand and closed it tightly around her calf.

1. Stockpiled chapters are like snow in the sun — one glance and there's less of it, sitting there melting away to nothing... In the last chapter I saw everyone enthusiastically urging me to take a day off, and at a pace of one update a day in a boys'-fiction space where you can still get yelled at for that, aren't we something of a revolutionary force? It'll happen, it'll happen — I'll make sure everyone leaves satisfied, feeling right at home, boots off and chatting on the kang.

2. I'm on a plane again on the 23rd. This year's theme is one long continuous sprint across the sky — by my count, over the next few weeks I'll have spent thirty or forty hours scrunched up in airplane seats in total. The major airlines would lose a little flavor in their lives without me.

3. The worldbuilding for Artifact Report has quite a few moving parts, and with the shifting-POV style on top of that — are you all managing to follow so far? Do the settings need to be laid out a bit more plainly? It's a modern Western setting, but hopefully it doesn't feel like you're choking on it? I still went with Western-style translated names for the locations, otherwise you'd have Sydney Ginn getting into trouble on Red Flag First Street, and that would really be switching channels on everyone.

4. I just love talking nonsense — it's not like I have two mouths to use, and when I'm bored it's either eat or talk, and talking nonsense doesn't put on weight.

Chapter 12: Mai Minghe's Comedy Horror

In the instant the world tilted sideways, Mai Minghe could only hold onto two sensations.

The first was sharp and overwhelming, driving out all capacity for thought and conjuring warped hallucinations before her eyes — somehow, inexplicably, it brought to her mind a tree she had once seen in the countryside on a picnic more than forty years ago.

It was the ugliest tree she had ever seen in her life: infected by some fungus or virus, the entire trunk was covered in gnarled, knotted burls, one heaped upon another in grotesque, cancerous clusters — at first glance, it scarcely looked like a tree at all, more like a massive lump of diseased, twisted, brownish hardened flesh.

Drenched in cold sweat, trembling, wracked with pain, she looked down at the place where her right shin should have been, and for a moment the illusion seized her that she was looking at that tree from forty years ago — she didn't even notice when her head had struck the floor.

Long, skeletal fingers — joint by joint, winding slowly and endlessly around her calf.

The second sensation was not really a sensation at all; it was a dull thud she heard — the sound of something heavy striking something else, not far from her.

When she first heard it, the pain had scoured her mind blank and she had no capacity to wonder what it was; yet something — whether it was the slick floor beneath her palms or the edge of her peripheral vision — cut through the fog like a bolt of lightning and lit up her mind in a sudden flash of clarity.

...Of course.

Because the Slender Patient had been deliberately tormenting her, she had barely done anything since this whole ordeal began — she'd spent most of it hunched over in the ring of Round Heads, retching violently; but what no one in that ward had anticipated was that this torment had brought about another entirely unintended consequence.

Specifically: the tile floor of the ward was now smeared, in great sticky, slippery swaths, with vomit and stomach acid.

During the "Eagle Catches the Chicks" game just now, five or six pairs of feet had been tramping back and forth through this foul, slippery mess, spreading it everywhere — which meant

that anything that walked on two feet, at this moment, on this floor, was one careless step away from a spectacular wipeout that would send them face-first into the tiles.

No matter how grotesque a flesh-tentacle might be, if it walked upright on two legs, it still had to eat pavement when the floor demanded it — isn't that right?

The moment that thought struck her, Mai Minghe felt strength rise from her body — that same body that had felt, moments ago, as gnarled and ravaged as the burl-covered tree; and when the Slender Patient's shadow fell over her, she twisted hard and looked.

Not far away, one of the Round Heads had indeed just slipped and crashed to the floor, and was now flailing its feet trying to stand back up.

In that moment, if Mai Minghe could have laughed, she would have laughed out loud — you think you're running?

No matter how bizarre the surface might be, the underlying logic was inescapable; apparently the basic laws of physics applied just as well to the strange things that lurked inside the Nest.

In that instant, forgetting the Slender Patient's existence entirely, Mai Minghe lunged forward, arm stretching out, and seized that Round Head by the ankle.

At the same moment, the Slender Patient's hand found her abdomen again.

If she had lost consciousness, no one could have faulted her for it; what was actually strange was that she didn't pass out at all.

The Slender Patient's shadow loomed high above her, and she still didn't dare look at its face — her eyes stayed fixed on the ankle gripped in her left hand, staking everything she had on that single hold.

Through the mind-blurring pain, through the growing void and dread as the "Snake Band" was peeled away from her body inch by inch, Mai Minghe kept her grip on that Round Head's ankle without loosening it one fraction — and a pained sound that didn't belong to her came trembling through the room.

"Tell — tell it to back off..." she gasped, words slurring: "Otherwise, I won't..."

She didn't need to finish. The Resident at the doorway understood perfectly.

Within seconds, a Round Head across the room called out: "Let her go!"

The Slender Patient seemed not to hear, still peeling the "Snake Band" away bit by bit, its movements careful — almost gentle, even — yet no matter how delicate its touch, the pain it kindled was enough to turn her vision black at the edges.

"Hurry up,"

All the Round Heads urged at once, striding toward the Slender Patient in perfect lockstep. "A mature flesh-tentacle can't be lost — make her release it, or else—"

"Fine," the Slender Patient did seem to hold the Round Heads in some kind of check; seeing them all advancing together, it finally released its grip on Mai Minghe's calf — though its other hand still held the "Snake Band," and it clearly had no intention of letting the Artifact go.

The moment it let go, sensation slowly returned to her calf — what had been a burl-covered tree transformed back into living flesh and blood.

Not that it helped.

Mai Minghe watched as a long, ghastly-pale hand descended through the air toward her arm, its fingers unfolding joint by joint by joint, joint after joint after joint, swinging down to sweep across it; setting aside how agonizing the contact would be, she had absolutely no confidence that she could withstand the force of that swipe without having her grip knocked loose.

And if her grip was knocked loose, wouldn't everything she'd done be for nothing?

Before it could connect, Mai Minghe pushed hard off the floor, managed to twist her body, and thrust out her right hand, reaching for the Round Head's ankle again — if one hand wasn't enough to hold it, would two do?

She knew the idea was perhaps naive. She knew she had been pushed into a desperate corner that ordinary humans could not fight their way out of.

The world seemed to roll over her like a wheel, again and again, grinding her down, trying to make her bow her head and swallow her defiance and make peace with it; she had no idea how she had managed to survive eighty-six years of that. The days that had felt interminable at the time, the days she had thought she would never outlast, had all passed in the end, swift as a breath.

If she had fought back a little more often, resisted a little longer each time, perhaps she wouldn't be lying here today so full of regrets she didn't dare examine them.

Compared to all the tangled, grinding suffering that people visited upon one another in this world, these strange creatures were almost refreshingly simple — straightforward in a way that was almost endearing.

All it took was reaching out one more hand. She could manage that.

She could definitely manage—

The thought never finished. A brief darkness swept through Mai Minghe's mind, and she knew nothing at all.

When the world came back into focus, she found herself lying on her side, both hands empty, lying limp and loose against the floor.

The Round Head had long since scrambled upright and retreated; the Slender Patient was peeling the last section of "Snake Band" from her back — one more loop to go, and it would be gone from her entirely.

...Had she failed?

Two hands, and she still hadn't managed to hold onto the Round Head.

Mai Minghe lay on the floor smeared with her own stomach acid, her body seemingly one step ahead of her, already preparing to return to its eighty-six years of age — weak and soft and heavy.

The Slender Patient extended two of its long, stabbing fingers — long enough to skewer a person clean through — and flipped the deadweight of Mai Minghe back over, laying her flat on her back, then continued peeling away the final stretch of "Snake Band."

As it flipped her, Mai Minghe's right hand flopped softly onto her own chest.

...Hm?

Her fingertips were wet — she couldn't tell whether it was blood or filth; her fingernails especially, thick with it under the rims, deeply uncomfortable.

Wait.

...Blood?

The thought rising in her mind sent a shudder through her entire body; driven by something that felt purely like the survival instinct, without thinking at all, she lashed her hand out and raked it at the Slender Patient's hand.

Contact with the Slender Patient always brought unbearable agony to her — so it could never have anticipated that Mai Minghe would willingly reach out to touch it; but there was something else it had anticipated even less.

The instant Mai Minghe's fingernails made contact with the Slender Patient, it erupted into a vast, churning, billowing mass of shadow.

It was as though her touch was absolute, unbearable agony — pain so intense that the Slender Patient flung the Artifact away, its long body writhing and convulsing, like a pale gray, panicked fog rising and roiling in the dim air above.

...Just as she'd thought.

Mai Minghe didn't dare waste a moment; she immediately pushed herself up off the floor, and the "Snake Band" — as though it had a life of its own — began coiling back around her body at once.

The moment she was upright, she thrust her hand out and flicked the liquid from her fingertips hard at the Slender Patient — and as she did, she thought it over, and despite herself let out a breathless laugh, broken and fragmented as shattered glass, sharp-edged and bright.

It wasn't that she had some peculiar temperament that let her laugh at a moment like this — it was that the scene genuinely was funny: in the middle of the room, a stick-thin shadow with its head brushing the ceiling, twisting and rolling, arms and legs flailing; and beside it stood a woman hurling liquid at it, her hand trembling like she'd had a stroke, the two of them looking for all the world as if they'd both grabbed a live power line at the same time.

Anyone who saw it would have to agree: even for accidentally stumbling into a horror film, this was comedy horror.

"What's going on?" the red-haired man asked from the other end of the ward, staring blankly. "Did it eat something it shouldn't have? Did you?"

He was standing beside one of the hospital beds, pushing it toward the doorway, and at the sight of the Slender Patient's convulsions, he'd actually stopped in his tracks.

The moment Mai Minghe saw what he was doing, she understood his plan immediately and called out: "Wait — take me with you!"

Even as she said it, she had already skirted around the Slender Patient and was sprinting toward the bed; before the red-haired man could react, she launched herself up and rolled onto it,

shouting urgently: "Go, go, go — it's not dead yet!"

The red-haired man looked like he wanted to curse at her, but also like he knew he didn't have time.

"You sure know how to hitch a ride—"

He bit back the rest of the complaint, gritted his teeth, and broke into a run, pushing the bed; just as they neared the doorway, the red-haired man gripped the side rail, planted one foot, and vaulted onto the bed — riding the momentum, the bed rolled "rattle-rattle-rattle" out through the doorway, carrying both of them with it, out into the corridor.

"Don't touch the floor," the red-haired man called, kicking off the wall and sending the bed sliding further along the corridor. "That Resident is underneath the floor!"

"So it really is under the floor?" Mai Minghe gripped the bed tightly and said: "Right before I told you not to go out the door, I noticed what looked like a bunch of thin lines drawn on the floor tiles between the Round Heads — I knew something was off about it then. Thank goodness it's not some kind of invisibility trick."

"This has nothing to do with invisibility!"

As the bed slid past the doorway, the floor tiles seemed to sense something; threads of blood-red lines bloomed suddenly across their surface, like the countless red capillaries that flood an eye wild with fury and panic — but both of them were seated on the bed, not touching the floor, and the "eye" could only watch helplessly as they glided away down the corridor, bed and passengers together.

"What happened back there — why did that tall, skinny one suddenly go berserk?" the red-haired man asked, pushing off the wall to keep them moving.

The explanation was actually simple enough: when Mai Minghe had lunged for the Round Head's ankle earlier, she hadn't managed to grab it — but her right hand had raked across and broken the skin of its ankle.

Before falling into the Nest, she had been a bedridden old woman, and her fingernails had gone uncut for quite a long time — she had certainly never filed them smooth — and the desperate, clawing grab had torn deep, drawing blood, coating her nails with a layer of the Round Head's blood.

"...The Round Heads suppress it, don't they?"

Mai Minghe helped by kicking off the wall herself; the bed zigzagged down the corridor, and with every lurch it slammed into one wall or the other, jolting the speakers mid-sentence.

"So whatever's inside a Round Head's body ought to suppress it too, right? So I wiped that bit of blood onto its hand. I genuinely didn't expect it to work so well."

The red-haired man couldn't help but laugh: "You're really sure this is your first time in the Nest? Not bad at all."

"Will they come after us?" Mai Minghe asked.

"Very likely," the red-haired man glanced back down the corridor — still empty for now. "Get ready — we'll coast a little further, then we have to jump off and run."

As he spoke, the bed carrying the two of them glided past a window into one of the rooms.

In the glass, Mai Minghe caught a fleeting reflection of herself: hair wild, face white as paper, one side of her face smeared with grime...

But the corners of her mouth held a smile, and she looked radiant.

Tomorrow I have to be up and at the airport by five in the morning, and after I land there's still another flight the day after — absolutely exhausting. I can see the last little bit of my chapter stockpile about to run dry, and I feel just like the wastrel son of a rich landlord: my ancestors left me a thousand taels of silver and ten thousand acres of farmland, and I've gone and smoked through every last bit of it. Life as I know it is over!

Before I board, allow me to offer my sincerest thanks to the following new godparents:

Thank you to Haynes for sponsoring my McDonald's (you even had the specific use in mind for me) — your generosity will surely be converted into body fat and stay by my side, possibly for the rest of my life...

Thank you to Iron-Clad Bai Tang for the several cups of coffee (you came back for the new book! Coffee is the only thing in this world keeping me from turning into a zombie) — if you ever catch a whiff of coffee in a future chapter, a portion of that aroma belongs to your support;

Thank you to Tail's Tail-Fur for the minoxidil; now why, you ask? Well, seeing your username gave me a very strong Sun Wukong moment — can I really just pluck a hair, breathe on it, and summon an enthusiastic reader? That's such a good deal. I want to grow more hair.

And thank you to vitang for the sweets (my ambitions in this life are really quite modest), and thank you as well to KanKanKan Sherlock, Meh-Meh's Little Soap Bar, and Whirlwind Fatball who treats sponsoring as a daily check-in, and everyone else for the encouragement — see you all after I land!

Chapter 13 — Mai Minghe: The Natural Order of Things

"We've been through life and death together — I saved you, you saved me."

The red-haired man was covered from head to toe under a white sheet, his voice muffled as he spoke.

In a room thick with the smell of disinfectant, an old incandescent bulb hummed and buzzed the moment it was switched on; Mai Minghe opened her eyes, but all she could see was the white cloth draped over her face — her whole field of vision a dim, hazy blur.

"Out of respect for that, I won't try to take the Artifact off you for now. But if you run into any of the other Hunters under me, and they decide to go after you, I'm not going to stop them. It's our assignment, after all — my people put their lives on the line to enter the Nest, and I have no right to ask them to give that up."

"...That part I can accept,"

Mai Minghe spoke from beneath the white sheet, her warm breath trapped in the fabric. "What I want to know is — why are we lying in the morgue pretending to be corpses?"

A few minutes earlier, the two of them had decided they were far enough from the Residents below, dropped off the hospital bed, and bolted — desperate to put as much distance between themselves and that ward as possible, to shake the Residents for good.

But as Mai Minghe ran, she glanced back over her shoulder and caught a glimpse of a dark shape flashing in the doorway of the ward — a Resident seemed to be giving chase. The red-haired man noticed too, and hissed under his breath: "Keep running and we're done for. We have to hide — follow me!"

The spindly patient was three or four meters tall and could stretch its body even further; if it was the one chasing them, the two of them had no hope of outrunning it.

What Mai Minghe hadn't expected was that the red-haired man would lead her charging straight into the stairwell, thunder down to the B1 level, and then push open a door marked "MORGUE" as though he'd been here a hundred times before.

When she hesitated, he turned and glared at her. "Get in here — what are you standing around for? You want the Residents to catch up?"

Easy for him to say — who in their right mind, seeing the word "morgue," would be eager to walk right in?

But when she watched her one and only living companion in this godforsaken place stride through the door without a second thought, Mai Minghe decided she didn't really have a choice.

The moment she stepped inside, she shuddered — a full-body shiver she couldn't suppress. The temperature in the morgue was at least three or four degrees colder than the hallway.

"Find an empty bed," the red-haired man said, flicking on the light. He pulled back the white sheet on one of the beds and lay down. "Do what I do — cover yourself from head to toe and don't move. If a bed already has someone on it, leave it alone; you'll be fine."

Mai Minghe stared at the gurney in the corner of the room. The white sheet draped over it rose and fell in the unmistakable contours of a human body. The lights flickered now and then, and she couldn't make out whether whoever — or whatever — lay there was breathing, or whether it was a person, a corpse, or a Resident.

At any rate, the figure hadn't burst upright to greet them when they came in, which she supposed counted as a good sign.

"About that..." She'd barely gotten two words out, pointing toward the gurney, when the red-haired man had already settled himself under his sheet in one swift, practiced motion. "Hurry up," he called from beneath the cloth.

In an instant, the entire morgue held only one person still standing — Mai Minghe — and two white-shrouded figures.

As she climbed onto the gurney and pulled the sheet over herself, her mind drifted into a strange haze: an eighty-six-year-old woman, first admitted to a hospital ward, now lying in the hospital morgue. It was, in its own way, perfectly in keeping with the natural order of things.

The whole evening felt almost like a metaphor. For what exactly, she wasn't wise enough to say.

The red-haired man let out a sigh beneath his sheet.

"First-timers in the Nest are nothing but trouble — they don't know anything." He kept his voice low. "Training newcomers is one of my least favorite parts of this job."

"It's not like I wanted to lie in a morgue either," Mai Minghe replied. "But as long as you're alive, you can't avoid doing things you'd rather not."

Including playing dead.

"Don't be ungrateful — the morgue is this hospital's 'Gate of Life.' Sounds absurd, doesn't it? How could the place where the dead are kept be a gate of life?"

Mai Minghe made an attentive sound immediately.

"The Nest contains countless locations, each with its own unique terrain, dangers, and opportunities. Saint Louis Hospital is a location our House Faction knows fairly well — this is my third time here. In Saint Louis Hospital—"

"Wait, this is Saint Louis Hospital?" Mai Minghe couldn't help cutting in. "You said this was the Nest — but Saint Louis Hospital isn't far from my home at all."

She'd been to Saint Louis Hospital a few times before, and she'd never seen anything like this.

"No — you're thinking of Saint Louis Hospital in Blackmoor City. What we're in right now is the Saint Louis Hospital inside the Nest.

"The Nest exists nowhere in the human world."

The red-haired man went quiet for a few seconds, as though giving that sentence time to truly sink into Mai Minghe's understanding.

"Perhaps the universe developed a crack, and the shadow that Blackmoor City cast into that crack became this Nest — a place teeming with danger and strangeness, an otherworld that only a handful of people can enter. Every place name you know from Blackmoor City, you can find in the Nest too, only almost everything here is a twisted, darkened version of the original."

As though afraid she might interrupt again, the red-haired man pressed on: "In any case, we've found that when someone in Saint Louis Hospital runs into danger they can't shake — say, when Residents have locked onto us — the morgue serves as a kind of 'reset' point."

"Reset?" Mai Minghe worked hard to absorb what he was telling her; what she couldn't fully absorb, she pressed firmly into memory.

She wasn't very fluent in young people's language — "smartphones" — oh, she supposed they weren't "clever-phones" — had taken her quite a while to figure out as it was.

"Right. Simply put: you come to the morgue, pull the sheet over your face, lie still for a while, and in the eyes of Saint Louis Hospital, you're 'dead.' The person the Residents were chasing is dead, so naturally they stop chasing. When you walk out again, you're a brand-new living person — nothing's after you anymore. It sounds like nonsense at first, but think it through and it's perfectly logical, isn't it? Someone who's been brought into the hospital morgue — of course the hospital forgets about them quickly."

"It's the same in life," Mai Minghe murmured. "The ones who forget you aren't just hospitals."

"That's exactly why I brought you here," the red-haired man concluded. "Be grateful — if you were a Hunter from any other House Faction, I'd never have brought you along so easily."

"Why not?"

"Same trade, natural rivals."

Mai Minghe began to understand. These people called themselves Hunters, and the Hunters seemed to be divided into many House Factions. They had no way of knowing whether rival factions had learned that the morgue was a reset point; if they hadn't, there was every reason to keep that valuable piece of information to themselves.

"But why do you come to the Nest at all...?"

"My dear," the red-haired man gave a short laugh, "feel the Artifact on your stomach, and ask yourself why you think. The effects an Artifact can achieve are endless — anything from raising your IQ by five points to rewriting your fate entirely, from the wildly practical to the utterly impossible. But Artifacts only exist in the Nest. Back in Blackmoor City, there's no shortage of powerful people — businessmen, politicians — willing to pay a fortune for them. Where there's demand, there's supply; economics is what drives us all into the Nest."

He paused, then said: "And that's why we're called Artifact Hunters."

Artifact Hunters...

To think that in the very Blackmoor City she'd lived in her whole life, there had always been people like this — chasing, buying, and selling things as fantastical as a dream...

And now, through her own carelessness, she had stumbled into the world beyond the world, and been handed a second life.

Mai Minghe lay on the morgue gurney, her heart thumping loud and steady.

What astonished her was that she felt no fear, no urge to flee back home. Instead she felt like a child who had wandered into an amusement park in the dead of night — the darkness was its own realm, the silhouettes of the rides strange and unsettling in the dark, yet utterly irresistible in their vast and peculiar wonder.

The Nest... In the deep, shadow-drenched blackness of the night, a fairground where she might climb onto a spinning carousel horse and gallop off toward some unimaginable land.

"I never imagined..." she said softly. "That I would ever fall into a place like this."

Compared to tonight, everything that had come before — an entire lifetime — suddenly felt shrunken and drained of color.

"It's understandable that you didn't know the Nest existed before now. People who manage to open a passage and stumble into the Nest entirely by luck, without any guidance from someone experienced — that's rare—"

"Passage?" Mai Minghe seized on the word and nearly bolted upright from the gurney like a revived corpse. "After I ran into the TV screen, I fell straight into the ward. Was that — was that my 'passage'?"

The red-haired man considered this, then gave a low "hm."

"So that's how you got in... You'd never run into a television screen before, had you?"

Of course not — nobody goes around headbutting their TV for no reason.

"Every Hunter's passage is different." The red-haired man gave a short laugh. "Of all humanity, only one percent are born with a passage — a channel that can lead them into the Nest. The conditions vary from person to person, and most of them are pretty strange and finicky. So even within that one percent, any number of people live out their entire lives without ever triggering their passage, never knowing the Nest exists at all..."

Wasn't that exactly her? Eighty-six years, right up until the thief broke through her door—

Mai Minghe felt a jolt.

...Right. That thief was an Artifact Hunter too.

"Some people have relatively ordinary passages," the red-haired man went on. "I've heard of someone who could enter the Nest just by sitting down in a bathtub full of water. Not that his luck was particularly good — think about it: the first time you take a bath, you're young, you're naked,

you haven't got a thing with you. What kind of chance do you have of making it back out of the Nest alive?"

"And then there are people with trickier passages — standing inside a toilet bowl while it flushes, opening a door in an abandoned building... all sorts of things, too many to list. Just triggering the passage already weeds out a huge number of people with how demanding the conditions are. And that's before you factor in the other important requirement for entering the Nest."

"What requirement?"

"You have to be in a city with a population of over ten million before a passage can open. We don't know exactly why, but..."

The red-haired man said quietly, "The general belief among Hunters is that the Nest is a byproduct born once human civilization reached a certain scale. So it's only in the most densely populated places that a connection to the Nest can form."

Mai Minghe lay still for a moment.

Every word he had spoken was like a piece of a puzzle, slowly assembling in her mind into a deep world she had never thought to imagine. She dearly wanted to reach up and touch her temple — the spot that had swollen from colliding with the television screen — just to confirm she wasn't dreaming.

"All right,"

There was a soft rustle of fabric nearby — it sounded like the red-haired man pulling back his sheet and sitting up. "That should be long enough — the reset ought to be complete. If you want to hold on to your Artifact, you'd better make sure my companions don't spot you."

This young man wasn't without his warmer side.

"That Artifact of mine — are you planning to hand it over to Wellesley?" Mai Minghe asked.

"That's right, he's the one who hired us," the red-haired man said, startled, turning to look at her. "How do you know about that?"

"He's already dead — he's in no position to buy any Artifact now." Mai Minghe thought back to the relentless news coverage on television over the past two days. "Haven't you heard? When did you enter the Nest?"

The red-haired man gave her a sideways look, then turned away.

It was plain he didn't believe her.

The Artifact Wellesley wanted had conveniently ended up in her hands, and now she was immediately claiming that Wellesley was dead and couldn't purchase it anymore — it was a little too neat, a little too convenient. No wonder he wasn't buying it.

"Ha — he's not about to die. The Artifacts he has are incredibly powerful—" The red-haired man stopped mid-sentence, rubbed his nose, and let the thought drop. "Whether he's alive or dead doesn't matter — I told you, I'm not going to take it from you. My advice is to get back to Blackmoor City as fast as you can."

"How do I get back?"

As terrifying and enthralling as the Nest was, Mai Minghe knew that the smart move right now — if he wanted to hold onto the Artifact — was to get out while he could.

"Ugh, honestly..." The red-haired man let his shoulders sag, looking a little deflated. "In for a penny, in for a pound — I'll take you to the exit. But let's get one thing straight: the moment a House Faction Hunter spots us, I'll have no choice but to side with them and take that Artifact right off you."

Greetings, dear readers — what you are now witnessing is yet another divine transmission from on high; seeing as I have already ascended the throne, doesn't that make this a decree from Heaven itself?

Day in and day out, it's nothing but power struggles — one moment I'm crowned and on top, the next I'm toppled and hitting the floor.

I have a question churning around inside me (sorry, it's not a baby): I've been seeing readers mention that Qidian now places a lot of weight on something called "chase-read" numbers — what exactly is that? Does it literally mean the number of people actively following updates? What happens if it's too low? How high is high enough? Does my own count count... Writing a novel is nerve-wracking enough as it is.

Chapter 14 — Chase: Sky and Sea, Vast and Boundless

"...AED defibrillator, cardiac stimulant, epinephrine,"

The lavish neon glow of the distant shore fell into the water, pushed and scattered by the waves, gradually dissolving into patches of dim amber and spectral green that shimmered across the surface, rocking together with the hull atop the black, heaving sea.

"Last one — broad-spectrum antibiotics, in case we end up out here for a while."

Each item was introduced in turn, and then a silver-white medical case snapped shut with a crisp *click*; a large hand with long fingers reached beneath the seat and pulled out a sleek black tube.

"This is a cauterizing gun. It can seal large wounds, sear through blood vessels and nerves, and keep a person from bleeding out. Very handy."

The cheerful voice was accompanied by a firm clap on the shoulder of the man sitting nearby in a white lab coat.

"Let me introduce you — Dr. Nate, a good man. Not only has he provided everything we need, but he's also willing to come in person to handle any complications... for instance, once I've removed your limbs, he'll make sure you neither die nor lose consciousness."

Dr. Nate didn't say a word. His lips were pressed into a tight line, his face contorted beyond recognition, a sickly pallor washing over him — he looked like a smear of fog dissolving into the night.

The cauterizing gun was set aside, and two hands came together in a loud, sharp clap. "Come on, say thank you to Dr. Nate."

The response was a muffled, inarticulate cry — a man with his limbs bound behind his back, wrapped from head to toe in tape so thoroughly that only his eyes and nostrils were visible, thrashing desperately, rocking the small boat with him so that it swayed back and forth, stirring soft ripples in the water.

"I'll answer for Dr. Nate — you're welcome, it's the least he could do."

The man in the expensive suit, tall and broad, his smile never faltering, leaned forward and gave the bound man an amiable pat.

His black hair was swept back, sleek and perfectly in place, catching faint glimmers of light in the dark above the water.

"Don't be in such a rush — I'm not done yet."

He spread his pale hands open wide, then flipped and curled his right hand with effortless ease, pulling a heavy barbell plate from beneath the seat. "Every arm and leg we take off will be tied to one of these — twenty-five kilograms apiece. You can watch your own limbs go *splash*, sinking down into the sea..."

He let out a low whistle, fingers dancing nimbly in the air, swaying from high to low like a school of fish gliding down into the depths.

"...Just like that."

The man mummified in tape let out another garbled, heavy groan — like a wild animal sealed inside a bag, fighting to get out.

The suited man leaned back against his seat, studying his captive with languid, appraising eyes.

"Ready to start talking?"

The bound man twisted frantically: "Mmph — mmph!"

The suited man flicked open a knife, gauged the approximate location of the mouth, and drove the blade sharply through the tape in a single deep slash — blood and a shriek of agony burst into the night air at the same instant.

Slender fingers pushed into the bloody slit in the tape and extracted a large wad of medical cotton.

The moment it left his mouth, gasping breaths and dry heaves spilled out in broken bursts: "You — who are you? What do you want—"

The suited man leaned in close, fixing his gaze on his prey, both eyes so black they reflected nothing at all.

"Whatever you want, I'll cooperate — there's no need to go this far..." As the bound man spoke, the cut on his lips tore wider, twisting his face with pain; his face glistened wetly in the darkness. "I'm just a nobody — I'm nothing to anyone..."

"That's the wrong thing to say."

The suited man raised one index finger, cutting him off. "A nobody, like a bit-part actor in a film — dies and that's that, no one cares. If you want me to let you go, you first have to make me care about you. Isn't that right?"

The bound man went still for a moment.

"You might be wondering — how do I make you care? Well, I'd have to understand you first, wouldn't I? I'd have to empathize with you as a person."

The suited man laced his long fingers together, pale as a white bridge arching through the dark. The face of his watch caught the faintest sliver of light, a half-arc gleaming softly in the night.

"So. Tell me — who are **you**?"

"I... my name is Evan. I'm twenty-nine years old, and I grew up—"

"No, I don't want a résumé — that's dull." The suited man cut him off, his tone encouraging. "I want to know: what are the hopes in your life? The losses? What are your dreams?"

Evan, his face streaked with blood and tears, stared blankly. "My — my dreams...?"

"Yes. Surely you don't plan to spend the rest of your life as Wellesley's bodyguard?"

Evan jolted, and a flash of dawning recognition lit his eyes.

"Could this have something to do with Mr. Wellesley—"

"What's more," the suited man paid him no mind and went on, "Wellesley died a sudden death yesterday, and today you find yourself in this position — not much of a bodyguard, really. Better to find a new line of work."

"I don't know anything..."

"Don't waste your energy." The suited man's thin lips parted like a blade, cutting into a smile. "A person who can't engage my interest is nothing but a sack of skin, and I have no particular feelings about how many pieces of it end up at the bottom of the sea."

Silence fell over the boat for a few seconds.

"Talk."

Evan could never have dreamed, even in his worst nightmares, that he would find himself in circumstances like these, laying bare the contents of his heart.

"I — all right. My dream... is to become someone like Mr. Wellesley..."

"The richest man in the city? A state senator? Winner of the Distinguished Contribution Award on the Climate Temperature Issue?" the suited man asked with a smile. "...Or the true power behind Blackmoor City?"

Evan only nodded without speaking. He stared vacantly at the distant Blackmoor City skyline — the neon advertisements along the shore, the towering skyscrapers. Across the central bay blazing with a thousand lights, black waves lapped gently at the little boat, nudging it this way and that.

"Good." The suited man nodded. "And what have you done to pursue that dream?"

"I haven't done anything," Evan came back to himself and said quickly, "Mr. Wellesley's death had nothing to do with me..."

"Wrong direction." A pale hand swept through the darkness with the air of a director giving notes to an actor. "I didn't say you had anything to do with his death — but are you telling me you took no action at all after he died?"

"I don't understand..."

"A character with ambitions but no actions — spineless, soft, impossible to sympathize with." The suited man sounded almost exasperated, as though furious at iron that refused to become steel. "If you won't even help yourself, why should I give you a break?"

Evan parted his bleeding lips, hesitated for a few seconds, and finally said, tentatively: "After Mr. Wellesley died... I didn't leave. I stayed. Does that count for anything?"

"Oh?"

"Mr. Wellesley had dismissed me the night before," Evan said quickly. "I was supposed to go, but I didn't want to leave the estate, so I told no one."

"Why did he dismiss you?"

"Bad luck, is all." Evan's glistening, wet mouth went still. After a moment, he said quietly: "It wasn't anything serious... I only tried on a pair of trousers..."

The suited man raised one eyebrow and one corner of his mouth. "Trousers?"

"Yes, yes... once you hear the whole thing, you'll understand." He paused, then said suddenly: "Did you know Mr. Wellesley had a very soft voice? When I first started working for him, I was

surprised — someone that important, I'd always assumed he'd speak loudly."

Evan's teeth were stained red with blood, but he seemed to have forgotten the wound; once he started, he couldn't stop.

"Later I came to understand — because his voice was quiet, everyone else had to listen with their full attention. When he spoke, he wasn't concerned with whether others could hear him. That was the listener's problem to worry about.

"You see, even the rise and fall of his volume was deliberate, was artistry... So in my spare time, I slowly began to carry myself the way Mr. Wellesley did, to dress the way he did. I even found a cologne close to his scent. I could feel the difference — the way people looked at me when I went out."

The suited man passed Evan a cigarette.

He took a drag; in the dim dark above the water, the tip glowed red for a moment; his cheek spasmed again with pain, but his tone and expression steadied considerably.

"This past stretch, Mr. Wellesley and a number of us staff had been living at the uptown estate. Two nights ago, he went to a banquet — it was my rotation off, so I didn't go with him. When he came back unexpectedly early, I happened — of all the bad timing in the world — to be in his room, in the middle of putting on a pair of trousers. He walked right in on me.

"He probably assumed I'd been having an affair in there... his face went purple as a bruise. But how could I have done something like that? He didn't believe me — shoved me aside, went through the bathroom and the dressing room, checked every corner, before he finally confirmed I'd genuinely been alone..."

Evan gave a bitter smile. "And that was when he realized — the trousers I was wearing were his. I only wanted to know what it felt like to wear them... But he flew into a rage on the spot, dismissed me then and there, and told me to pack my things and be gone by the next morning."

The suited man threw his head back and laughed, the sound deep and resonant, crashing against the night air.

"Entertaining — but nothing more." His large hand patted the cauterizing gun. "You want to reach the heights of wealth and power, and the action you took was secretly trying on someone else's trousers? With that kind of effort, what could you ever actually accomplish?"

"It isn't that simple—"

Evan was stung into anger for a moment, and blood sprayed as he argued.

"Imitating his clothes and manner is only one part of it. I never let an opportunity for real action pass me by either. Yesterday, the moment I heard Mr. Wellesley had died in the study, I realized immediately — the fact that I'd been dismissed hadn't gotten out yet. Only Mr. Wellesley and I knew. Now that he was dead, if I said nothing, it was as if the dismissal had never happened. No one would ever know.

"So I got to the study door as fast as I could. On the surface I was pretending to secure the scene and wait for the police, but actually I was quietly—"

Evan stopped short.

The night settled into nothing but the slap of waves and the thick, labored rasp of his breathing.

The suited man fixed his gaze on Evan and slowly leaned forward, like a great python lowering itself inch by inch from a branch.

"So... you went inside the study." His voice dropped low.

Evan seemed to realize it then — that when an interrogator never reveals their purpose, the person being interrogated will make mistakes they didn't even know they shouldn't make.

"...And what happened when you went in?"

When Evan refused to answer, the suited man raised both hands. There in the murky expanse between dark sky and dark sea, they loomed like two enormous pale fans — each large enough to cover an adult man's entire face.

"Strange, isn't it? I showed you all the first-aid supplies but never showed you what I'd use to take your limbs off. That's because I only remembered when we got on the boat — I forgot to bring the electric saw. Fortunately, I have some confidence in the strength of my hands... score a line through the skin, and you can peel it back layer by layer. The bones are even simpler — wedge the limb against the edge of the boat and one good stomp will snap it clean."

In the darkness, the suited man's mouth spread open in a soundless grin, rows of white teeth sharp and perfectly even.

"Why did you go into the study?"

This time, Evan answered quickly. "I — I only wanted to see if there was anything worth taking... what if there was something valuable? I saw a watch..."

"Why did you go into the study?" The suited man's hand came to rest, gently, on Evan's arm.

Evan swallowed a mouthful of mixed blood and saliva.

"You likely already know — what disappeared from Wellesley's study is not something that belongs to this world. Anyone who touches it when they shouldn't will end up exactly as you are now: swallowed up and swept along by the fate it brings... sky and sea, vast and boundless, and no way out."

The suited man closed his eyes, drew a long, slow breath through his nose, pulling in the salt-tang of the sea, the petrol smell of the boat engine, and Evan's fear — all of it, deep into his lungs.

When he spoke again, his voice had gone hoarse.

"The Artifact from the study — where have you hidden it?"

The great ordeal begins today... Yesterday, the moment I landed, I got a text saying my connecting flight had been cancelled — so I scrambled to refund and rebook, only to find no flights were available, and now I have to travel to Guangzhou first to catch a flight out. An extra leg of the journey out of nowhere, and a big chunk of time gone with it.

The days ahead are going to be hectic, exhausting, and miserable. Adjust to the time difference? What a luxury that would be — a blink counts as a full night's sleep around here.

Ugh.

All I want is to go home and burrow in for a solid year — ideally with a brand-new e-ink tablet tucked in my arms.

Chapter 15: Chase, Hunter Among Men

Chase drew a silver comb from his suit pocket and slowly worked a loose strand of hair back behind his head.

The comb was small, set with emeralds that threw off a deep, clear light — light that sank into his black hair and shattered between the strands.

The finest and most luxurious things in this world existed to be used. Chase would never lock a comb away in a jewelry case simply because it happened to be a priceless antique.

"I stripped his clothes off with my own hands."

Chase leaned back against his chair and continued. "I don't mind finding a new use for a cauterizing gun, but Dr. Nate was worried I'd be too heavy-handed and puncture the man's intestines, so he did the inspection himself. I watched the whole time — I can say with certainty that bodyguard had nothing on him."

Across from him, Rolan Kay let out a low "mm."

He was past sixty, his hair faded to iron-grey, like the thick morning fog of an overcast day. Deep wrinkles had carved a hard, expressionless face, and his two pale-blue eyes always seemed to be watching from somewhere far away, deep in the mist.

In his presence, Chase sometimes still felt like a small child.

"What about the bodyguard's home?"

"I got back from there just this morning — there isn't a single unbroken tile left." Chase thought for a few seconds, then went on: "I searched the car too. Nothing. I also checked the driving records and surveillance footage — after he left the estate, he drove straight home, and never went out again before I found him. Other than the pizza delivery guy, he hadn't met with anyone. If he hid the Artifacts at the estate —"

"There's nothing left at the estate," Rolan Kay said quietly. "The new Hunter swept the place."

Chase nodded, knitting his thick dark brows.

"Four Artifacts vanished from Wellesley's study, and that bodyguard didn't get his hands on a single one?" Rolan Kay asked.

Chase stared at the ceiling and thought for a moment.

"No," he murmured. "He got to them — he got at least one."

"How do you know?"

Chase sat up, a restless irritation moving through him. His large, pale hands were locked tightly together, knuckles raised, a few veins standing out across the backs. Along the edges of his nails ran a faint smear of dark reddish-black grime he hadn't yet had the chance to clean away.

"I searched everywhere a person could possibly hide something, and found no Artifacts. That man had no backbone — one broken left arm and he was already begging me to search his home, his car. Without me even asking, he volunteered the address of his sister who lives outside the city."

He pulled out a few banknotes, folded them into two small stacks, rolled them up, and used the sharp corners to slowly clean the grime from under his nails.

"My search was thorough — I'm confident I missed nothing. But as I sat watching him on that boat, a feeling gradually took hold of me... I can't explain it, but I simply knew." Chase fixed his gaze on the dark-red smudge at the corner of the rolled bills. "He'd gotten hold of an Artifact."

Even in the grip of terror and pain, desperate beyond measure to escape that little boat — to escape Chase — there had been something about Evan, something... something hard to name, like bone, that had held up the weeping, convulsing, howling man and made him clench his teeth and keep the secret.

Those who had seen another world seemed to carry a slight distance from the reality in front of them. Even bodily pain, at first, felt as though it came from behind a layer of cotton wool.

Chase had felt that quality before — in Hunters who had just come back from the Nest.

Evan was no Hunter; he had only brushed up against another reality through an Artifact, and so he carried only a faint, vague trace of that same quality.

But under ordinary circumstances, he wouldn't have held out much longer.

The moment that thought struck him, Chase's hands twisted against each other in a sudden surge of frustration.

However precious an Artifact might be, it was worth less than life and limb; even a rare Artifact capable of bringing a person to the pinnacle of wealth and power was not something anyone would willingly be reduced to a human stump for.

In the small hours of last night, Evan had sat naked in a pool of blood, shaking violently in the cold sea wind, his left arm broken in several places and wrenched from its socket at the shoulder where a wound gaped open, hanging a good length lower than his right.

One look at him and Chase had known — no need to go any further. He was not far from his breaking point.

By any measure, Evan was not a man who could hold out under pressure.

A few more minutes and he would have talked — but at precisely that moment, a light suddenly pierced the pitch-black curtain of night above the sea in the distance; the engine of a large speedboat roared and cleaved through the waves, pushing that light steadily into Chase's field of vision.

Dr. Nate jerked his head up and said in a low voice, "Is that the — the Coast Guard?"

From what Chase knew, the Coast Guard didn't usually appear at this hour in this location — but out of caution, he set down the bloodied barbell plate in his hand all the same; it hit the deck with a dull thud, making the hull shudder.

"Get down," he ordered the bodyguard, then turned: "Doctor, pass me the cover cloth from under the seat."

The canvas normally used to cover the boat — he slung it over Evan from above, covering the pale, naked body and the dark, bloody mess together.

Chase stepped over the shivering, rustling cloth in a single stride, took a can of beer from the cooler, tossed it to Dr. Nate, and said, "Drink."

The crisp snap of the ring-pull was swallowed by the engine's rising roar; dimly, Chase could already make out that the approaching vessel was a large speedboat, very much in the style of a Coast Guard craft. By the look of it, within a few minutes it would come bearing down and pass across their bow.

"Wonderful — the taxes I pay, coming to get in my way."

Chase muttered this as he sat down and picked up a fishing rod from the deck, not even bothering to cast the line.

That night the sky was thick with cloud, not a star or moon to be seen; visibility on the water was almost nothing — a few meters out, the eye simply fell into black void.

If the other vessel didn't swing a searchlight their way, they wouldn't be able to make out a fishing line, let alone how many people were on board; the cover cloth, the beer, and the fishing rod were precautions against a slim possibility, nothing more.

Boats out night-fishing at two or three in the morning were few, but the central bay was never short of private pleasure craft, and the Coast Guard vessel seemed to have a different quarry altogether — it went straight on past, showing not the slightest interest in Chase's little boat, without even slowing down.

The large speedboat, driving fast, threw up wave after wave that lifted the small craft and sent it plunging back down, tossing it without mercy — and somewhere in that rolling swell, Chase suddenly cursed under his breath and was on his feet in an instant, spinning and lunging toward the cover cloth.

He lost his footing and slammed into the railing, but he barely seemed to register the impact; he swept his arm out, and one large hand with its long fingers came down on the cloth and seized it.

"What is it?"

Over Dr. Nate's startled cry and the crash of waves against the hull, Chase drove his palm down onto the heaving, shifting cloth and closed his fist around it — Chase had full confidence in the strength of his grip. If he locked onto someone's hand, they were not getting free unless they were willing to lose the limb, like a gecko shedding its tail.

And yet Evan still managed to slip away.

The whole thing had happened so fast that Chase only worked out how Evan had escaped after the fact, piecing it together in hindsight.

Evan had used the rocking of the waves to crawl out from under the cloth toward the railing, hoping to throw himself overboard while Chase was distracted; Chase noticed in time and lunged, pressing him down and hauling him backward — but with the boat pitching in the swell, and the

cloth between them, Chase hadn't anticipated that what he'd grabbed was the very arm he himself had broken and torn open.

The yank on that shoulder ripped open the wound Chase had only just cauterized and sealed, tearing it wide again in an instant; a long, agonized scream rang out from the railing, slicing sharply into the night.

Along with the cry, blood came pouring freely from the body.

The pain was unbearable — but it was precisely because of all that blood as lubrication that Evan was finally able to wrench his broken arm free with one violent pull in the moment the waves rolled the boat, roll himself over the side, and drop into the sea. The whole thing lasted no more than two or three seconds; yet by the time Chase reached the railing and swept his gaze around, the bodyguard had already gone under — gone from sight entirely.

The night was black and the sea was vast; even with a flashlight, he could see no more than a few meters into the churning water.

Trailing one injured arm, Evan would still only need to hold his breath underwater for a short stretch to move beyond Chase's range of visibility.

"He thought he could swim back to Blackmoor City with a wounded, bleeding arm?"

Chase tried to smile, but found every muscle in his face heavy and still. "He most likely drowned in the central bay long ago — no telling where the current has carried him by now. I'll keep an eye out over the next few days for any reports of a body being found."

"You're going to wait on news from a dead man before you know how to move forward?" Rolan Kay gave a small smile and asked.

"No — of course not, Uncle Kai."

Chase couldn't help it — even his voice dropped. "I'm planning to find his sister. And the pizza delivery clerk."

Rolan Kay, however, seemed to have no interest in his next steps. He took a sip of black coffee and said, "Anything visible on the surface, anything that lets you see it — that's not where something is hidden."

Chase forced himself to swallow those words.

He had nothing to say.

Before Evan had jumped overboard, Chase had already taken his keys, his phone, his documents — even his important passwords. All that had escaped was a naked body. By all reasoning, even if the bodyguard had fled, as long as he'd hidden the thing somewhere he'd actually been, Chase should eventually be able to trace it.

And yet Chase had searched every hiding place he could think of, and still come away empty-handed.

Where exactly had he missed?

Chase's hands had been twisting and pressing against each other without his noticing; only now did he realize that the banknotes he'd been using to clean his nails had been reduced to a scatter of fine shreds, drifting down into the carpet in little flecks — and he felt a flush of embarrassment.

"Uncle Kai, let me get the vacuum cleaner. The handheld one — is it still in the usual place?"

He had barely started to rise when Rolan Kay said, "No hurry. Sit down."

Though puzzled, Chase sat back down.

"Violence works in both directions," Rolan Kay said slowly. "The force of a blow you land on another person — however unavoidably — reverberates back into your own tendons, your own bones, your own core. That's why men who do the beating in an interrogation either start out dulled and brutish, or gradually become dulled and brutish through the violence itself."

A warm, tingling ache spread outward from the center of Chase's palms and reached his chest.

"I'll be careful, Uncle Kai," Chase said, genuinely grateful. "A bit of blood — that I can handle."

"That's not what I mean."

Something dropped in Chase's chest. He waited for what Rolan Kay would say next the way you wait for a fist that's about to bury itself in your gut.

"A dulled, brutal enforcer is the least valuable thing in this line of work," Rolan Kay said. "You grew up at my side. I had expected you to operate with more intelligence than this."

It was only after a brief, suspended moment that Chase remembered to breathe.

"If a Hunter House Faction is to grow in strength, the Nest is only the foundation. What truly matters is how we establish ourselves and act in the world of men — how we build influence. A truly powerful House Faction holds dominion over the 'reality' that every one of us is obliged to live within."

From deep in his throat, Rolan Kay let out a low, heavy laugh.

"...And yet dominion over 'reality' cannot be won by violence and bloodshed alone. Don't tell me that's the only card you have to play."

Chase hadn't known his own head could feel so heavy; for a moment he wanted nothing more than to sink it deep into his hands — and not because he'd been awake all night.

He knew Rolan Kay wasn't angry, but he would have preferred the man to rage at him, to question and berate him for failing to get it done.

Chase stood a full head taller than Rolan Kay now, trained and formidable in a fight, a man even Hunters were wary of. Yet when Rolan Kay was disappointed in him, Chase still felt that drowning sensation of being plunged into ice water — because he could not stop being disappointed in himself.

He stared at his own hands; faint pale scars ran across the backs, stretching away to disappear beneath his watchband and cuffs.

In his youth, desperate to locate his own passage, Chase had conducted many experiments on himself, leaving behind various scars and hidden injuries across his body.

Only one percent of humanity possessed a "passage" — an innate conduit that let a person enter the Nest. No one knew what form their passage would take; they simply had to try one method after another. He had worked through every known means of entry, testing each in turn, and still he stood rooted in the mortal world, unable to catch so much as a glimpse of the Nest.

He was thirty years old now, and he still couldn't forget the look on Uncle Kai's face the day he finally accepted that Chase had no passage — eyelids dropping, not a single word spoken.

It was like watching a work of art shatter on the floor, only to reveal the cheap foam padding stuffed inside.

The scar on the back of his hand wasn't from the experiments. It was from after — after the last test, Chase had taken a hunting knife and cut it there himself. He didn't really know why. Maybe, in that moment, he'd thought he could slice a passage open that way.

"I understand," Chase said, and realized his voice had come out rough. He cleared his throat. "Uncle Kai, I made you a promise — everything on this side of the world, the mortal side, I will deliver it into your hands."

He couldn't enter the Nest. But he could become a Hunter in the mortal world — seizing every scrap of power and wealth this world had to offer and laying it all at the feet of the Kai family.

Because what Uncle Kai truly wanted, he could never give him.

Chapter 16 — Chase and the Artifact Lost in the Metropolis

"Based on the surveillance footage we obtained,"

Chase said as he drove, "Evan left the gates of the Wellesley Family Estate at 7:21 a.m. on November 16th and never looked back."

Of course the bodyguard had no intention of going back either — the moment he'd stolen the Artifact, he put his job out of his mind entirely, left without a word to anyone, and made straight for Blackmoor City.

"What about his movements after he left the estate? How are you confirming those?" The young woman in the passenger seat wore her hair in long, thick dreadlocks dyed a deep violet, cascading over her shoulders like a tumbling armful of lavender.

"His GPS records are in my hands. The route we're driving right now is the exact route he took on the 16th."

The young woman paused at that and glanced over at him.

"I know," Chase said, his expression unchanged. "The fact that a route is logged in his GPS doesn't mean he actually drove it."

"Right — I've heard you have to pull the route data from the manufacturer to know exactly where someone went," the woman with the dreadlocks replied. "That's not easy without police resources, is it?"

Generally speaking, that was true.

But Chase had always had unusually good luck.

He quickly discovered that a grocery store sat directly across from Evan's apartment building. Because the owner lived on the second floor, a smart security camera had been installed at the entrance, recording all comings and goings.

Posing as a police officer, Chase had no trouble pulling the footage from the time window he needed — at 10:47 that morning, Evan's car had rolled down the street, cruised around for a bit, and snagged a parking spot.

It had been a Saturday, so there was no rush-hour traffic. Evan had taken 3 hours and 26 minutes to travel from the upper district to Blackmoor City — only thirteen minutes more than the GPS estimate. Given the drizzly weather that day, a difference of a dozen or so minutes was well within normal range.

"If he'd taken any other route, the timing wouldn't have lined up this closely."

Every other GPS route would have added at least twenty minutes, and the numbers simply wouldn't match. Besides, Evan had been fleeing with stolen goods — by all logic, he would have wanted to move as fast as possible and wouldn't have gone out of his way.

That meant the possibility that Evan had made a detour somewhere along the way — to his sister's place, say, or to a rented storage unit — to hand the Artifact off to someone else for safekeeping was essentially ruled out. A window of just over ten minutes wasn't nearly enough time for any of that.

But what if Evan had called his sister ahead of time and arranged for her to wait somewhere along his route?

He could have simply passed a package out through the car window as he drove by — a delay so brief it would never show up in the driving record.

That hypothesis, however, was quickly demolished by Chase himself.

He had everything of Evan's in his possession, and it had been trivial to pull the call records from the carrier. Evan hadn't made a single outgoing call that morning, and he hadn't been in contact with his sister in the days surrounding the incident either. In fact, Evan's entire call log for the 16th contained only two entries: the first was an incoming call from the head of the bodyguard team demanding to know why he had abandoned his post without notice; the second was an outgoing call that afternoon to a pizza place, ordering a large pepperoni.

No one was going to hand over a priceless Artifact to a delivery driver they'd never met.

If the two had known each other, that might be a different story — but according to the Hunter sent to investigate, the delivery driver had absolutely no connection to Evan.

It was possible Evan had used another phone, though there was currently no evidence to support that — and besides, Evan didn't seem like the kind of person capable of thinking that many steps ahead.

Regardless, Chase still had to exhaust every possibility.

He had to bring back what Grandpa Kai wanted and deliver it to the House Faction — and before that single objective, no obstacle could be allowed to remain one.

"Mr. Monroe, I have a question—" the young woman with the dreadlocks said.

"Chase is fine," he cut her off. "When other Hunters call me Mr. Monroe, it means they know they're in trouble."

Sydney Ginn hadn't been with the House Faction long — she had previously been an unremarkable Hunter of no particular reputation — but a short while ago she had suddenly surged in renown and become a highly sought-after talent. Since she'd been recruited into the Kai household, today was the first time Chase had met her in person.

As far as Chase knew, such transformations in Hunters weren't unheard of.

The Nest was a place of ten thousand shapes and endless strangeness. Beyond the Artifacts that could be brought back into the world, Hunters might encounter creatures, rules, domains, and things so utterly beyond definition that no imagination could catalogue them all. Those encounters produced any number of consequences and effects — not all of them beneficial, of course.

The vast majority were not.

But every so often, there were lucky ones like Sydney who drew the winning lot — Hunters who returned from the Nest one day simply possessing abilities they hadn't had before.

"Chase," she corrected herself. "I surveyed the Wellesley Family Estate thoroughly, and I can confirm there isn't a single Artifact left anywhere on or around the grounds. On the drive here, I didn't sense any Artifact presence either. That does support the idea that the bodyguard took it with him and made straight for Blackmoor City after stealing it — that part's all well and good.

"But why did he just shut himself inside his apartment after he got home? If he stole the Artifact, he must have understood what it meant, what it was worth — he had to have known people would come after him. If it were me, I'd have grabbed what I needed and run the moment I got home. Actually, I probably wouldn't have gone home at all. I'd have left everything behind."

Before answering, Chase tilted his chin toward the window.

Outside, a heavy overcast sky pressed down in shades of iron and grey, scowling as though threatening to rain at any moment. Beneath it, a dark smudge of dull-green forest streamed steadily past.

"Well? Anything?"

Sydney furrowed her brow, held still for two seconds, then said, "It overlaps a lot with my last detection sweep... still nothing."

Chase glanced at the time and said nothing.

He had no idea how Sydney perceived Artifacts.

In principle, the ability to sense Artifacts was a foundational and invaluable asset for any Hunter — but the problem was that Sydney's detection accuracy was simply terrible.

He had been driving at fifty kilometers an hour for several minutes now, and they still hadn't left the radius of her last sweep.

By rough estimate, her Artifact detection range was approximately five kilometers in every direction — and as for where exactly within those five kilometers any given Artifact might be hiding, only heaven knew.

Was a detection method this vague really something that a Hunter's House Faction had to go out of its way to recruit?

Chase had never set foot inside a Nest himself, so he had no answer to that question.

"Evan was a man with a certain low cunning."

He turned his thoughts back to the present, eyes fixed on the road ahead, and answered, "He knew people would be tracking down the Artifacts that disappeared from the study, so he gambled against fate — he bet he could slip through the cracks."

"Slip through the cracks?"

"If a former bodyguard bolted the moment Wellesley died, everyone would immediately know something was wrong. Not to mention, nobody knows yet whether Wellesley's death was natural or not. What if it was murder? Running would tie him to Wellesley's death as well.

"If Wellesley was killed, a fleeing Evan would draw the attention of three different parties.

"First, the police, investigating the cause of death. Second, whoever murdered Wellesley, who wouldn't want anyone finding leads. Third, every Hunter faction suspecting him of stealing the Artifacts."

Sydney nodded slowly. "That's fair... He was better off playing dumb. Even if he was going to run eventually, he should at least ride out the first few days quietly without drawing attention."

"Exactly. He couldn't stay at the estate — that would be the first place anyone looking for the Artifacts would search. Wellesley had dismissed Evan before he died, so Evan had a perfectly good excuse to leave. And since four Artifacts went missing and he probably only took one, as long as he kept his head down, there was no guarantee anyone would come knocking on his door."

"So how did you end up at his door?" Sydney asked, genuinely curious.

"...Lucky, I suppose."

"Lucky? I don't believe in luck," Sydney said, watching the road ahead with a smile.

"Everything I have, I earned myself."

What a very young answer that was.

The Nest was no elementary school teacher. The Nest never rewarded sheer effort — but Chase kept that thought to himself.

"Is that so? Then I suppose you won't mind the things other Hunters say about me."

"What things?"

"That the reason my luck is so good is because I drain the luck from the people around me."

Sydney probably thought he was joking — she laughed and studied Chase for a moment — but the amusement passed over her face like a cloud shadow, dimming and dropping away, leaving her quiet.

Anyone who'd made it as a Hunter had sharper instincts than the average person, in one way or another.

Following the GPS route, Chase took the off-ramp and crossed into Blackmoor City proper.

A forest of modern towers built from glass and steel; classical buildings that had settled and stood through past centuries; neon advertisements layered in shifting light and shadow; office workers striding briskly along the pavements; tourists on the upper decks of red double-decker buses, phones held aloft — piece by piece, like a puzzle assembling itself before his eyes, the most prosperous, most vibrant, most gloriously varied metropolis in the world spread itself out ahead of him.

Chase had lived in Blackmoor City for thirty years, and all his accumulated knowledge of the place probably amounted to less than the tip of an iceberg; alongside the vast, teeming, endlessly varied population came an uncertainty — the absolute unknowability of what the next moment might bring — and Chase had never once thought about leaving Blackmoor City, not only because of the Kai household, but because he needed that uncertainty the way he needed air to breathe.

If every day of a person's life were identical to the last, then as far as he was concerned they were already dead — just waiting to be buried.

To cut down on interference, Sydney closed her eyes and rolled down her window, as if she were listening to the pulse of the city itself.

"Nothing... nothing... is that Buluan 5th Street up ahead?... Nothing there either."

"Are you sure?"

Sydney's eyes snapped open. "Wait!"

Chase eased off the accelerator. The moment the car slowed, a frustrated chorus of horns erupted from the line of traffic piling up behind them.

Blackmoor City residents were not known for their patience.

"There!" Sydney's eyes went wide, her head swiveling left and right — yet a shadow of puzzlement lingered on her face. "Hold on, let me just—"

"Where?"

Sydney didn't seem to hear him. She thrust her head out the window, held perfectly still for several seconds, then dropped back into her seat with a thump.

"It's gone," she murmured. "I thought there was an Artifact somewhere close — but it's so strange. The feeling was there and gone in a flash. When I tried to focus and reach for it again, there was nothing. I swear my sense for these things is reliable — this has never happened to me before..."

There and gone in a flash?

The car crept forward. The honking and shouting from behind had been completely shut out of Chase's mind.

His attention swept outward like a searchlight, fanning across everything around him — the road, the streets, the buildings, the pedestrians, the signage — scenes he must have passed a

hundred times before, yet now each one printed itself on his mind with striking clarity, as if he were seeing them for the first time.

An Artifact that flickered and vanished — within a radius as vast as five kilometers...

His eyelid gave a sudden twitch. His gaze snagged on a round sign in the distance bearing the letter "D."

A thought took shape.

He glanced at the oncoming lane across the road, timed a gap in the traffic, and then the steering wheel snapped sharply in his hands — the car cut across half the road and swung onto the opposite lane.

In a chorus of screeching brakes, blaring horns, and furious shouts, he laid on the center of the steering wheel and kept the horn wailing without pause, the car already jumping the curb onto the sidewalk; pedestrians scattered in both directions in a panic, like waves thrown up by a speedboat's hull.

Sydney Ginn clutched the grab handle above her head in a white-knuckled grip and screamed, "What are you doing?! Where are you going?! You're going to hit someone!"

With one set of tires on the curb and the other on the road, the car lurched forward at a tilt; they blasted past a row of storefronts, startling a customer who had just stepped outside and sending coffee splashing all down his front.

The chaos erupting outside the car didn't register with Chase in the slightest.

Eyes locked on what lay ahead, he said, "I know where the Artifact is."

Hey everyone, yesterday I was up and out the door at the crack of dawn running errands, and I actually published the chapter from the car — chapter number, author's note, all of that went right out the window. First priority was getting the food on the table; I'll remember to bring silverware next time. For now, just eat with your hands — we've been through enough together by now, haven't we.

As for what I'm up to today, at this very moment I am once again on my way to the airport. If you stopped by the head offices of any major airline right now, you'd find my portrait hanging on the wall — I'm serious, go ahead and check.

About writing author's notes — I have complicated feelings. I hate to skip my usual rambling, but whenever I do post it, I keep seeing people say the author's note is more entertaining than the actual chapter, and honestly I don't know whether to be pleased about that or not. Maybe after the story goes premium I'll just post pure nonsense — does that work for everyone?

Chapter 17 — Chase: The Hunter Who Was Hunted

Yiwen was either a genius or a complete idiot.

No, Chase thought — probably some unholy mixture of the two. They say that when a fool has a flash of brilliance, even the smartest people can't keep up.

"Are you trying to get yourself killed? Don't drag me into it!" In her panic, Sydney forgot to be polite to her superior and cried out, "This isn't the Nest — this is the real world! There are consequences for driving like this. You hit someone, you go to prison — can't you hear the sirens back there?"

It had only been a few minutes since he'd blown through a string of traffic laws when he first heard the sirens.

They spiraled through the air like a ring of spinning blades, slicing the sky behind them again and again. Sometimes the wailing grew distant, and Chase thought he'd shaken a patrol car — but then it surged close again as fresh units converged from other directions and joined the chase.

Even so, the police never managed to cut him off, because they couldn't do what Chase did: mount the sidewalk without a second thought, drive the wrong way through red lights, blast through intersections as though they were empty.

Along the way, he'd lost count of how many pedestrians had flung themselves toward the curb in terror, and how many times he'd heard the shrieking friction of tires grinding against asphalt.

Everywhere the car went, it left behind a wake of chaos — running figures, blaring horns, screaming voices. Miraculously, by the time Chase finally threaded back onto the main road and floored it, he had only clipped off one side mirror and crumpled one headlight, without causing any truly irreversible disaster.

"Hold on," he said, glancing at the sweep of flashing red and blue lights behind them. "I'm about to speed up."

"More? You can't — "

Sydney never finished the sentence. The sudden surge of acceleration shoved her straight into the seatback.

Chase wrenched the wheel; the car twisted past the vehicle ahead, then cut sharply in front of it, drawing a chorus of furious honks. "That search I had you run earlier — you kept the results open, right?"

Sydney sighed and pushed her lavender-colored hair back out of her eyes.

"It's open," she said, lifting her phone into the edge of Chase's vision. Sure enough, a maps app glowed on the screen. "Fine — it's not like I'm the one driving. Where exactly are we going?"

"Buluan Community College Station," Chase said shortly, already screaming through the gap between two more cars.

"...Why?"

"When you sensed the Artifact flash by, I spotted the sign for 'Fulington Station' on the D Line. Buluan Community College Station is the D Line's last stop in this direction."

Sydney absorbed that, blinking several times in rapid succession.

"Wait — you're saying you think that bodyguard hid the Artifact at Buluan Community College Station?"

"No," Chase replied. "I think he hid it on the subway."

Sydney's jaw dropped. Two full seconds passed before she got it back up. "The subway? Blackmoor City's subway? He — you — is he out of his mind?"

Somehow, Chase had the distinct feeling that what she'd originally meant to say was closer to "Have you lost it?"

Blackmoor City's subway system was, it could be said, world-famous — just not for being busy or efficient.

Alongside the ordinary commuters and tourists, the cars were always packed with cult recruiters trolling for new disciples, vendors hawking counterfeit newspapers, people loudly announcing the deaths of public figures who were very much still alive, doomsday prophets warning that the end was nigh, and performers stripping off their clothes in public to beg for money — an endless, inexhaustible parade of strange and extraordinary characters.

People often said that the true test of whether someone was a genuine Blackmoor City local was simple: put them on the subway and see whether they could ride all the way to their stop without batting an eye.

Anyone with something to hide would never, as a first instinct, hide it somewhere like that.

And besides — once the train pulled away, how was Yiwen supposed to get it back?

"There's a lot I don't understand," Sydney said, thinking it through. "Yiwen was on the road into Blackmoor City, stopped the car, went into the station, then came right back out — that part makes sense, and he had time for it. But how do you know he hid it on the train?"

"You said the Artifact 'flashed past,' right? If your detection ability is as reliable as you claim, that means when you sensed it, it was already at the outermost edge of your range, moving fast, and it left your range within an instant.

"Which means that before you even started sensing, it had already been moving through your range for some time at a certain speed — that's the only way it could be right at the edge of your range the very moment you began to sense it, and then vanish in a flash."

Her detection range was enormous. An ordinary pedestrian, a bicycle, even a car traveling within the city speed limit — none of them could have escaped her range in any reasonable amount of time.

Based on what they'd pieced together so far, Yiwen hadn't been in contact with anyone. So within city limits, what could move continuously at high speed without being constrained by traffic, and carry the Artifact out of Sydney's detection range?

When Chase's gaze landed on the "D" sign, it came to him: Fulington Station was right there.

While they'd been searching everywhere and finding nothing, somewhere deep beneath their feet, a subway train was thundering away into the distance — Artifact on board.

The possibility that a second Artifact had simply appeared along Yiwen's route was something neither of them paused to consider — "possibility" and "probability" are, after all, two entirely different things. No matter how many Hunters worked tirelessly to move Artifacts into the human world, the total number of Artifacts in existence was still vanishingly small.

Sydney glanced back at the cluster of police cars still glued to their tail, then accepted her fate, tightened her grip on the handle overhead, and said, "No wonder you were cutting across streets and going the wrong way — you're racing the subway. An ordinary shortcut wouldn't have been enough. Still, this is genuinely terrifying. If I don't die in the Nest but end up dying in a car crash, that would be deeply ironic."

Chase didn't respond to that. He just flicked a glance at the time and said, "You detected the Artifact at around 10:03."

He had an almost obsessive habit: no matter what was happening, he had to know the exact time — down to the minute.

He'd kept the habit for over twenty years, and by now his internal clock was nearly flawless even without looking. Before he'd checked, he already knew it was 10:13; he'd been tearing through the city with police on his tail for close to ten minutes.

Ahead of him, an unknown number of red lights were waiting. Each one was a choice: stop and get caught? Run it and get T-boned?

He needed a plan — a way to carve an open road through the gridlocked streets of Blackmoor City.

Chase asked, "What's the current headway on the D Line — how many minutes between trains?"

Sydney glanced at the maps app on her phone. "Seven minutes," she answered.

"Check the navigation — how many minutes until the next train departs from Fulington Station? And how long does it take to reach the terminal?"

"Next departure in two minutes. Thirty-five minutes to the terminal."

Sydney caught up with the logic even as she said it, her eyes gradually brightening. "So the train carrying the Artifact will reach the terminal at 10:36! We just have to get to the platform before 10:36."

People who could make "entering the Nest to hunt" a career rather than just their last hobby before dying were never slow on the uptake.

If the next train departed at 10:15, then the previous ones had left at 10:08 and 10:01. When Sydney had begun her detection at 10:03, the 10:01 train had been just about to exit her range; by the time it traveled from Fulington Station to the terminal, it would be exactly 10:36.

"But I still have one question," Sydney said, frowning. "How do you know the train was heading toward Buluan Community College Station and not the other direction?"

"I don't," Chase said.

Sydney's head snapped toward him and she stared.

"There's only one thing I know," Chase said, and for his own faction's Hunter he was more patient than usual, explaining: "When you come down from the street entrance at Fulington Station, the platform on level B1 is the one going toward Buluan Community College Station. Level B2 is the platform heading the other way."

"Oh," Sydney said, her frown easing, and she nodded. "So you're betting that the bodyguard just got on the first train available. That tracks — he only spent thirteen minutes more than the GPS's projected route. Factor in parking, getting out of the car, and waiting for a train, and that means he didn't linger in the station at all. Quick in, quick out."

Yiwen only needed to ride one stop — once he'd stashed the Artifact, he could get off at the next station, cross the platform, and catch a train going the opposite direction without even having to wait.

"Still," Sydney marveled, "you just know off the top of your head that some random subway station has two levels of platforms? You were born in Blackmoor City, weren't you? You know it like the back of your hand."

Chase didn't answer. Instead he ordered, "Call the police."

Sydney blinked twice, and couldn't help glancing back at the patrol cars behind them. One had gotten very close; its whirling lights painted the rear window in alternating pulses of blue and red.

"We're not short on police," she pointed out.

"Don't waste time." Chase kept his foot down, continuing toward the red light ahead. "Call them. Tell them you're in a speeding vehicle. Tell them to seal off the area between Colorado Avenue, East 106th Street, and Cherry Street within ten minutes."

"You're the boss." She grumbled and pulled up the dial screen.

Sydney had barely finished pressing the three digits when her eyes tore away from the screen: from the road to their right, a massive freight truck had just crossed through the intersection and was now thundering toward them, on course to broadside the black Mercedes squarely in the middle.

"Truck — "

Rather than brake, Chase floored it — pressed the accelerator flush with the floor. The engine let out a sound almost like a howl of despair as the car plunged straight ahead at breakneck speed.

Sydney's involuntary scream ricocheted around the cabin, then was swallowed by the tremendous crash from behind — although the truck had only clipped the very corner of the rear bumper, the impact sent the whole car lurching violently sideways, nearly spinning it to a crosswise halt in the middle of the intersection.

A pair of large hands wrenched the steering wheel hard; through the whining shudder of metal and engine, the car pulled free of the intersection and back onto the road ahead. Behind them, the truck slammed on its brakes and jackknifed across the lanes; a chain-reaction of screeching rear-end collisions instantly turned the road into a wall of steel, trapping the pursuing police cars on the other side.

"I joined the Hunter House Faction because I wanted better job security," Sydney cried, still shaking from the shock. "Not to risk my life on the clock! This isn't the Nest — "

"911," a woman's voice rose from somewhere near the floor of the seat, "what is your emergency?"

"Quickly," Chase said, keeping his foot down, snapping his fingers once in front of Sydney. "We might not get lucky like that at the next intersection."

"Hello — hello!" Sydney scrambled to scoop up the phone. "I'm in that car that's been driving like a maniac through the Buluan district!"

She rattled off Chase's instructions at top speed, then paused, glanced at him, and answered, "...You want to know who I am? Well, I was — I was kidnapped onto this car. He's holding a gun to my head and made me make this call. He says if the road isn't blocked off..." She paused again. "He's going to throw a bomb into traffic."

Chase slid her a sideways glance and let a smile crack open across his face, a flash of white teeth.

"I'd say it's been a pleasure working with you," he murmured, once Sydney had ended the call, "but our collaboration is only just getting started."

Ahhhh my stockpiled chapters are almost gone after tomorrow ahhhh

On top of that I've been running around like crazy these past few days and haven't had a chance to check how many new patron pledges came in — the bonus chapter debt counter is still at 7, and hey, as long as I don't look it stays at 7... okay no, what I mean is, I will absolutely write those bonus chapters like a responsible person.

Today is packed wall to wall again — morning I'm heading to Qidian, afternoon I've got errands to run, and tonight there's some last-minute event that just got sprung on me out of nowhere that I absolutely cannot skip... I had absolutely no idea this thing was happening, so my suitcase only has jeans, sneakers, and t-shirts, and they might not even let me through the door — wait, actually, if they turn me away at the door, I can just come home and write, right? See, I'm really a very responsible person with her priorities straight.

PS: The cost of living is going to be the death of me... especially my friends in Shanghai — how do you people survive? I stood in front of a single bottle of mouthwash going back and forth four times like I was working up the nerve to propose to it, and the store clerk was staring at me before I finally made myself grab it. A small bottle of mouthwash is like, what, under ten yuan anywhere else? What is Shanghai mouthwash made of — liquid collagen and the tears of a wellness influencer?!

Chapter 18: Mai Minghe's Fourth Person

The exit of St. Louis Hospital (Nest version), according to the redhead, was inside the guardhouse just outside the hospital building.

To get there, they would have to climb to the first floor, cross the lobby, and walk out the front doors — and along the way, they had to avoid not only the Residents, but the redhead's companions as well. Without someone to guide her, it was a genuinely tricky problem.

Mai Minghe was grateful.

"Young man, what's your name?"

She smoothed the white sheet back into place — a habit she'd kept for seventy or eighty years, one she couldn't break even after climbing down from a morgue slab — and sighed: "What a shame we don't know each other back in Blackmoor City. Otherwise I'd have to knit you a sweater and send it over. Just look at yourself — you came out here in short sleeves, and it's already November."

The redhead glanced at her as though she were the strangest thing in the entire Nest.

"...You're not my great-aunt," he finally muttered after a long pause. "My name's Jonah. But I'd advise you, once you're back, to keep it that way — act like we've never met. Don't let my House Faction find out about you."

She still had a thousand questions, and she would have loved to ask Jonah all of them somewhere safe — but he was right. None of them mattered as much as the Artifact.

The questions about the Nest could wait. She'd tease out the answers bit by bit, sooner or later.

"Let's go," Jonah said. "We've reset, but it's still safer not to take the same way back."

As the two of them left, Mai Minghe switched off the light on her way out. In the last instant before the room went dark, the shape under the white sheet in the corner of the morgue swept once more across the edge of her vision — and then was swallowed by the darkness inside the room.

The morgue door was heavy; left to itself, it swung shut on its own and fell closed behind them with a dull boom.

Mai Minghe followed behind Jonah as he turned into the far end of the corridor, and for reasons she couldn't quite name, she felt an uneasy, drifting unsettledness in her mind.

She kept turning over the image in her head — that silent outline under the white sheet back in the morgue. It had the quality of a real corpse: no reaction when Jonah turned on the light, no reaction while the two of them talked, and no reaction when they left.

"Do they actually use the morgue to store real bodies?" Mai Minghe asked. "The thought that we might have been lying right next to a real corpse this whole time — well, it gives me quite a fright, if I'm honest."

"Hm?" Jonah answered distractedly. "Just now? A corpse?"

Mai Minghe swallowed back the words that had nearly slipped out, then raised her eyes and looked at his back.

Jonah's red hair was cut short. Below the neat, clean edge of his hairline at the back of his neck, there was a fine dusting of pale-orange stubble that hadn't been shaved away — a soft, hazy blur drifting over his skin like mist.

Her thoughts rose and fell for a moment, almost formless — she could barely have said what she was thinking — and she answered vaguely: "Right, yeah... just now."

Jonah was quiet for a second or two.

Between one footfall and the next, he said, "I don't know. Could be, I suppose. It is a morgue, after all."

Mai Minghe made a soft sound to show she'd heard.

She glanced back over her shoulder. Behind her stretched a straight corridor leading back to the staircase they'd come down.

If she turned and ran from here, she had nowhere to cut sideways — running in a straight line, it would be nearly impossible to shake off pursuit. But wait — maybe there would be no need to run at all?

Maybe she was overthinking it?

Right, no need to panic — think it through first, Mai Minghe told herself.

One: the morgue was a "reset" location — a person went in, lay down, played dead, and after enough time had passed, the hospital Residents would forget about them.

Two: before the two of them had gone in, there was already someone lying in the morgue — or at least something human-shaped.

Three: after they came out, Jonah had clearly forgotten that there was still a person lying in the morgue.

Goosebumps rose and fell in waves across Mai Minghe's thighs, every pore seeping cold.

If she reasoned from those three known facts, only one conclusion was possible: Jonah was a Resident.

But that conclusion was absurd. He was plainly a flesh-and-blood living person, and he had saved her life. She must have missed something — she needed to think it over again.

Jonah walked fast. Following at his pace for a stretch, Mai Minghe found they had already climbed up from the staircase at the other end of the hospital building and emerged onto the first floor, not far from the emergency room.

The hospital corridors and the waiting area were all brightly lit, with not a soul at the nurses' station.

Aside from the all-encompassing emptiness, the place was an exact replica of the real human world. On the triage counter, someone had even left a paper cup — just without anyone there to drink from it. It felt like a place that humanity had fled in an instant, abandoned at the sudden end of the world.

Along the corridor where they walked, there were several consultation rooms. Some doors were shut tight; others stood half-open, trailing a narrow gap of impenetrable gloom.

All the way down, there was nothing to hear but their own footsteps and breathing. Jonah had chosen a good route — not a single Resident encountered, every danger skirted.

"The emergency room usually has things in it," Jonah murmured, crouching behind a wall and easing his head around to peer ahead. After a moment he turned to Mai Minghe. "When we pass through, we have to be absolutely silent."

Mai Minghe nodded — but a thought had already forced its way into her mind.

...And yet when they were playing dead in the morgue, silence hadn't been required?

She knew next to nothing about the Nest, or about "life gates" — but thinking it through with common sense, she felt that when a person was pretending to be a corpse, they shouldn't be doing

what the two of them had just done: talking back and forth, easy and relaxed.

A corpse, after all — shouldn't it be like the person lying in the corner? No matter what happened, not a twitch, not a sound?

What if the person in the corner was the one who had actually been resetting — a genuine Hunter doing it right?

In that case, had her own reset even worked?

Mai Minghe looked down at her fingertips.

Come to think of it, she did actually have one way to verify whether Jonah was a Resident or a living person.

Although she had wiped most of the blood and grime onto the lanky patient earlier, a thin line of dark residue remained deep under her fingernails — she hadn't managed to shake it all off.

Using the nail of her other hand, Mai Minghe worked out a small scraping of black-red filth and pinched it between her fingertips. When Jonah stood and murmured "let's go," she immediately reached out and grabbed his arm, calling out, "Wait."

Lucky for her, he was wearing short sleeves — the black-red blood on her fingers transferred neatly onto Jonah's skin.

The writhing, thrashing reaction the lanky patient had shown didn't happen at all.

"What is it?" Jonah half-bent, stepping back behind the wall. "Did you spot something?"

Aside from looking a little pale and ashen — though who could possibly look rosy-cheeked in a situation like this? Mai Minghe suspected her own color was worse — he showed no sign of anything wrong. No pain, no reaction; he hadn't even noticed the smear of round-head's blood on his arm.

So he probably wasn't a Resident after all. Mai Minghe quietly let out a breath of relief.

The business with the morgue must have another explanation — she just couldn't think of one at the moment. But then, she wasn't God. How could she possibly account for every last thing without a single gap?

From here on, she'd just have to pay closer attention.

"Say something."

"Mm... well, the thing is," Mai Minghe fumbled for a reason under his stare, stuttering a little: "once we're out of here, it's going to be pretty dangerous, isn't it? Maybe we should find something we can use as weapons before we head out."

Jonah frowned, thinking it over. "We don't have much time. Who knows how long this corridor stays safe? As long as we move fast and make it to the exit before anything closes in, weapons aren't strictly necessary."

It had only been an excuse to start with, but now that he'd said it, Mai Minghe genuinely felt that finding a weapon was a good idea. In life, whatever you were doing, it never hurt to have a backup plan — being without one could only ever make things worse. Jonah was young and brimming with confidence, which was perfectly normal, but she couldn't afford to let his self-assurance carry her along.

"How about this — when we pass by the nurses' station, I'll duck in and have a quick look around. It won't waste any time."

To leave the building, they had to pass the triage counter anyway; if she went in at one end and came out the other, a few seconds of scanning was all it would take.

Jonah wasn't thrilled about it, but he didn't argue.

"Then I'll come in with you," he said, tilting his chin to indicate the direction. "If there's nothing strange inside the nurses' station, it's actually safer than standing in the open — we'd have some cover."

Decision made, the two of them immediately crouched low, stepped lightly, and slipped out from behind the wall.

Scanning left and right as they went, they scurried toward the nurses' station — like two flustered beetles, eight legs rustling and scraping across the floor — and ducked behind the station's counter panel.

The triage station was rectangular, with an entrance on each of the two shorter sides facing directly across from each other. Mai Minghe kept dreading that if she looked up, a face would have appeared in the opposite doorway; so, with an almost neurotic compulsion, she swept her gaze across it every few seconds before she could feel at ease.

On the side facing the lobby, there were three nurses' workstations fitted with computers, office chairs, telephones, and an assortment of odds and ends — forms, binders, and the like. If it

weren't for everything she'd just been through, she could almost not believe this wasn't the real St. Louis Hospital.

How could there be phones and computers inside the Nest? Who had brought all of this in?

The letters on the keyboard had been worn white, exactly as if someone had really been typing on it for years; a small potted cactus — whether real or fake she couldn't tell — sat in a dusty clump in the corner of the desk.

For a moment she almost forgot what she was even there for, overtaken by the peculiar feeling of a television viewer walking onto a film set for the first time — even the most mundane, unremarkable things, the duty roster and the ballpoint pens, seemed to carry a new layer of strangeness that made them worth a second look. Unfortunately, there was nothing she could see that might serve as a weapon.

Mai Minghe had just reached out to pick up the receiver — she wanted to hear whether there was a dial tone — when Jonah stopped her immediately.

"Don't touch anything that could make contact," he warned in a breath-light whisper. "There's no telling what it might bring."

He'd probably been traumatized by her pressing the call bell four times in a row earlier; his entire face said: "How do you never learn?"

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and thought for a few seconds.

"There's nothing here," Jonah said, crouched behind the workstation counter — low enough that no one outside could see he was there. He pointed toward the doorway on the other side and murmured, "Let's go. We've wasted enough time."

"All right."

As Jonah crept forward toward the doorway, he suddenly stopped and glanced back at Mai Minghe. "What are you just standing there for? Come on."

Mai Minghe pulled out a desk chair; its four wheels rumbled and rattled across the floor, shattering the silence, and came to a stop in front of her.

She bent slightly at the waist, both hands pressed on the back of the chair, and looked at the face across from her.

Jonah couldn't have been older than thirty — his journey as an adult had, in every real sense, only just begun. His eyes were a little red, his lips dry, and a faint shimmer of hot sweat clung to his skin — unmistakably, undeniably human.

She didn't know the truth of it — not yet. But she couldn't help feeling sad. It was like a conditioned reflex: she ached for a boy this young, and she ached for the mother who had raised him, little by little, to become who he was.

"You go on," Mai Minghe said, her voice gone hoarse. "I won't be going with you."

Jonah's brow creased. He stared at her for a moment as though he thought she was talking nonsense.

But after two seconds, his brow smoothed out.

"...You figured something out, didn't you?" He didn't seem to care about being seen anymore — he straightened up beside the doorway of the nurses' station and flashed Mai Minghe a bright white smile. "Why don't you tell me too."

"Leaving aside the lanky patient who was already in the room to begin with —"

Mai Minghe said quietly: "After I pressed the bell four times, what came were one nurse, a pair of hands from under the bed, and the underground Resident controlling the round head — that's three 'figures disguised as hospital staff' in total. The fourth one to enter the room was you."

Honestly, I thought once I posted the Mai Minghe and Sydney Ginn sections, someone would definitely catch the foreshadowing about "the fourth person" and "the exit" — but nope! (Sydney Ginn's section did mention that returning to Blackmoor City also goes through the passage.) So I'm calling that a win for me — and no going back to leave comments now that you've read this!

Consider it a small mercy from you all, letting me have this one victory — I've been having such a rough time lately, running around exhausted and stressed and irritated every single day... ugh, I won't even get into all the annoying stuff.

My stockpile of pre-written chapters is completely gone. Starting tomorrow I'll just have to get up on stage and perform for you all with this shameless face of mine (not literally) — opened up the Artifact Report page and looked, and wow: folk arts, variety talk, crosstalk (not really).

First I lure you in with a novel, then once the buffer's gone, I start performing a ballet called "Swan Lake with a Broadsword" to pay back the debt I owe you all — is that okay? A bold new form of fraud, honestly.

Chapter 19: Mai Minghe's Reproductive Unit

Looking back on it now, Jonah had been watching her pretty closely.

He would turn his head every now and then to check whether Mai Minghe was keeping up, and whenever she hesitated or slowed down, he would urge her to keep moving. Even for a kindhearted young man, he seemed a touch excessively invested in her personal safety — not only willing to forgo the Artifact, but even ready to abandon his companions just for her sake.

Of course, all of this reflection on Mai Minghe's part was pure hindsight.

"You're that sure about it?"

Jonah's voice was still hushed — no longer a bare whisper, but still as though he didn't want anything else to hear him.

"This is your first time inside the Nest. How can you be certain that ringing the bell would definitely bring a Resident out? What if one of them didn't go, or went and found they couldn't beat the others to it, and simply didn't enter the room?"

"If I really were just a Hunter who got caught while trying to escape and was thrown into the ward, and yet you're this suspicious of me, wouldn't you be throwing away a powerful ally for nothing?"

"...And are you?" Mai Minghe asked quietly.

Jonah licked his dry lips, considered for a moment, and smiled.

"...No."

The word had barely left his mouth before Mai Minghe was already planting a kick into the chair, sending it flying straight at him.

She didn't wait to see whether it connected — she spun around and bolted. A sharp clang rang out: the chair had apparently struck something hard, sending a gut-clenching echo through the empty, silent waiting hall.

That sound wasn't right for a chair hitting a human body, but Mai Minghe had no time to glance back and see what had happened. She burst out of the nurses' station, sprinted across the hall, and charged toward the corridor she had come from — she remembered several examination

rooms along that corridor with doors left ajar, and if she could dash into one and lock it, she might be able to hold Jonah off.

A sharp whistle pierced the air behind her, and Jonah called out: "Come!"

What was he calling to?

Mai Minghe forced herself to pump her legs even faster, twisted her body, and plunged into the still and silent corridor — somehow, not a single footstep sounded on the floor behind her, as though Jonah hadn't given chase at all.

She couldn't suppress her curiosity and threw a quick glance back over her shoulder.

The corridor stretched away empty, pale light pooling in the stillness of an abandoned place.

Jonah really hadn't come after her.

Never mind why he hadn't — she'd already run this far, so even if he started chasing her now, he probably couldn't catch up, could he?

Should she still duck into one of the examination rooms?

The question flashed through her mind, and she made her decision instantly: yes.

She knew nothing about Saint Louis Hospital inside the Nest, and running around blindly might lead her straight into danger. She had taken a look at the rooms as she passed them earlier — at the very least, they weren't entirely unknown territory.

The first examination room was locked tight; she tried the handle and found it wouldn't turn, so she immediately ran toward the next room, whose door stood half-open — it turned out to be a heavy sliding door cased in steel paneling. The moment she got a clear look at it, she cursed under her breath and kept running.

Fortunately the next examination room wasn't far, and its door was also ajar, left open a crack. She gave it a quick push — but the door wouldn't open, stuck at barely the width of a fist, as if something were wedging it in place.

"Why didn't you go into the room just now?" came Jonah's voice.

Mai Minghe's heart skipped a full beat.

She slowly raised her head and looked toward the sound — and in the corner where the ceiling met the wall, she saw a human face hanging upside-down.

Of course... Jonah had climbed up the wall before. He had crawled along it to get here — no wonder there had been no footsteps.

Jonah's abdomen faced the ceiling, his hands and feet clinging fast to the plaster wall, like some enormous insect. She had no idea when he had worked his way above her head, nor how he was keeping himself from falling.

His neck bent downward, his eyes rolling loose as they fixed on her, showing a wide strip of white — Jonah at that moment reminded her of a certain kind of doll, the kind whose eyes flipped open and shut with gravity, so that every time you held one you had the feeling you were holding something alive that was pretending to be lifeless.

She also understood now why the door wouldn't open.

One of Jonah's hands wasn't gripping the ceiling at all — instead it was thrust into the gap, clamped firmly around a corner of the door panel, making it impossible for her to push or pull it in either direction.

"No need to rush," he said.

As the question was still forming in Mai Minghe's mind, Jonah opened his mouth, his upper teeth flickering in and out of view between his upside-down lips. "My child will be here shortly. Reaching full maturity still depends on you."

What child?

Mai Minghe stepped back from Jonah in a wide stride, then quickly darted a glance down the corridor.

From around the corner crept a very small shadow. Had it not been crawling toward her with a soft rustling sound, Mai Minghe might never have realized it was a living thing.

At first glance it looked like a ball, or a crumpled plastic bag; but within a few seconds she could see it clearly — roughly the size of two fists, a wrinkled mass of flesh-pink tissue, and on either side of it, dozens of thin legs churned forward in rapid alternation, blurring into a smear of shadow.

What the hell was that thing?

The thought had barely crossed her mind when she felt a sudden chill on both cheeks; two hands hung down from the ceiling, fingers clamping like iron talons around her skull.

Mai Minghe startled and struggled wildly, her fists hammering against hard muscle with dull thud after thud — thump, thump — yet without loosening the grip in the slightest. The two male hands sank deep into her cheeks, fingers cupped around her jaw, forcing her mouth open.

The wrinkled pink mass of flesh seemed to grow excited all at once, scuttling forward faster, its several tentacle-like legs climbing up her pajama pants.

She had never in her life craved a weapon in her hands as desperately as she did right now — anything would do, even just a length of pipe; but she was an old woman who had been bedridden just earlier that night, and apart from the clothes on her body, she had nothing at all.

"Don't be afraid," Jonah's voice said soothingly. "Look — I'm doing just fine now, aren't I? As long as the memories persist, a person isn't really dead. After I entered Jonah, his memories of being 'Jonah' are still continuing, which means 'Jonah' is still alive... just with an added symbiont, that's all."

No wonder the round-headed one's blood had had no effect on him — because the blood had been smeared on Jonah, not on the Resident's true body.

Mai Minghe swung and swept at herself frantically, trying to knock the thing off, but the fleshy mass moved like an agile cockroach, its legs skittering and darting, slipping away from her palms again and again, pressing ever closer to her head each time.

"You could try covering your mouth, the way Jonah did at the time," said the Jonah above her head.

What kind of half-hearted advice was that?

Now that he'd said it, she genuinely didn't know whether she should cover her mouth or not — or was that exactly the effect he was going for?

Mai Minghe now truly regretted ringing that bell four times; from the moment she had fallen out of the hospital bed, she had lurched from one near-disaster to the next, each situation more wretched than the last.

In the moment she hesitated, the thing had already crawled up to her chest. Up close it looked more and more like some hybrid of a brain and an insect — a raw, icy chill rose from her chest, its five or six thin legs stepping across her collarbone, and a hideous thing of slick folds and overlapping flaps of flesh appeared in Mai Minghe's field of vision.

Mai Minghe suppressed every instinct screaming at her to raise her hands, wrenching her head to one side as hard as she could, and in the same motion quickly stripped off her sleep jacket — the older you get the more you feel the cold, and she was no exception; she slept in several layers, and the outermost one had its buttons undone, so she could rip it off in one pull.

Two long, slender legs had already crept into her mouth, making her gag with revulsion and itch with unbearable sensation.

Mai Minghe forced her gaze upward, fixed on her target, drew back her arm, and snapped the sleep jacket through the air — crack — bringing it down with every ounce of force she had, square across Jonah's eyes.

If you were using a human body, surely you were also subject to its physical limitations?

Who could remain completely steady and unmoved after taking a blow to the eyeball?

Sure enough, Jonah let out an involuntary cry of pain, and the hands gripping Mai Minghe loosened ever so slightly.

The moment she felt the grip give, she immediately bent low, pulling her head free from within Jonah's reach; and at the same instant, using the sleep jacket to shield her hand, she grabbed hold of the thing that had been crawling into her mouth and pulled it out.

Thank goodness the gaunt patient had already wrung her completely empty, otherwise the sight of the flesh-ball thrashing and writhing its limbs right in front of her face would have made her retch all over again.

Mai Minghe wrapped it in the sleep jacket, forced down her revulsion, clutched it in her fist, and ran.

This time she couldn't afford to be choosy. When she realized she had run back to the heavy steel sliding door, a plan suddenly came to her. She charged inside and immediately spun to face the doorway — and sure enough, she saw Jonah on the ceiling, his eyes half-narrowed and red, scrambling toward her with a contorted face.

"You slippery old woman—"

Mai Minghe kept her face blank and took hold of the door.

These Residents.

"I've told you, I'm not an old woman," she said under her breath, and hurled the flesh-ball down onto the floor, landing it squarely on the sliding track. She yanked the door hard, and it ground toward the flesh-ball.

Jonah's shriek sounded as though it might tear his throat apart: "No, wait!"

The heavy sliding door, steel-plated over a lead core, came crashing down on the wrinkled pink mass just as it hit the floor, before it had found its footing. It burst apart without so much as a sound, foul blood and shredded flesh spattering in all directions — in an instant, all that remained between the door and the wall was the largest fragment, a flattened scrap of flesh, its thin legs still twitching.

Before she could kick the remnants aside and slam the door shut, a hand with prominent veins slapped against the door frame — crack.

Through the gap in the door, half of Jonah's face had become barely recognizable as human; his nostrils flared open and closed, as though two new bellows had been cut into his face.

"My child!" he screamed.

Mai Minghe threw all her weight against the door, not daring to let him wrench it open, while at the same time she swept a rapid glance around the dim interior — and couldn't help letting out a quiet, bitter breath.

Just as she had expected, the room was a medical imaging suite.

An X-ray room's door panels and walls all required radiation shielding, and few hospitals would install windows in an X-ray room — not because radiation-proof windows didn't exist, but because they were expensive and impractical — which meant that once someone was chased inside an X-ray room, they were a turtle in a jar, with no way out.

That was also why Mai Minghe had passed this door without entering the first time: if she had gone into an ordinary examination room and locked the door, she could still have escaped through a window — but not here.

"Does something like you really need to pass on offspring?" Mai Minghe said through gritted teeth, leaning into the door with all her strength. "You're already in the Nest — surely you don't need to bother with ecological reproduction?"

"After I kill you," Jonah rasped, his words seeming to stick and drag against each other. "Your corpse will dissolve in the Nest, and I will rebuild my child from your constituent units..."

"You mean you'll take my flesh and blood to rebuild your child?"

Mai Minghe leaned against the wall, pushing the door with both hands and feet together, her muscles trembling, still unable to get the sliding door fully closed. She swept the room with her eyes, searching for anything that could serve as a weapon, and kept talking to buy time: "My flesh and blood probably isn't disgusting enough. You won't get much out of it."

Jonah suddenly burst out laughing.

"Flesh and blood? I don't want your dried-up old flesh and blood at all! All that matters is that you once contemplated the act of giving birth — the moment you did, your mind and body were marked. The version of you who once considered 'reproduction' is still a part of who you are today, and as long as I can take hold of that part—"

Mai Minghe went very still.

She hadn't expected that here, of all places, and now, of all times, she would be dragged back to memories from years ago: the anxiety over her steadily declining fertility, the confusion over what choices to make, the unease about what old age might hold for her...

Without realizing it, her grip loosened just a little.

Jonah caught it.

The sliding door was shoved open with a violent bang — she barely had time to startle before a red-haired head came poking through the gap.

I dug a saved draft chapter out of my iPad and bought myself another day of survival — honestly, it feels exactly like finding a thousand yuan in your winter coat pocket!

Chapter 20 — Jonah of Mai Minghe's Desperate Plea

The shock hit Mai Minghe like a thousand volts crackling through her body. She threw every ounce of strength she had into shoving the door forward — and her reflexes didn't fail her: just as Jonah's body was squeezing through the gap, the sliding door caught him squarely at the throat, pinning him tight.

If only that pressure could choke him out — things would have been simple.

But the door had landed on the side of his neck, over the artery rather than the windpipe. It flushed his face a furious red and made every breath a struggle, yet it stopped short of crushing his airway. As long as he could breathe, he had strength, and one hand had already hooked around the door's edge, straining to push it back toward her.

The man could still talk.

"Did you know," he said,

his breath ragged but his words still clear and complete, "...that anyone who lingers in the Nest for more than seven days — or who dies inside it — is broken apart piece by piece? Not just the body. The mind, the memories, the feelings, the experiences, even a single passing thought — all of it dissolves and is remade into something else, becoming part of the Nest itself. You've lived a long life, haven't you? Quite a few experiences, I'd imagine. Quite a few dark thoughts too, I'd wager. When you die here, who knows what wonders might emerge from you... People who don't die in the Nest until their seventies or eighties — now that's a rare thing."

She half understood, and half didn't.

After death, emotions, memories, experiences — all of it would become part of the Nest? What did "part of it" even mean — would her memories each spawn their own Residents?

As though he had heard her thoughts, Jonah let out a raspy, scratching laugh. "I wonder what will come walking out of eighty-six years of living... I can hardly wait."

This was his play, wasn't it — the same trick as before, trying to shake her.

Mai Minghe held the door with everything she had, jaw clenched. He'd miscalculated, she thought.

"Is it because Jonah always has to train the new recruits that you can't help giving me a little orientation as well?"

Even with her muscles trembling and her whole body shaking, she still managed to talk, her voice quivering as she spoke: "You live inside a person like a roundworm in someone's gut — you have no human experience to speak of. There isn't a life lived that doesn't get ground down, that doesn't hit its hard stretches. But life has a way of doing this, just when you least expect it: it lets a little light through. A little tenderness.

"Even if you kill me here today and use me as raw material to churn out your Residents, I won't die in pain or in anger. I didn't have many days left to begin with — lying in bed every day, a dried-out husk of a person. The best of it is gone forever. But before my life ended, I got to be young again, to live it one more time, to die looking the way I remembered myself — who else could be so lucky? That is the tenderness heaven had in store for me. I'm quite happy about it."

"Shut up!" Jonah couldn't get a word in; he let out a hoarse cry. "Shut up!"

"When you get to a certain age, you can't help rambling — once you start, you just can't stop."

Jonah seemed genuinely furious, and for once he led by example and shut his own mouth, pressing his lips into a tight, flat line. And so the two of them — one full person, one person's head — settled into a quiet, grim tug-of-war in opposite directions, each breathing heavily.

Sure enough, Mai Minghe couldn't hold her tongue for long.

"If you've burrowed into Jonah's body, has he lost every last bit of his own will? Hey — young man, are you still in there? Can't you do something about that brain-worm of yours? This can't go on."

The capillaries in Jonah's face had long since burst; his skin was covered in vast, lurid splatters of red — he looked like a bloated purple grape about to split — yet he seemed utterly unbothered, and showed no reaction whatsoever to her words, still pulling at the door.

People were said to be their own worst enemies when they got something stuck in their heads; but judging by the look of things, when something that wasn't a person got something stuck in its head, the problem was just as intractable...

Mai Minghe knew perfectly well that her physical strength was no match for Jonah's.

Even though her body had been restored to youth and she was stronger than her eighty-six-year-old self, Jonah was powerfully built and hardened by constant brushes with death — the two of them weren't even in the same league to begin with. And worse still: elderly people had small appetites, and in the day before she fell into the Nest she'd eaten nothing but a few crackers and a little egg, all of which she'd thrown up. Now, looking at the mangled remains of the "child" on the floor, she was — to her own mild horror — starting to feel a little hungry.

The only reason she'd held on this long was the advantage of her position. The longer this stalemate dragged on, the worse her odds would get.

Mai Minghe glanced at the "child's" remains on the floor again, and suddenly sucked in a sharp breath through her teeth. "Hm?"

That flash of startled suspicion loosened her grip just slightly.

Jonah reacted immediately — just as she'd expected, he followed her gaze downward — and that was the moment Mai Minghe had been waiting for. She seized it at once, threw her full body weight behind the door, and slammed it forward with everything she had. A harsh, cracked, ragged shriek tore out from between the door and the wall — like someone had crushed a frail, deflated rubber tube.

"A child's trick, and you actually fell for it." Mai Minghe said it aloud, but inwardly she was groaning.

She had been hoping that when Jonah looked down, she'd be able to take the chance to slam the door fully shut.

No such luck. The situation was barely any different from a moment ago, and there was no telling how much longer this standoff would drag on.

Air pushed in and out of Jonah's throat in a series of labored, broken passages, as though each breath cost more than the last.

Had the door caught his windpipe this time?

He had twisted his head around, so from Mai Minghe's angle she couldn't quite tell.

"I... I..." Jonah's face was turned toward the wall; his voice was muffled and hoarse, less like speech and more like a balloon slowly losing air. "I'm... a Hunter for... the Morgan House Faction..."

He was introducing himself — at a moment like this?

Mai Minghe's initial flicker of confusion sharpened into something more alert, and she kept listening.

"My name is Jonah Zinco... This is already my fifth day in the Nest..." He spoke with great difficulty. "Please... go to the Morgans... ask them for help..."

Goosebumps broke out all across Mai Minghe's skin.

She didn't know whether the door had happened to press down on something critical — some nerve or vessel that had temporarily severed the Resident's control — but whoever was speaking to her now was not the Nest's Resident that had been intent on killing her. It was Jonah, a Hunter from Blackmoor City, begging for his life.

"Where are your partners?" Speaking had become an effort for Mai Minghe too. "Can't you call them to you? You can see what kind of shape I'm in right now — I can barely look after myself."

Her limbs had long since been cycling through waves of weakness. She had been keeping herself going by telling herself just one more second, and when that second was up, just one more second again.

"Get out of... out of the Nest right away..." Jonah continued, still in halting fragments.

"I can't get out," Mai Minghe cut him off. "Can you keep control of your own body — stop the Resident from coming after me? It's still a long way from here to the exit—"

"No, no... it lied to you."

Mai Minghe snapped her mouth shut. Her teeth clicked together.

"However your passage brought you in... that's how you go back..." Two wet, clicking sounds came from deep in Jonah's throat, and then silence.

Just as Mai Minghe's heart lurched and she thought the Resident had wrested back control, Jonah's voice returned without warning: "You fell through the television... the television... go back. You've passed through a passage once already, so when you see it again, you'll feel it..."

"But the moment I let go, the Resident takes back control of you — right?" The anxiety she'd been holding back was beginning to bleed through into her voice. "Never mind that I might not

make it out at all. Even if I could run for it, I don't know if I'd find the tele— find it before the Resident gets to me—"

The last word died in her mouth before she could speak it.

Her gaze had come to rest, very still, on the far end of the room.

A few seconds passed. "When I see the passage," Mai Minghe said softly, "I'll know it's the passage — is that what you mean?"

Jonah's throat rasped and hissed. It seemed as though he could no longer answer her.

Mai Minghe couldn't help swallowing. Her heartbeat was so loud she could hear it inside her own ears.

Through the dimness, she could just barely make out a small door at the other end of the room.

The medical imaging room had no windows to the outside, but one section of it had been partitioned off into a small inner room, and that door led into it; beside the door was a pane of glass facing the X-ray machine.

When she had been searching for a weapon, she'd only looked nearby, within arm's reach — so when she'd noticed the small door and the glass window, she hadn't given them a second thought. But now, all of a sudden, she remembered something — whenever she used to come in for an X-ray, the radiologist would always be sitting in that little room.

Why did they sit in there?

Because they operated the machine and read the images.

Through the edge of the window now, she could make out the shadow of half a computer monitor; no light was coming from it, and everything was blurred and indistinct — if you weren't deliberately looking for it, you probably wouldn't even register it as a screen.

The screen was a medical imaging display — built large, meant for examining films. And all at once, like a wildfire catching, the feeling she'd had earlier — lying on the bed, that burning restlessness, that desperate pull toward the television — ignited inside Mai Minghe and blazed hotter and hotter.

Could it be that her passage wasn't a television set, but a screen?

But that didn't add up — when she'd passed the nurses' station and seen the computer monitor on the counter, why hadn't she felt anything?

That question didn't matter right now. This was not the moment to puzzle over it.

"Hey — Jonah?" Mai Minghe called out. She wanted to check her guess against what he knew, but from Jonah's throat came only a slow, wet gurgling.

"How do I find the Morgan House Faction? Do you have... do you have their number?"

You wouldn't find a Hunter faction in the phone book — oh, right, there weren't phone books anymore. In the old days people worried about no one being able to reach them, so they'd put their numbers in the public directory. Nowadays it was exactly the opposite — everyone seemed terrified of something called a "privacy breach."

The world had changed.

How was she supposed to find "the Morgan House Faction"? Would it be on a smartphone? She couldn't let a perfectly good young man get killed off by some wretched parasite.

But she called out to him a few more times, and Jonah gave no response at all.

She glanced at the screen in the small inner room, and the wildfire in her chest burned brighter.

If her guess was wrong and she made a dash for that inner room only to find no way back to Blackmoor City, she was certainly done for. But if this stalemate went on indefinitely, death was just as inevitable.

When danger lay on every side, she might as well move.

Mai Minghe drew a long, deep breath, and took her foot away from the door.

The moment she loosened her grip, the pressure lifted, and the Resident snapped awake at once. In the same instant that Jonah's shoulder shoved the sliding door open, Mai Minghe was already on her feet, sprinting toward the inner room.

Today is another flying day for me — by my reckoning I'll need to take at least three more flights over the next two weeks, and every major airline in the country is currently popping champagne — except China Eastern.

The moment I spot China Eastern while booking tickets, I get a visceral sense of dread and have to scroll straight past. There's that saying, isn't there: people won't remember what you said

or what you did, but they'll always remember how you made them feel? That's China Eastern for me — I've long since forgotten exactly what it was they did that disgusted me so thoroughly, but that disgust, tempered and burnished by the passage of time, remains unshakeable. The mere thought of China Eastern can make me seasick on the toilet. So I would rather take a Southern Airlines flight that doesn't land until eleven at night than hand a single yuan to China Eastern for their afternoon departure.

Chapter 21: How Can You Tell If It's a Fake Excuse Note

Friends, grandmas, extraterrestrials — honestly, I have no idea whether this counts as a legitimate excuse note or not.

Grandma, please put down your shoe first and let me explain myself for a moment — then you can decide whether or not to hold back from squashing me like a cockroach.

I was originally supposed to fly out yesterday. I checked the weather that morning — Shanghai was bright and sunny — and I was actually pretty happy about it. I trotted off to Pudong Airport, figuring I could sneak into some quiet corner during the wait and type away. I had it all planned out; I was even willing to spring for a lounge pass just to get some writing done.

After all that hassle getting there, I pulled out my phone and — well, guess what — the flight had been cancelled.

Apparently Guangdong was under an orange thunderstorm alert. Really goes to show how warmly it was welcoming me home.

But I couldn't just sit there and become a Shanghai local, could I? I still had to get back. So I immediately applied to rebook — and then spent a goddamn two hours waiting for that rebooking to go through, fielding calls and refreshing flight info the whole time. Two hours later, I successfully got rebooked onto a 9:30 PM flight that same night — except it was departing from Hongqiao Airport.

Right then. Off to Hongqiao.

Every Didi driver in Shanghai must be burning incense and praying for my continued patronage.

I got to Hongqiao Airport and looked at the departures board — there was a new line of text. Right above "Scheduled departure: 21:35," someone had added "Estimated departure: 23:35." I mean, is that even a language humans use? Are we playing a game of who knows the most synonyms for the same thing? I already had a bad feeling at that point. After all, Guangdong's rainstorm doesn't discriminate — but what could I do? I couldn't just sit in the airport waiting to see when this plane might actually take off. I decided to book a hotel.

I'm not staying overnight anyway, so I'll just get the cheapest one available — maybe in a few hours I'll be on my way. I thought to myself, naively.

So I dragged my luggage into a cab and got dropped off somewhere that looked less like Shanghai and more like a county town. The place was genuinely close to the airport — massive planes thundered past so low they practically grazed my scalp, nearly blowing my hairpiece right off (years of furious typing having thinned my hair at the ripe age of eighteen). I took a few photos of the planes while I was at it. Couldn't let the trip be a total waste.

Checked in, opened the door to my room, walked right back out — why? To go buy disposable toilet seat covers. The toilet seat ring was so yellow it looked like it had been lacquered in aged braising stock. Obviously the residue of years upon years of someone else's business.

Right. This is what over three hundred yuan gets you in a hotel. I am, undeniably, in Shanghai.

And then — you'll never guess — the universe heard me say I wasn't staying overnight. The second flight was delayed. Delayed until five in the morning.

Even an owl can't pull an all-nighter like that!!!

I rebooked a second time, this time to eleven o'clock this morning.

And so there I stood, hugging my bag, stranded in that hotel room, trapped in my own private siege, realizing I truly was going to be spending the night here. If I'd known it would come to this, why didn't I book somewhere decent? Heaven is out to get me. I first put the door chain on (something I never do), then peeled back the blanket to inspect the sheets — the sheets were fine, at least they looked white.

By this point it was already late in the evening. Not a single word written, and utterly drained in body and spirit, I reached my hand down to feel the mattress.

...Where was my mattress?

One spring, then another — poking, jabbing — what in the world were these things made of, diamond-forged steel coils? Don't mattresses normally have padding on top of the springs? Where was the padding?? I could feel every individual spring right through the bed sheet — I could practically take their pulse — WHERE WAS MY PADDING?!?!

I genuinely felt like crying. You want to know how I made it through that night? I pulled the blanket back out and used it as a mattress pad. Lying on top of the blanket, the sensation was

roughly equivalent to lying on a sidewalk.

Then I pulled one end of the blanket out from underneath me, wrapped it around my sides, and turned myself into a human burrito. That way I had both a mattress and a blanket — one item doing double duty — and only then could I actually sleep.

By this point I had written a grand total of three hundred words and was completely exhausted. I closed my eyes just after nine. Falling asleep that early was frankly disrespectful to the neighbors next door.

So around ten o'clock, I heard it. You think a hotel has only so many kinds of sounds. You'd be wrong.

I heard a pair of high heels clacking down the hallway — clack, clack, clack — for at least twenty laps back and forth (no carpet), and then a door slammed, boom, and whoever it was went inside. What followed was the sound of someone moving furniture.

I was half-asleep, and even in my dreams I was wondering: how are you moving furniture? The desks and beds in hotel rooms are all bolted to the floor — so what in the world was that heavy thing scraping across the floor??

And why did it go on for a full half hour?! Were they renovating the place??

What on earth were the other guests in this hotel here for???

Anyway, long story short, I made it through the night. Once I post this little situation report, I'll have to pack up all my bags again and head back to the airport. I'm exhausted, bleary-eyed, and strongly suspect I smell (too scared to shower in that room)··· Landing time is estimated at around two in the afternoon. If we actually land on time, there might be an update tonight. If there's another delay, I'm going to go throw myself into the Huangpu River.

And after everything I went through on this trip to Shanghai — you think it's over once I get back?

No. I didn't finish what I came to do. I have to come back again on the 8th, after the holiday.

Wonderful. I'm just here to temper my spirit and experience life to its fullest.

Chapter 22: Sydney Ginn, After Life and Death

They say that at the moment of death, the memories of a lifetime flash before your eyes like a lantern show; Sydney Ginn now knew that was neither quite right nor quite wrong.

She lay on the cold floor of the exhibition hall, yet she felt herself dissolving into a small boat, the ropes that tied her to the world of the living slipping loose, drifting her slowly out onto a great river wrapped in mist.

Sometimes the mist thinned and parted, revealing the scene of her first arrival in Blackmoor City — sharing a half-basement apartment with a stranger, looking out the living room window at the street, watching the shoes and trouser hems pass back and forth.

Sometimes she saw the client from her very first transaction, turning an Artifact over and over beneath a desk lamp, the light falling into their eyes until the irises and the suspicion behind them both went translucent.

The experiences closest to her — opening the passage, attracting a stalker, being killed — felt as though they had happened to someone else entirely, flat and bleached, invisible through the fog. The older moments were more vivid by far: carrying out the scallion-and-meat pie her mother had baked, spending afternoons at a classmate's house in seventh grade... open the door, walk in, and she could go home.

Drawn by those distant memories, Sydney drifted further away; the wet, rattling, desperate sound rising from her wounded throat was almost too faint to hear now.

Her head lay submerged in a pool of blood, which spread outward into her own private Styx.

"Just die," a voice floated above her, hissing out like air leaking from a puncture.

Yet that farewell called Sydney back, just a little.

...How had it come to this?

She had hailed the taxi, paid the fare, followed every instruction to the letter without daring to stray, and by the time she stepped out her neck was stiff and aching.

She had pretended not to see the female Resident crawling out of the elevator on the right, made it into the basement exhibition hall through sheer effort, held her breath the whole time, wound tight and ready to spring...

She had done everything, done it all perfectly, and still ended up like this. The bitterness of it was almost unbearable.

A dark shape hunched down, seemingly kneeling on the floor, studying her face.

Sydney could no longer make out details; her eyes held only dim silhouettes: the rounder shape was a skull, and below it a stretch of neck; jutting out from that neck was a dark line — the hunting knife she had driven into the Resident's throat.

As the shape opened its mouth to speak, the hunting knife buried deep in its neck bobbed gently up and down. The blade had cut through its windpipe, and between each word air wheezed and leaked out: "...I really should thank you, actually. It's only now that I remembered — what I forgot was the hiking backpack."

Even if some thought still flickered inside Sydney, nothing on the surface showed it. Blood had stained her neck a deep black-red, as if her throat had been erased altogether; her body lay utterly still, sunk in silence.

When she had jumped onto the first taxi, she must have accidentally stepped on the "Duplicated" square.

She still remembered: the moment she lifted her foot, someone gave the hiking pack on her back a violent yank, nearly sending her toppling backward; Sydney caught herself and turned around — and saw her own face. Not distorted, not warped in any way. Smooth and unblemished, exactly like looking into a mirror.

She froze.

"When did you copy yourself into me?" the other "Sydney Ginn" demanded, glaring at her, getting the words out first. It seemed to want to shove her, yet couldn't quite bring itself to make contact, and instead snapped, "Get away from me!"

So the square that said "Duplicated" really would only ever duplicate her, nothing more?

That made a kind of sense, she supposed — duplicating something didn't necessarily mean the original would be damaged in the process...

Apart from there now being a copy of herself, Sydney felt nothing wrong anywhere in her body; the one thing that truly disturbed her was this: "Sydney Ginn" seemed to have inherited both her body and her mind simultaneously, and was at this very moment utterly convinced, with complete sincerity, that it was the real one.

...Then how could she be a hundred percent certain she wasn't the Resident? She was equally convinced she was the real Sydney Ginn.

No — no, that was impossible. The one in front of her was the Resident, and it was trying to take her place at the Museum of Modern Art.

There was one key piece of evidence that proved she was the real Sydney Ginn: the backpack, the hunting knife, and the phone had all remained with her, none of them duplicated; the other one had nothing, its hands completely empty.

"At that moment I was entirely focused on how to get onto the taxi, and I forgot to pick up the hiking backpack. I'd been standing in the square the whole time — it was too heavy to keep on my back, so I'd set it down on top of my feet..."

The dark shape hovering before her, vaguely human in outline, went on leaking air as it spoke: "Something happened afterward that made me not pick up the backpack, but I've forgotten what it was — because that stretch of memory was handed over to the driver."

"Sydney Ginn," it seemed, still did not consider itself a Resident, even now.

It paused there, as if remembering something: "I was actually going to ask you — Passenger Rules item four, does lifting your head become allowed once you've paid the fare? Though I suppose you're a Resident, so you don't follow the Passenger Rules. What could happen to you anyway... never mind. It doesn't matter. I got off just fine in the end. And here you've gone and delivered my things to me."

...The bitterness of it.

At the time she hadn't dared keep brawling with "Sydney Ginn," afraid of stepping into some penalty square; so she had called another taxi, paid the fare with her memories, spent the whole ride with her neck bowed following behind "Sydney Ginn," and got out at the Museum of Modern Art.

Whatever it did, she did the same — until at last she followed it down into the basement exhibition hall, seized her moment, and drove the hunting knife deep into its throat.

Sydney had heard that Residents couldn't be killed. Even if they died temporarily, they could revive somewhere else.

But Residents were still subject to rules and constraints beyond ordinary life and death, so an attack would still have some effect — what she hadn't anticipated was that driving a knife into a

Resident's neck would do nothing more than make its windpipe leak air.

She had stood there in a daze, letting go of the knife, staring at "Sydney Ginn."

When it had tried to spit, nothing had come out of its mouth, which gaped like a dried-up black hole; now with the knife in its throat, it only hissed and wheezed — no blood flowed.

The Resident stood in place too, its eyes rolling downward for a moment to look at the knife, then lifting back up to look at her.

For one or two seconds, neither of them moved.

"Sydney Ginn" slowly drew back its lips to reveal a set of teeth she knew intimately. Every single one she had brushed countless times, examined in the mirror for color and shape, and could recognize at a glance — and yet here they were, inside someone else's mouth.

...Revolted.

"My throat's been stabbed," the Resident said, matter-of-factly, after those one or two seconds. "Since you've copied yourself into my form, your throat should be stabbed too."

The words had barely left its mouth before Sydney's throat opened up.

...Why? How could this be happening?

The outside world was so much colder than she had known; when the blood vessels and muscle were torn apart all at once, it was as though a splash of ice water had been poured in along the split — the pain came only afterward, delayed and belated.

The sudden chill at her throat was immediately swamped by the scalding spray of blood, which spattered a constellation of red drops across the face of her "self" standing opposite — Sydney clamped one hand hard over her gaping neck, instinctively trying to press the wound shut again, but blood kept gurgling up between her fingers.

In a consciousness shattering toward death, she crumpled to the ground.

Her eyelids froze half-open, half-closed, and her soul drifted into the deep, thick fog.

Sydney forced down the crawling horror and fear, one hand pressed tight against her neck, the other gripping the handle of the hunting knife.

Her palms were slick with cold sweat, her legs too weak to hold her up; she could only slide slowly down until she was sitting on the floor. A few steps away, the body that wore her exact face lay on the ground, its eyelids half-open, the eyes beneath them already glazed and still as a dead fish's belly.

"Sydney Ginn" hadn't stabbed deeply enough, missing the critical structures — perhaps the one stroke of luck in an otherwise disastrous situation.

She knew perfectly well that when a blade had been driven into the body, pulling it out would cause a deeper wound and greater blood loss; the first rule of first aid was "do not remove anything from a wound." Sometimes a blade embedded in the body could even temporarily act as a plug, sealing the wound and slowing the bleed.

The reason "Sydney Ginn" had died from an identical injury while she herself was still alive was most likely due to that one crucial difference — the hunting knife was blocking the bleed. Which meant Residents were not unkillable after all, at least not the Vulture kind.

The logic of killing it was just a bit convoluted: you had to let it copy itself into a second version of you first, then sustain a fatal wound yourself, then remind it to copy the fatal wound onto itself — only then would it die.

Even something that merely looked like a fatal wound would do.

Even knowing she wasn't going to die, having a knife lodged in her throat was agony to every nerve in her body; and besides, she couldn't call an ambulance in the Nest, couldn't go to an emergency room, and certainly couldn't climb up a high building and jump back to Blackmoor City for medical care with a knife sticking out of her neck...

She would have to deal with it herself.

She dug a spare T-shirt out of her backpack and wrapped it tightly around her neck and the knife, binding it so snug she could only gasp and see bursts of stars. She gently pressed the skin above the blade's tip to locate its position, readied her fingers — the moment she pulled the knife free, she would have to press down on the wound immediately, and not allow herself to bleed out.

Sydney knew the Nest was dangerous and that self-administered first aid was probably something she would need more than once; but even with the basic first-aid knowledge she had taught herself and the well-stocked supplies in her pack, a wound like this was beyond anything she had imagined.

Even she herself didn't know how she managed to stop the bleeding and then clumsily stitch the knife wound closed — it was, by any measure, a miracle.

Despite the success of the "surgery," Sydney couldn't hold on; she lost consciousness for a while.

When she came to, the basement exhibition hall was still utterly silent. She and the stiffening corpse of her own self lay slumped on either side of the enormous candle, and if you pressed your ear to the air, it felt like a tomb.

Sydney rested for a long time before she could slowly pull herself upright.

The grievous wound, the lingering shock, and the exhaustion made her want nothing more than to go home, to curl herself under the covers, to breathe in the familiar scent of jasmine laundry detergent and sink into one long, sweet oblivion.

But it wasn't time yet.

Sydney felt a quiet flicker of surprise at herself; she hadn't imagined she would show such unearthly resilience in the face of an Artifact. A knife wound to the throat — how many ordinary people could survive that?

She walked step by step to the candle, hesitated a moment, and placed her hand on it.

A line of small text immediately floated up beside her palm: 2009.4.22.

...Meaning that the history encoded at this position was from April 22, 2009?

She was standing several meters below the top of the candle. Why would this particular point correspond to April 22, 2009?

Sydney thought about it, walked to the very top of the candle, reached out and touched it — and sure enough, she saw her own birthday: 1998.9.29.

So that was how it worked... Her gaze traveled down the length of the candle.

The candle, then, held a flow of time beginning from the day of her birth and stretching all the way to today, the living present; there was no future inside the candle.

Because the future is unformed and uncertain, and so cannot be foreseen?

Her greedy hope of glimpsing the future had come to nothing, which was disappointing — yet looked at from another angle, it was also a strange sort of comfort: if fate was not already sealed,

then she still had a choice in what she did and where she went. A person was not a small insect in a glass box, every path already fixed and bounded.

Even in this world of sudden shocks and helpless bewilderment, a person still held this small measure of control over themselves.

Of course, Sydney wasn't arrogant enough to think the Nest had tailored this Artifact specifically for her — whoever touched the candle, it would presumably display history starting from that person's birth.

She walked a little further along, estimated roughly where she wanted, and pressed her hand to the candle again, searching.

2026.5.2. She found the moment of her first encounter with the stalker Anthony without any trouble.

Sydney had an idea.

She crouched down and found an ignition switch beneath the metal trough. *Click* — flame leapt to life at the base of the candle.

She wanted to see if she could snuff this whole thing out before it even began.

All the sleep I'd lost during those frantic, exhausting days came collecting the moment I finally got home... no matter how much coffee I drank, I was dead on my feet from the second I opened my eyes in the morning to the moment I fell into bed at night... by eight o'clock I simply couldn't take it anymore and had to sleep...

Chapter 23: Sydney Ginn — If the Mountain Won't Come to Mohammed

In the cavern-still silence of the exhibition hall, the only sound was the soft crackle and spit of the flame.

Sydney Ginn's nerves were strung tight as a bowstring; every little pop and snap of the fire was like a finger plucking at the strings inside her.

She had read through the full description of the Artifact known as "Candlefall," and stood there for a good while afterward, turning it over in her mind before she could say she had more or less digested it.

She made another circuit of the underground exhibition hall, making sure nothing lurked in the corners or the shadows, ready to launch a second attack — being attacked by herself once had already been more than enough.

When she passed the body, she quickened her steps, then abruptly stopped and turned back.

The corpse of her own dead self always left Sydney Ginn with a squirming, hollow unease.

She didn't want to look at it, and still less did she want it looking at her, so she draped a towel over its face, blotting out that accusation and judgment she had leveled at herself, and only then returned to the candle.

Melting such a colossal candle with a tiny flame was naturally going to take considerable time.

By the time she had completed one full circuit of the hall, the candle had finally softened enough to move to the next step: the section of wax representing early May 2026 had begun to grow slack and pliant from the base, sagging heavily toward the floor like the belly of a woman in her final weeks of pregnancy — except that the "belly" was slowly turning translucent, dark shapes drifting and churning inside it, as if she were carrying a womb full of ghosts.

Sydney Ginn hurried over in two or three quick strides, bent down, and peered into the past world seeping through the melted wax.

The first thing she saw was herself.

According to the Artifact's description, because she was the one who had touched the candle, what surfaced in the wax was primarily her own personal history — the word "primarily" was

necessary because no one exists in isolation, so major events in her surrounding environment that had shaped her would also rise to the surface alongside her story.

The description put it in these exact words:

"...In today's highly integrated world, the historical turning points that carry decisive influence are almost always created by a small minority. The mass movements that occasionally succeeded in the past are now nearly impossible to replicate.

"The decisions of a small oligarchy can influence and alter the fate of all humanity. By the same logic, when the lens narrows to an individual's history, the candle will faithfully render the pivotal figures and events that influenced and reshaped that person's immediate world."

The passage had felt somewhat opaque when she first read it, but after studying the history in the wax for a little while, Sydney Ginn understood.

Take, for instance, the question of why she had crossed paths with Anthony the stalker in early May.

The most immediate reason was that a female friend had invited her out to a bar that evening.

Amber was not a Hunter and had no passage, but she worked in finance for the Morgan House Faction, and she and Sydney Ginn had dealt with each other enough times over the years to get along well; it was that very night, at that bar, that Sydney Ginn had encountered the gilded-and-hollow Anthony.

But dig a little deeper: why had Sydney Ginn — who hated the smell of alcohol more than almost anything — actually agreed to go to a bar with Amber that day?

Because at the end of April, a regional war that had dragged on for years, bleeding the whole world into exhausted inflation, had finally sputtered to its end in a mess of bloodshed and something that felt almost farcical.

The outcome satisfied no one with any claim to justice — no matter which side their justice stood on — but after years of numbing, relentless tragedy, the whole world exhaled in unison; on the day the ceasefire was announced, impromptu celebrations and parades broke out everywhere, and even the news anchors seemed lighter than usual.

Artifact Hunters kept one foot in the Nest and one foot in the human world, and their relationship with ordinary life was always a few steps removed; Sydney Ginn was no different.

But even she, during those days, had felt something like sunlight on her skin — a mood as warm and brimming as the summer that was almost here — and when Amber suggested going out for a drink to celebrate, Sydney Ginn figured she could always have fruit juice, and agreed on the spot.

If the war hadn't ended, Amber wouldn't have invited her out to celebrate; without the bar, she would never have met Anthony; without him becoming her stalker, Sydney Ginn would never have entered the Nest, would never have taken a knife through the throat, would never have stood beside her own corpse, and would certainly never have found this enormous candle.

Everything she had suffered today, traced back to its root, came down to some bald old man thousands of miles away who had started a war in the first place — so how could the people and events closer to home, the ones that had truly shaped her, not be woven into the candle?

"When you reshape the contents of Candlefall, you will find that the greater the physical distance between you and your target, the harder it becomes to alter their past."

The description of "Candlefall" continued immediately with the following passage:

"A person standing right beside you is extremely easy to change. Reach into the Candlefall and nudge or mold the wax itself, and you can shift their position, their experiences, and their actions — and their past will naturally diverge from there.

"Someone on the other side of the city can still be changed, albeit with difficulty; you will find that the portion of the Candlefall surrounding them is stiff and uncooperative, resistant to fine detail, and you can only reshape the broad outline at best — as for how much difference that actually makes once you're done, that's another question entirely.

"And what about someone on the other side of the world? Regrettably, even if such a person appears in your candle, you cannot exert any influence whatsoever over their past."

That hardly mattered, Sydney Ginn thought, studying the still-slightly-blurred scene inside the candle. The person she wanted to change would be stepping out of the bar's back door any moment now, coming to stand right beside her.

The wax had become transparent candle tears, hanging in mid-air just before they could drip to the floor, like a shimmering pool suspended in the air. She touched it lightly and found it wasn't hot.

In that pool, the night of Blackmoor City blazed with countless lights; leaning closer, Sydney Ginn could even catch the distinctive smell of the bar — alcohol, tobacco, and perfume all blended together.

Inside the pond formed by the candle tears, the high-rises, the bar, the shops, and the streets all looked like tiny scale models. A finger-tall version of herself stood at the bar's back door, gazing up at the star-free night sky above Blackmoor City.

Here. This was the moment.

There was no need to stir the candle tears and hunt for the right instant — she only had to wait. In that sense, working the Candlefall was a little like scrubbing through a video timeline: you could drag it forward or back, or simply let it play out at its own natural pace.

She remembered that before she had encountered Anthony, a motorcade of several black Mercedes SUVs had swept past — windows treated against blast, by the look of them — striking enough that she'd watched it go by for a good long moment; and not long after the motorcade rounded the corner, the bar's back door, painted a deep burgundy, had —

There it was.

The moment that small back door cracked open the barest sliver, Sydney Ginn reached out her little finger, pressed it into the candle tears, and held the door shut with her fingertip.

Her shortest finger, and yet it was nearly as wide as the door itself — pressed up against it like that, the sight was genuinely strange.

From behind the door, Anthony shoved again and again, his effort no more than a tiny insect kicking against the pad of her finger; how could someone so minuscule in the candle tears ever hope to push past her enormous fingertip?

She leaned in close to the candle tears and heard, faintly, amid the raucous music on the other side of the door, a muffled curse: "...What the hell? This damn door —"

The tiny Sydney Ginn standing outside in the fresh air paid absolutely no attention to the enormous finger cutting across the air right beside her.

When she heard the cursing from behind the door, she only glanced back once, then stepped a few paces away — a proper Blackmoor City resident always maintained a certain wariness and coolness toward strangers, especially a stranger who was swearing.

The future stalker on the other side of the door gave it a few more desperate shoves, then apparently gave up and turned away; the door fell quiet.

That should do it, Sydney Ginn thought, still not daring to withdraw her finger, holding the door shut. Right?

As long as they never met in the first place, nothing that followed would ever happen.

The fury and resentment she had felt toward Anthony had been doused by something cold and shivering after watching "herself" die — it no longer burned as fiercely as before. Her immediate priority now was simply to run an experiment with the candle; revenge could wait.

The Artifact's description had provided a detailed explanation of how changing the past would affect the present:

"...After the point of divergence, history will continue to unfold naturally along its own internal logic, and the 'present' will change accordingly.

"There is a classic time-travel paradox about whether a person can travel back and kill their own grandfather. If the grandfather dies, the person is never born, and so no one exists to go back and kill the grandfather — and thus the paradox is formed."

Whenever time travel and altering the past were involved — whether in films, novels, or Nest Artifacts — there always seemed to be a great deal that needed to be explained.

"'Candlefall' does not fall into such a paradox. The candle represents a fixed timeline beginning at the moment of the toucher's birth and ending at the moment they touched the candle. Therefore, you cannot change anything that occurred before you were born.

"However, altering history through 'Candlefall' will still affect the present. For example: suppose you melt open the candle from a month ago and crush the version of yourself inside the candle tears. The moment you crush her, you will also vanish from in front of the candle, and the candle will revert to its original state.

"That is an extreme case. If instead you caused yourself to break a leg a month ago, then naturally, one month later, you would not have been out skiing when you encountered a potential client — isn't that right? As previously stated, history will always advance according to its own internal logic and produce the consequences that naturally follow."

In other words, if she prevented herself from meeting Anthony that night, Sydney Ginn would vanish from in front of the candle — without a stalker, she'd have had no reason to enter the

Nest; without entering the Nest, she certainly wouldn't be here now.

"However, to preserve the continuity of the timeline, the memory of having used 'Candlefall' and altered history will remain fully intact; changing history will not cause you to lose that portion of your memory."

Which meant... if Sydney Ginn prevented herself from ever meeting Anthony, she would not appear in the Nest today — yet she would still remember that in "the previous version of history," she had met Anthony, entered the Nest, and altered the timeline.

Preserving the user's memory was how the continuity of the timeline was guaranteed? But why?

Sydney Ginn thought about it for a while, came up with no answer, and let it go. Being able to keep her memories was a tremendous stroke of luck for her; tremendous strokes of luck didn't hold up well under scrutiny, so the thing to do was simply accept it and move on.

Keeping her memories meant she could come back and find "Candlefall" again; measured against an Artifact this precious, what were the nauseating memories Anthony had given her worth?

Inside the candle tears, the tiny Sydney Ginn stamped her foot, turned around, and seemed to be heading back into the bar.

Sydney Ginn lifted her little finger and watched that tiny version of herself pull the door open and disappear into the flickering light and music beyond.

Good. Everything was done. She could extinguish the flame trough and let the candle solidify again.

Only once the candle tears had resolidified would the new timeline and new history set into permanence.

The transparent pool of candle tears hanging in the air slowly turned white, then cloudy, then rose steadily upward, drawn back into the body of the candle, until the surface was smooth and unblemished once more — by any measure, it looked as though it had never melted at all.

Sydney Ginn took one last look at the shrouded corpse nearby, then closed her eyes and waited quietly for the new "present moment" born from the altered history.

After a little while, she opened her eyes.

She had not returned to Blackmoor City. She was still in the Nest.

The pool of blood beneath the shrouded corpse had dried nearly black, the candle stretched away into the distance, and the exhibition hall was utterly, absolutely still.

In her mind, a series of memories lay perfectly intact — being stalked and harassed by Anthony, entering the Nest, being copied by the Resident, the candle melting away — every last one of them, crystal clear, exactly as the Candlefall's description had promised. None of it was gone.

There was only one difference.

The place where she had first encountered Anthony had changed — from the back door of the bar to the front door.

These past two days have been absolutely exhausting... I've been running on empty for a while now and just can't seem to recover. Those of us who are 18 aren't young anymore — not like we were at 17 — I can actually feel the toll it's taking on my body. Ugh.

When you're this tired you can't tell if you're fatigued or hungry, and all you think about all day long is food — but the moment you eat anything you inevitably crash into a food coma right after, making everything worse... These past two days have really been... just awful...

Chapter 24: Sydney Ginn's Altered History

The wound on her neck had mostly stopped hurting — her toughness and resilience had surprised even herself.

But Sydney Ginn's irritation only kept growing, like a heart overgrown with weeds that no amount of pulling could clear.

So much for history being malleable. She'd changed one small detail, and still couldn't bend the trajectory of fate. People always said that missing a single turn could send your whole life in a different direction — what a load of nonsense.

One obsessive stalker, and he'd somehow managed to make the whole thing feel like destiny, like some chosen one had found his fated match. Just thinking about it made her sick.

Sydney Ginn glanced over at the corpse.

She had killed a Resident for the first time — a creature that legend said couldn't be killed — and she'd only managed it by talking it to death. It was hard not to keep second-guessing herself; she kept half-expecting it to lurch back up off the floor the moment she looked away, so every few minutes, she had to look again.

But she was worrying for nothing. Death had already soaked through that body like cold water, fixing it in place completely.

After watching the corpse for a moment longer, she finally let herself relax a little and opened the fire channel again.

One more try — this time, Sydney Ginn intended to cut off any possibility of the two of them ever meeting, right at the root.

She melted the candle at the same point in time and watched as transparent Candle Tears dripped down through the air, pooling once again into a lake below.

In the lake of Candle Tears, a tiny Sydney Ginn and a tiny Amber climbed out of a miniature taxi together, laughing and talking as they walked into the bar — Sydney Ginn watched them disappear through the front entrance, then shifted her gaze back to the street, scanning it carefully.

That night, she clearly remembered that when the stalker Anthony had approached her, he'd said: "You must have arrived before me. Otherwise, there's no way I could have missed a girl like you walking in."

You couldn't take a pickup line at face value, of course — but thinking back, it did seem like Anthony had shown up just after she had.

Sydney Ginn pressed down her mounting irritation and kept her eyes fixed, unblinking, on the bar's front entrance.

There had been a big crowd at the bar that night — within the span of twenty or thirty minutes, four or five groups of strangers poured out of several successive cars — she had never seen so many tiny living people all at once, milling about in twos and threes under the night sky and the glittering lights; it was hard to make anyone out clearly. Her eyes were nearly crossing from the effort when she finally spotted Anthony rounding the street corner.

From what the introduction had said, "killing yourself" via Candle Tears seemed to be possible — but nothing had been said about whether you could kill anyone else with it.

Sydney Ginn decided to try.

What could be more final than simply turning him into a dead man on the spot?

She had never been the type to take a life lightly. In fact, ever since she'd become a Hunter, she had seen plenty of corpses — but not a single one had died by her hand.

But tonight something inside her felt like a shell had cracked open, and whatever was inside it was trying to claw its way out.

Then again, she reasoned — she had already killed "herself." Trying to kill someone from the past, one pathetic stalker, hardly seemed like such a momentous thing by comparison.

If she couldn't kill him, she'd find another way — but either way, it would at least count as learning more about what Candle Tears could do.

Sydney Ginn held her finger suspended above Anthony's head, like some colossal celestial body about to slam into the earth and grind the dinosaurs to dust.

He remained blissfully unaware of it all — hands tucked in his jacket pockets, tall and at ease, the picture of a decent-looking man.

...Squash him flat, and she'd still have to wash her hands after.

Sydney Ginn curled her knuckle and brought it down hard on that carefully styled head.

She had expected it to feel something like crushing a large beetle — instead it was more like pressing down on a slippery ball. With all her force behind the blow, the stalker only stumbled half a step to the side; he steadied himself almost immediately and walked on, not only still alive but seemingly unhurt.

Anthony looked down, muttered a curse, and kicked a pebble out of his path.

...So you couldn't simply reach in and kill someone else. You could only kill yourself?

Well, wasn't that just hilarious.

Irritated as she was, two more attempts seemed to bear out exactly that conclusion: she tried shoving the little Anthony into the road, but an oncoming car swerved clear in time, leaving him with nothing worse than a string of abuse from the driver; after considerable effort she managed to dislodge a neon sign, timing it carefully — only to watch it bow in midair and crash to the ground a hair's breadth from Anthony's nose.

The stalker was clearly not an ordinary person. He'd brushed past danger three times in a row without batting an eye, and strolled right into the bar as though nothing had happened.

"One of the most powerful Artifacts in existence" — the broadcast was doing a lot of overselling. Couldn't kill a person, couldn't prevent two people from meeting — what was the point of this broken candle containing the past at all?

In the end, wasn't everything exactly as it had been? Nothing had changed.

Swallowing her frustration, Sydney Ginn sifted through the Candle Tears, searching for herself.

She had grown fairly practiced at working the Candle Tears by now, and quickly found the moment the two had met: tiny Anthony pushed open the dark red back door, spotted tiny Sydney Ginn, walked straight over to her side, and struck up a conversation.

"I didn't have the courage to ask for your number — I'm not the kind of person who goes around chatting up girls." Anthony said, something almost reflective in his voice. "But you know what? On my way here just now, a neon sign came crashing down right in front of me — this close — if I'd been half a step faster, I'd be dead. The moment I thought about how full of surprises life can be, I knew I couldn't let this chance slip by..."

She had actually helped him upgrade his script?

Sydney Ginn had played a computer game called *The Sims* when she was little, and watching the two of them talk in the *Candle Tears* now, she felt a strange, disorienting flicker of familiarity — she didn't know whether to laugh or cry.

But this was not a computer game.

Sydney Ginn watched that tiny, oblivious version of herself inevitably exchange numbers with Anthony, and could only exhale a long, aggrieved breath and shut the fire channel — she needed to let the *Candle Tears* cool and solidify, letting this stretch of history "set" with the two of them meeting, and then melt it once more before she could try to change things again.

The tiny Sydney Ginn — she had lost count of how many times now — pushed open the back door and stepped out of the bar's tangle of music and liquor-smell, standing outside for a breath of air.

A convoy of matte-black Mercedes SUVs materialized silently out of the dark; each vehicle, reinforced against explosives and bullets, maintained an identical distance from the one ahead of it as they rolled past the bar's back entrance one by one.

As the last car was about to pass, Sydney Ginn reached out and flicked it toward the back door — the matchbox-sized SUV caught the force of her fingertip, lurched involuntarily, veered off the road, and with a shriek of tires and a thunderous crash, drove its nose straight into the bar's back entrance.

The back door, which had already been left ajar, took the full force of the collision — the panel caved in, the hinges twisted — and it now hung there at a crooked angle, clearly beyond closing.

The tiny Sydney Ginn stood two paces from the SUV, face white as a sheet.

Oh — she'd forgotten she was supposed to protect her past self. Well, no matter. She hadn't been hit by the car. Alive was good enough.

It wasn't as if Sydney Ginn had chosen to get mixed up with a stalker of her own free will — look at how much grief it had caused her. Getting the fright of her life was the least she deserved.

With a detached, vaguely exasperated indifference, Sydney Ginn watched the tiny version of herself scramble back a few quick steps and cry out to no one in particular: "Help! Someone's been in a crash!"

If the bar shut down temporarily because of this, it might scatter the two of them before they could even meet —

She hadn't finished the thought when the driver's door of the SUV was shoved open, and a man in a black suit half-fell out, righted himself, and moved quickly to crouch behind the wide-open car door; a gash had been torn open at his left temple, and blood, curling hair, and a clip-on earpiece radio were all matted together in one tangled mess.

But the most conspicuous thing of all was the 9mm pistol gripped between his two hands.

The moment the tiny Sydney Ginn's gaze landed on that black handgun, her lips pressed into a tight line.

The car had been struck and immobilized, and his first move had been to bail out before he became a sitting target; he had taken cover behind the car door to use it as a shield against any potential sniper; even though he had clearly taken a hard knock, the 9mm was still held rock-steady in a position from which he could return fire at any moment — his slightly bent elbow didn't so much as tremble...

Whether inside or outside the Candle Tears, Sydney Ginn could see it plainly: this was a highly trained professional bodyguard.

Then the other vehicles —

Sydney Ginn turned immediately, and just as she'd expected, found that the convoy hadn't wasted a single breath — the other four SUVs had already scattered in an instant, each changing lanes, shifting direction, accelerating, vanishing into the night and the lights in four separate directions.

The level of professionalism here was high, she thought to herself. Very high.

The moment the rear car was struck and lost control, the convoy had already abandoned it and broken formation — each vehicle peeling off onto a different route, rapidly putting distance between themselves — it was clearly a crisis protocol that had been prepared long in advance.

A protocol like that generally served only one purpose: to protect whichever car in the convoy was carrying someone important, ensuring that no potential enemy could determine which vehicle that person was actually in.

"...No, I can't confirm yet what was done to the vehicle. Yes, no attack has been made so far."

The man in the black suit crouched behind the car door, speaking in a low voice into his earpiece: "The situation with the car is strange, but I haven't picked up any signs of an Artifact being used in the area... Correct, there's a bar here and bystanders in the vicinity — they've likely already called the police."

Artifact? Had he just said Artifact?

Sydney Ginn's interest sparked at once and she leaned in closer — fortunately, the man in the black suit was nothing more than a tiny figure inside the Candle Tears, and had no way of seeing the enormous pair of ears hovering somewhere between heaven and earth, cupped directly over his car, catching his every word.

"...Understood," the man in the black suit replied quietly a few seconds later. "In the negotiations and handling that follow, I will not mention Mr. Wei's name."

Mr. Wei?

Sydney Ginn went very still.

A person of importance, and surnamed Wei... could it be that the one so carefully guarded by this convoy was none other than Wellesley — Blackmoor City's foremost figure in both wealth and standing?

Wellesley was certainly a man of great privilege — but he was no head of government. For his security to be this tight, this airtight, it was obvious he knew he was in danger.

Could it be that his impending death hadn't been from natural causes at all, but was the result of human hands?

Had he known, months earlier, that someone was trying to assassinate him — and taken these painstaking precautions because of it?

Curious as she was, Sydney Ginn hadn't forgotten her original purpose, and glanced back at the rear door.

The collision had drawn all the bar patrons outside — some were gawking, some were on their phones, and a few were already snapping photos to post on Twitter; the man in the black suit had a sharp read on the situation, and to avoid causing a scene, had already reholstered the 9mm beneath his jacket — though his hand remained pressed against it, ready to draw at any moment.

Among the gathering crowd, the tiny Sydney Ginn and Amber were speaking quietly to each other; a few steps away, the tiny Anthony was sneaking glances in their direction.

Within seconds, he walked over and greeted the tiny Sydney Ginn with a smile.

There was seriously no way to avoid running into Anthony, was there?

Sydney Ginn cursed under her breath, but after a moment's consideration, decided to set the stalker problem aside for now.

Wellesley appearing in her own Candle Tears history meant that his fate and hers had become entangled in some way — and that was precisely what made it interesting: what possible connection could she have with the soon-to-be-dead richest man in Blackmoor City?

She set aside miniature Sydney Ginn and the stalker, then worked her way backward along the timeline, tracing from the moment Wellesley's motorcade had appeared. Once she had a rough fix on the location, she lit a new wax channel.

If she could keep a close eye on Wellesley's history, she was sure she could dig out a wealth of information...

The more you wait for something, the slower it comes.

Sydney Ginn fidgeted restlessly — now poking at the melting candle, now adjusting the flame — impatient and on edge, her thoughts scattering in every direction. Her gaze swept back and forth across the room, and it was only after quite some time that she abruptly realized two things.

First: the stretch of Candlefall recording the moment she and Anthony had met because of the car accident had solidified and set once again, hardening into the latest version of history.

Second: the corpse on the exhibition hall floor had vanished without a trace, at some point unknown.

I've finally managed to recover a little today! But then I looked at the date — it's already the 5th — and between one blink and the next and another blink, I'm going to be heading back to Shanghai again...

Following the seven Gourd Brothers from a while back, I have no idea how many Minions I owe everyone now — let me take a look...

Okay, I'm back — it's way too many to list in the author's note, so I'll put up a separate chapter tonight and thank everyone properly there (。

Thank you all, my dear patrons, for your overwhelming enthusiasm. I've already put down a deposit on a unit in the obstetrics ward of Shenzhen Second People's Hospital — I'll just be living there permanently from now on, and you're all welcome to visit bearing cakes and gifts.

Why is it always Shenzhen Second People's Hospital, you ask? Because that's where I was born — we like to keep things nice and circular.

Chapter 25: Sydney Ginn, Latest Version, Present Day

Though the opening of the story had been rewritten several times, one thing never changed: the moment Sydney Ginn met Anthony.

It was on the cusp of summer, a night warm and soft as a breath, with a restlessness in the air — and that was when she ran into a pretty-looking snake.

Of course, her eyes couldn't pierce Anthony's smooth, handsome skin and hair to see the dark, twisted sludge churning deep inside his mind — and besides, when a person feels like they're getting everything they want, one by one, they can afford to seem gentle and generous, attentive and kind.

Especially right at the beginning.

"...That genuinely scared me half to death," Sydney murmured to her friend. "He just lost control out of nowhere — the car came straight at me. Lucky I've been keeping fit, my reflexes kicked in and I threw myself to the side in time... otherwise I'd be a human pancake right now, squashed between the bumper and the wall."

Amber sucked in a sharp breath. "That dangerous? Good thing you always go to—"

She caught herself, shot a sideways glance at Anthony, and smoothly redirected: "Good thing you always go to the gym."

Amber kept her hair short, her face round and small, with ears that poked out from her straight-cut bob like a pixie's — and her personality matched the look: sharp, quick, and perceptive.

Sydney had often told her it was a shame she didn't have a passage — the two of them could have been partners in the Nest, venturing in together — though Sydney also knew perfectly well that if Amber did have a passage, she'd be a Hunter for the Morgan House Faction, which would make them potential rivals.

"You had a close call. Working out regularly never hurts."

Anthony, none the wiser, fussed over Sydney with concern and solicitous attention, the lingering fright on his face so pronounced it was as though he himself had nearly died.

In under a minute or two he ran the full emotional gamut — worry and relief giving way to righteous indignation, completing an entire arc: "What kind of driving was that? Was he drunk? Standing off to the side all shifty-eyed, not even coming over to apologize! When the police come to take statements, you need to make sure you explain everything clearly."

What would later seem hollow was, in the moment, quite welcome. Sydney gave him a smile and lowered her voice: "He wasn't drunk... he's probably a private bodyguard. I caught a glimpse of his sidearm just now."

"A bodyguard?" Amber glanced sideways and immediately let out an "Oh," her voice understanding. "No wonder his hand's been tucked under his jacket the whole time... There's no one else in the car — did his client leave?"

"Left," Sydney answered. "There was a whole convoy ahead of him — the moment his car had trouble, they all scattered immediately. I don't know what went wrong with his vehicle. Why he crashed into the door like that."

The moment Anthony heard the word "gun," his face had tightened almost imperceptibly. He hesitated, then reached out and steered both women behind the bar's back door, repeating quietly, "Better safe than sorry... What if he's not a bodyguard? What if he's some kind of unhinged maniac? Why don't we go inside?"

At the time, Sydney thought he seemed steady and cautious — someone with a level head.

"I'd rather stay out here a bit longer," Amber said, her gaze drifting several times toward the black-suited figure behind the SUV. "I just love a good spectacle. You two don't mind, do you?"

Anthony glanced at her, then looked at Sydney.

Amber wasn't there for the spectacle. Sydney knew that perfectly well.

Compared to the day-to-day business of a Hunter House Faction, a car crashing into a door barely qualified as worth mentioning.

What's more, the look in Amber's eyes was nothing like that of the ordinary rubbernecker: there was a bright, focused light in her gaze as it moved from the car to the people, as though that small beam of light had already snagged on something amid the noise and chaos of the scene.

With a major Hunter House Faction at her back, Amber was extraordinarily well-informed. The Matthew Effect held true here as well: the more a person knew, the better they understood

where to look for information, and the more clearly they could recognize what actually counted as information.

Unfortunately, Sydney couldn't simply ask her what she'd spotted — Anthony was right there beside them.

"Then I'll keep you company," she said.

Anthony showed no sign of reluctance.

"The public order in Blackmoor City keeps getting worse. I suppose even the wealthy are starting to feel the water heating up around them." He leaned against the wall, chatting idly with Sydney: "Ordinary people like us can't afford bodyguards — we just have to look out for ourselves... especially a young, attractive woman like you. You're more of a target than most."

With his gaze resting warm and intent on her face, Sydney instinctively reached up to smooth her hair and said with a smile, "I'm not particularly worried."

"Having a boyfriend makes you safer," Anthony said. "Didn't your boyfriend come with you tonight?"

"I'm single."

Because she had a good impression of him, Sydney didn't bother minding the transparency of that gambit. She thought for a moment, then added: "I can take care of my own safety. I won't go into details, but I do have a small ladies' pistol at home, and a hunting knife I had specially brought back from Europe."

Anthony blinked.

Something seemed to rise in his throat, then settle back, held in his mouth while his tongue turned it over — he was weighing it, choosing his words. As he filtered and deliberated, Amber gave Sydney a quiet tug and murmured: "His colleague just showed up."

Sydney looked through the crowd and, sure enough, spotted a car that had just pulled in; the driver who climbed out wore the same black suit and strode quickly toward the bodyguard who'd caused the crash.

Whatever had caused that bodyguard to lose control moments ago, the danger had long since dissolved from the surrounding air, replaced now by curious bar patrons, a deeply worried bar manager, and freshly arrived emergency responders. The bodyguard himself had finally begun to

relax — he was sitting in the driver's seat with the door wide open, submitting to questions from two police officers while letting the paramedics check his pupils.

"Brother Dylan," the newly arrived black suit called out.

"Ivan?"

The crash-bodyguard looked up at the voice and startled visibly, lowering the cotton pad he'd been pressing against the wound at his temple. "How is it you who came?"

The second bodyguard, Ivan, seemed lower in both rank and experience, and his manner was respectful and proper: "There was a problem here, and the boss got a bit uneasy going to pick something up, so a lot of extra hands were deployed on short notice. Sister Mi was worried you'd have a hard time managing alone, so she sent me over to look after things."

For some reason, his voice ran a full register lower than most people's. Sydney was entirely certain that Amber, just like her, had pricked up her ears and inched several steps closer before they could make out even the general gist of what was said.

Dylan's reception of this backup was noticeably lacking in warmth or gratitude.

"Understood," he said, pressing the cloth back against his wound, his whole manner suggesting he had no wish to say more and equally no wish for Ivan to say more either — perhaps because there were police officers right beside them.

"We're still open for business as usual," a bartender called out loudly from the back door, apparently hoping to nudge the patrons back inside to keep spending money. "Nothing to worry about — everything's fine, folks!"

"Shall we?" Anthony bent his head and said to Sydney with great gentleness: "Let's go back in, sit down properly, have a good talk. Let me buy you a drink."

Running into Anthony tonight had been entirely unexpected; she found herself torn on the spot between "bodyguard crashes car" and "attractive man" — it was Amber who resolved the dilemma with a smile, tipping her chin toward the bar door and saying, "You go ahead. If anything interesting comes up, I'll fill you in later."

Sydney had little choice but to tell her, "Come find me inside in a bit" — and only after Amber promised did she follow Anthony into the bar.

As she settled into her seat, a thought flickered through her mind, briefly catching on the one called Ivan. He'd said something about "the boss going to pick something up," hadn't he? Pick up what, exactly? And was it connected to whatever had caught Amber's interest?

But she didn't pursue the thought. Because Anthony had settled in beside her just then, a strand of hair falling across his face, and the light in his eyes shimmered softly in the shadow of that fringe — as if she were some rare treasure the rest of the world had, inexplicably, overlooked.

Later, Sydney would reflect that no matter what the quarry, anyone capable of being a Hunter needed a certain instinct — for instance, there was nothing she could identify as remarkable about the way she was dressed or presented that night, and yet Anthony had singled her out from the crowd of bar patrons at a glance.

In the Nest, she was a Hunter. Back in the world of people, she was prey.

"What would you like to drink?" he asked.

"I can't stand alcohol," Sydney said it right there in a bar and couldn't help laughing at herself.

Using "I don't drink" as their opening topic, she began her conversation — and her courtship — with Anthony.

Over two or three months, they went from the occasional meeting to growing steadily closer; and after Anthony's first visit to her home, he became, in all appearances, the most perfect boyfriend in the world — though the illusion didn't last particularly long.

At some point — she had lost count of how many times they'd met by then — their conversation drifted back to the black SUV that had crashed into the bar's back door that early May evening; and it was only then that Sydney remembered she'd never asked Amber what she had actually discovered that night — perhaps it had ultimately amounted to nothing, which was why Amber had never thought to mention it.

"By the way — I remember you saying that night that you had a hunting knife you'd had specially brought back from Europe." Anthony's interest suddenly caught. "Hunting knives exist here too, so what makes a European one special? Let me have a look."

Sydney immediately sprang up from the couch, fetched the knife, and launched into its brand, its craftsmanship, its value; and the more animated she became in the telling, the more Anthony was moved to want.

"I'm not trying to take it from you," he'd said then, still willing to play the part, with a convincing air of mild embarrassment: "Could I borrow it for a while? I have a friend who specifically collects knives — I'd like to show it to him."

Sydney had thought it over and decided that for the next month or two, she probably wouldn't need to go back into the Nest. And even if she did, she had other weapons and tools. "Sure — just bring it back when I need it."

...She slowly opened her eyes, unable for a moment to tell which was cold and stiff — her body, or the exhibition hall's tiled floor. The two had all but fused into one.

Anthony never returned the hunting knife.

Sydney looked at the two threads of memory running through her mind — bewilderment and sudden clarity arriving together.

In silence, she turned her head, her gaze traveling out across the floor to where the enormous candle loomed across the exhibition hall...

And there, seated before the candle: the back of her own figure.

Ah. So that was it.

In this second version of history — altered for reasons she still didn't understand — Anthony had borrowed the knife and never given it back; Sydney had entered the Nest without the knife, and naturally had no way of plunging it into the Resident's throat.

And so the Resident had never inflicted that same wound upon its own throat...

And so she had survived.

Labor Day holiday just wrapped up and I'm back to my restless self — ran around for most of the day, so the chapter's a bit late... Exhausted every single day, all I want is to get home and sleep...

This author's note is being written on an e-ink screen! I've been buying them and returning them and buying them again — this is already the third one I've gone through. Will this one make it past the 7-day no-questions-asked return window? Stay tuned... The first two I sent back the moment they arrived.

(Okay, I cannot do em-dashes — are you trying to kill me.)

Chapter 26 — Sydney Ginn's Choice at the Crossroads

For the first few seconds, Sydney Ginn stared from a distance at that other version of herself — her own back, crouched over a growing flame — while her mind detonated like a nuclear warhead, leaving nothing but scorched wasteland. Fragmented thoughts drifted like fallout, swirling without shape, impossible to catch.

Why did she have two separate lines of memory?

In the first memory line, on the night she had encountered the stalker Anthony, there had been no car crash behind the bar's back door; she had never mentioned owning a hunting knife, so Anthony had never "borrowed" it.

She had entered the Nest intending to retrieve something that could deal with Anthony, only for things to spiral out of control — at the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid, a Resident had duplicated itself into her exact likeness.

That Resident believed with every fiber of its being that it was the real "Sydney Ginn."

It had even found an explanation for the missing backpack, phone, and hunting knife: a scuffle before boarding the taxi had sent it scrambling into the car in such a hurry that it had left everything behind.

The truly thorny part was this — if the Resident was so utterly convinced that it was the real Sydney Ginn, then she had no way of ruling out the possibility that she herself might be the Resident. Sydney had originally thought that having her phone and hunting knife on her person proved she was the genuine article; but what if she had simply forgotten how she had seized those things from the original?

Hadn't boarding the taxi cost her a chunk of memory? If that missing memory happened to cover the moment she had transformed into Sydney Ginn and wrested her belongings from the real one, then she had absolutely no evidence left to comfort herself with.

Between the self lying on the floor and the figure sitting before the candle — which one was actually the Resident?

No... that question was a bottomless rabbit hole; fall in and you'd never climb back out. She could set it aside for now. Assume she was the real Sydney Ginn, and work through the timeline

from there.

After the Resident left, she had hailed a second car, followed the Passenger Rules to the letter, and trailed the Resident all the way to the Museum of Modern Art. On the basement level, Sydney had found her moment and driven her knife into the Resident's throat.

Not a single thing she had hoped for came to pass.

The Resident simply stood there, both hands pressed to the wound; in the fraction of a second she'd had to look, she hadn't even registered whether it was bleeding — and she'd had no chance to look properly, because almost immediately the Resident turned to look at her and smiled, baring a set of teeth she knew far too well.

"Since you copied my appearance, it stands to reason that your throat can be cut open too."

The first memory line ended with her neck splitting open, blood spraying in all directions, her body collapsing to the ground like a stone statue struck down by a wrecking ball.

Sydney Ginn knew that she had died.

Yet death was not her ending; after death, a second memory line had begun.

On the night she met Anthony, a black SUV had barreled straight toward her, and after she barely threw herself clear, it slammed into the back door. The conversation had started with the driver being a bodyguard — and from there she had mentioned her hunting knife to Anthony; not long after, he had taken it from her.

Stepping into the Nest, Sydney had muttered a quiet curse — one fewer weapon always left her feeling a little exposed.

After that, the second memory line was indistinguishable from the first: she heard the broadcast, stepped onto the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid, hailed the taxi, got duplicated by the Resident... the only difference came at the very end — when the second memory line stopped, she opened her eyes on the floor.

Keeping her gaze fixed on the silhouette crouched before the candle, Sydney eased herself off the floor as soundlessly as she could. The floor tiles were smooth and cold beneath her, not a single drop of blood on them.

The second memory line had replaced the first, becoming the true, most recent version of history — which meant she had never stabbed the Resident, and her own throat had never been

slit with a single sentence.

She didn't dare straighten up fully, terrified the Resident would notice her, so she retreated on all fours toward the pillar, clamping her breath down hard until her chest began to ache with a dull, spreading pressure — she had to keep it contained, or she was genuinely afraid she might start sobbing.

...How does a single sentence slit a person's throat?

Faced with the image of a gaping mouth opening across her own neck, she couldn't even decide which terrified her more: being killed again without warning, or discovering she wasn't truly human at all — that she was a Resident, doomed to wander the Nest forever?

If she wasn't a Resident, why had her own throat so obediently mirrored the other's wound?

Not one of these questions did Sydney Ginn have an answer to.

Back pressed flat against the pillar, eyes clenched shut, one hand clamped over her mouth, she desperately wished she could draw every part of herself inward, compress into a ball too small for the Nest to ever find.

No — calm down first, think...

There were several pieces of circumstantial evidence pointing to the other one being the Resident: first, it had no phone, no hunting knife, and no backpack; second, according to what she'd witnessed in the first memory line, it had boarded the taxi without following the Passenger Rules and still gotten off without incident.

Third — and most compelling — the throat was nothing but a thin layer of skin wrapped around arteries, nerves, blood vessels, a windpipe, and a voice box; could a living person really be stabbed in the throat, treat themselves on the spot, and carry on as though nothing had happened?

Sydney Ginn calmed down a fraction and stole a careful glance around the pillar.

The Resident was still seated before the candle, fiddling again and again with the flame control, looking thoroughly impatient waiting for the wax to melt. The candle had begun to soften and sag, sending a pool of nearly transparent wax hanging in the air — Candlefall. From this distance, Sydney could just barely make out what sounded like a voice from within the wax calling out "Mr. Wellesley."

The candle had to be the key — the reason she had been pulled back from death and left with two lines of memory.

The broadcast had called it an immensely powerful Artifact, and that appeared to be no exaggeration — anything capable of dragging a person back from death was formidable beyond measure.

But why was the Resident so utterly fascinated by it?

Sydney glanced around the room and noticed that the far wall of the gallery was covered in a dense block of text — an exhibit description. In general, some kind of "item description" existed near any Artifact in the Nest; that had to be it.

The only problem was that the description was on the opposite side of the gallery, and to reach it she would have to pass directly behind the Resident.

No matter how she looked at it, she had to deal with the Resident first.

Regardless of whether she herself was truly Sydney Ginn, once the "Sydney Ginn" beside the candle was gone, she would naturally become the one true Sydney Ginn — right?

When one's own survival was at stake, it seemed even certain fundamental, principled things could be quietly glossed over... until today, Sydney Ginn had never imagined she was capable of thinking this way.

But the Resident could kill her with a single sentence — so how, exactly, was she supposed to kill a Resident?

Her gaze swept across the room and landed on the hiking backpack slumped on the floor nearby, its opening flopped open at an angle, revealing a crumpled hand towel and a jumble of odds and ends inside.

"Where did it go—"

From across the room, the Resident was still fixed on the Candlefall, murmuring to itself with obvious impatience. "He said something important just now, I think... didn't he? Where did he say it..."

Taking advantage of its complete absorption in the candle, Sydney quickly slipped off her shoes and padded forward one careful step at a time in sock-wrapped feet toward the backpack — and sure enough, made not a sound.

As she passed the backpack, she reached in and hooked out a long hand towel with one swift motion, then retreated quickly to the far end of the hall — she didn't dare stand in the open expanse of the gallery and crane her neck back at the exhibit description, so she ducked behind another piece on display at the far end of the room; it was a fair distance from the candle, constructed from bundles of long wooden rods fanning outward in a spiral radiating pattern — handsome enough, if incomprehensible as art — but it would just about manage to conceal a crouching woman.

The Resident would discover her absence from the floor sooner or later.

Even if its attention was entirely on the candle for now, it wouldn't be long before it noticed that its own throat was perfectly intact, the wound erased. This was the only window she had to strike first — but how could she use it?

Should she spend this window reading the candle's description, or should she move against the Resident immediately?

If she struck first, could the candle become the Resident's trump card, its way of turning the tables on her? Had her throat being slit by a single sentence in the first timeline had anything to do with the candle?

Unfortunately, when Sydney had followed the Resident down here in the first timeline, she'd had no chance to read the candle's description carefully.

When people stand at a fork in the road and make a choice, they can never foresee the full chain of dominoes that will fall afterward — just as Sydney had never imagined that entering the Nest to deal with Anthony would lead her to news of an Artifact, and that searching for the Artifact would lead to being duplicated by a Resident.

Which path should she choose?

After a moment's hesitation, Sydney still couldn't say what exactly compelled her — but she took out her phone, silenced the shutter sound, aimed it at the exhibit description on the distant wall, zoomed in, and took several photos in quick succession.

Before she could even enlarge the photos to read the description properly, the Resident suddenly rose to its feet — her entire body clenched tight, shrinking what felt like two sizes, as she peered through the gaps between the wooden rods and fixed her gaze on its back.

It hadn't noticed anything was wrong yet. It seemed dissatisfied with that particular stretch of candle, and it placed its hand along the wax, searching for something as it took a few steps, then crouched back down and snapped the flame control open with a sharp crack — pak.

The flame wavered like a water plant swayed by a current, flaring up to illuminate the brows and eyes that were her own.

Sydney let out a small, cautious breath of relief and enlarged the first photo, reading as fast as she could.

The description in the first photo was the closest to her, and though the text was blurry, she could make out the general sense of it. By the time she had finished reading, her mouth had gone completely dry: no wonder she had been pulled back from the fatal ending of the first timeline — it turned out the Resident had accidentally altered history. She had never once imagined there could be something so inconceivable inside the Nest.

If she could bring it back to Blackmoor City...

She tapped open the second photo, but the angle and distance were far less ideal than the first, making the specific text genuinely difficult to decipher.

Never mind — the most important thing was now clear: as powerful as the candle was, capable of reversing history, it could not be weaponized as an attack.

Then it was time to proceed with the original plan.

Sydney Ginn made her decision, pressed two fingers to the screen, and locked her phone.

In the display that went dark in an instant, a second face stared back at her.

Feels like all the numbers have been kuacha kuacha sliding down lately... I guess that's the price you pay for writing niche stuff (not really though lol)

Getting on another plane tomorrow ahhhhh

When oh when will I ever get to go home and just lie down in peace ahhhhhh

Chapter 27 — Wait, I've Been an Ungrateful Wretch Since April 23rd?

Time flies, the years slip by, and in the blink of an eye, those seven Gourd Brothers I once promised you all have...

Never grown up, because I still haven't had them...

I always feel like I wrote my last reader appreciation post just a little while ago — then I actually checked, and it was April 23rd?? So I've been heartless, shameless, and completely without conscience ever since?

I'm so sorry, everyone. You've all been cheering me on and supporting me without end, and I've been an ungrateful wreck without end. Let me count my blessings, tally up the ledger, and figure out how many of those original seven Gourd Brothers have turned into Minions by now. Don't go flipping past this just because it's an appreciation chapter — what if your name gets called?

I've been running around nonstop lately, and I figure there's no paying my debts properly until I get home. Thankfully this stretch of running around looks like it's finally in its last leg — Shanghai is my last stop. Once I'm back, I swear I won't want to leave the house for the rest of the year. I love writing, writing loves me, and nothing is going to come between us.

(Unless someone warmly invites me to New York to report on Artifacts.) (I could literally leave right now.) (What do you mean a lowly web novel writer should work harder — isn't that exactly why I need inspiration?!)

The crowd of people waiting to pick up their babies outside the OB-Ginn department of City SZ Second People's Hospital has grown quite a bit:

Well, well — Bohemian Xiang (a name I dare not examine too closely) has shown up to show support from day one. I'd think quite a few of you remember this legend... I genuinely can't remember how many babies I owe you... Can we just call it one for now...?

A new legend has arrived: Gunsmith Rousseau. You single-handedly added two spots to the baby queue, and honestly, my knees are trembling a little. The username feels vaguely familiar, but I don't dare say so out loud. Are you a new reader lured in by the Artifact report angle? Or are you ancestral blessings bestowed upon me by the apocalypse (??).

b11111111 — I refuse to believe you got the right number of 1s the first time you typed your username after registering! I'm fairly sure you can't tell if I wrote too many or too few either (not really), but the point is, a baby has been owed (.)

Thank you Yaoyao and Linlin for the KFC (yes, I have abandoned McDonald's — the Golden Arches have let me down, and did you know they don't even use Heinz ketchup anymore?), to Tiejia Baitang for the desserts (desserts have gotten so pricey — I looked and egg tarts are over 20 yuan now), and thank you to Chushi Qingzi Chan, Mo Yuan (pronounced "black bird"), and Yingyou — each of you stuffed a cup of bubble tea into my hands (the flavors these days are unbelievable, who comes up with them?). And Haines even treated me to dinner — between all of you, you covered my entire day!

How many babies does that make? Oh, that's five more — so what!

Too many persimmons and your mouth won't pucker!

Thank you to Ershisi's QD for buying me a DQ (Dairy Queen is genuinely amazing, and your timing was incredibly lucky), to vitang (you even bought me two mouthwashes, all the way from Shanghai), to Fengyin (did I forget to pay you back from last time?), and to Jiiiiii for sending an opening ceremony flower arrangement...

And to Libao Baobao's Baobao (honestly, I don't even know the story behind that name — please, someone, explain it to everyone), to Zhangao Gao de Yu (that fish really is very tall — I've been snacking on it since last book), to Junmi xi (all longtime readers!), to Dongxie (oh goodness, I feel so bad, hehe), to Aaaaa What Is Happening (what IS happening)—

And to Murakami's Kafka (no consort sitting next to you this time), to Sanxi Yi (I think I spotted your comment), to Ciel Mo (whatever you said — I'm only rounding up a few sheep here), and to Shiwanfute (were you the one who recommended that giant Northeast-style bathhouse?).

Thank you to Chen Chengye (new reader?), to Xiao Sun Daini Fei (not a new reader), to Liu Jinqi (very much acquainted), to Parsons Prep, to Emmy-chan, to whhit, to MARGINAL Yu, to Ya'er (nice to see you again), to Reader 20240202130643416 (I nearly died typing all those digits), and to Reader 20230109114807508 (please, I'm begging you both, go set a proper username).

Let me catch my breath and continue:

Sanjiu's Exclusive Bandage (fair enough, you don't shower), Meituodi Diudiu, Xuanfeng Feipil who tips like it's a daily check-in, Yuezhua Likes Adventure Stories, Mi'a'ao, Lin Sanjiu's

Dog (?), Yuxia Xie Wuchu Bu Zai, Ni Yongyuan Shi Qian Taiyang De, mocaozy, yoleen Yu...

And to everyone who's thrown in monthly votes — I can see almost all of you, I just genuinely ran out of room to write. I'm deeply grateful that you're willing to cast your votes on something this under-the-radar. I'll admit I'm a little worried about the numbers lately, and seeing monthly votes and readthrough stats is genuinely reassuring.

You know what I've realized — saving up all the tips and thanking everyone at once makes it look like business is booming (not really)... It's just twelve babies, right? Come on, let's run through the entire Chinese zodiac (.

Chapter 28: Hello Everyone, This Is Your Southern Airlines Ambassador

Welcome to the Southern Airlines Passenger First-Hand Experience Channel, where you can feel the full flight experience in real time — no Wi-Fi, no social distancing, two hours of bolt-upright seats that won't recline, and not a meal in sight. No need to leave home to suffer along with us.

That said, I'm honestly pretty content — the two girls sitting next to me smell lovely, not funky at all (if anyone smells funky it's probably me, I've been running around all day), and the flight isn't even delayed!

What an honor!

Right now the seatback is digging into the back of my skull, the seatbelt buckle is jabbing my butt, my bag is crushing my feet, and the screen in front of me is playing a podcast called "Why We Love the Song Dynasty," while a faint but unmistakable odor drifts from somewhere up ahead (someone jumped the gun on that one).

I sat down and haven't looked up once — I'm racing against the clock to bring you this live flight report. Why, you ask?

Because.

Your wandering author won't touch down until seven-thirty.

Who knows

whether today's fragmented, rootless

update

will

post at what time

in China.

A humble poem, offered with gratitude for your kind readership.

Finished the poem and realized I have a tiny bit of time left, so let me ramble for another two cents' worth: the new chapter is five hundred words in! Still starring our favorite big-eared monkey (?) Sydney Ginn!

If heaven would give me two — no, three hours, I could definitely get the update out today.

But who knows what time I'll reach the hotel... because I'm landing at Hongqiao Airport and staying over in Pudong... My greatest hobby in life is making charitable donations to airlines and Didi drivers.

Why do I always stay in Pudong? Because that's where the starting point's Nest is located.

I'm about to venture deep into their lair once again!

(Can my editor see this? I'm definitely NOT saying you're a Resident.)

Huh? What if it's too late by the time I get to the hotel?

First we eat, first we eat — come on, fill up your cups, let's all finish eating and then we'll talk, eat first and then we'll talk.

Chapter 29: The Attack Pattern of Sydney Ginn's Resident

The very first words Sydney Ginn heard from behind her, in the midst of her terror, stirred something unexpected — a faint, fleeting sense of relief.

"I knew you'd come back to life long ago,"

Her own voice drifted up from somewhere behind and above her head, thick as a cloud of miasma, low and unhurried. "You're so easy to fool — nothing like me at all."

Good, Sydney Ginn thought, spinning on one knee and twisting her body around in the same motion. Thank god its first words were a waste of breath.

What did it matter that it had noticed early? One way or another, the two of them were always going to end up here, fighting for their lives.

She had already steeled herself for this — and yet the moment "Sydney Ginn" flashed into her field of vision, she couldn't help it: her breath caught, as if someone had shoved her hard in the chest.

Compared to the "Sydney Ginn" she remembered, the Resident looked somehow more vivid, more real: a forehead glinting with tiny beads of sweat in the firelight, a strand of golden-brown hair stuck to her temple; the fine down on her cheeks, the warm breath spilling from between her lips...

Those eyes, burning so bright it looked like nothing else was left inside them.

This was Sydney Ginn. This was herself — and yet she herself was standing outside that self, arm raised high, bringing a dark shape crashing down toward her face.

Sydney Ginn threw herself sideways at the last possible moment. A thunderous impact exploded beside her ear as the exhibit was bitten deep, gouged into a massive crater; amid the shower of splinters she squeezed her eyes shut and rolled frantically across the floor, already unable to tell how many wooden shards had stabbed into her face and the palms of her hands.

"Just die already — there can only be one Sydney Ginn in this world!"

The voice — strange, and yet entirely her own — rang out in wave after wave through the exhibition hall; with a grunt of effort, "Sydney Ginn" wrenched a fire axe free from deep within the sculpture of wooden slats.

When had it...?

She didn't even finish the thought. Sydney Ginn sprang to her feet and bolted — only to remember, too late, that she had taken her shoes off earlier. Her feet were bare except for socks, and on the slick exhibition hall floor she had almost no traction at all.

In the instant before she went sprawling, she committed: arms forward, body flat, she launched herself into a racing dive — since she'd opened her eyes again, she seemed to have spent more time face-down on the floor than standing upright.

The fire axe hit the floor tiles with a muffled thud, burying itself deep — barely one step behind her.

Sydney Ginn had never in her life peeled off a sock so fast.

While the axe was still stuck in the floor, she ripped the sock off and flung it straight at her other self's face, aimed right at her eyes. Like any normal person, the Resident had no desire to take a sock to the eyeballs, and jerked its head aside.

Sydney Ginn would have loved to keep the momentum going, but there was no time to pull off the other sock — the Resident had already closed the distance in one stride and was hauling the axe up high above her.

Almost on instinct, she drove her foot hard into the Resident's ankle.

Once a Resident had replicated a human form, it was nothing more than an ordinary human body; when one person kicked another's shinbone with every ounce of strength they had, the pain was real, and the Resident stumbled back two lurching steps. Sydney Ginn seized the opening, scrambled upright, and ran — one foot gripping, one foot sliding.

But even as she ran, her mind kept drifting back to that ankle she'd just kicked.

It was something she had never once thought about before: what shoes was the Resident wearing?

She already knew that when a Resident replicated someone, it couldn't reproduce things like backpacks or phones. But what about clothes? What about shoes?

In that split-second glimpse during the life-or-death scramble just now...

"Wait!"

Sydney Ginn knew perfectly well that with one bare foot she had no chance of outrunning the Resident — and the more chances she gave it to talk, the more danger she was in. She spun around and called out: "What are you wearing on your feet?"

The other "Sydney Ginn," teeth gritted, bearing down hard behind her, faltered for just a moment at the question — but it wasn't distracted. It brought the axe down first; only after Sydney Ginn barely dodged did it laugh between ragged breaths: "Trying to buy yourself time with small talk, are you?"

"Residents can't replicate backpacks — and they can't replicate clothing either!"

Terrified it would catch up, Sydney Ginn rushed on: "You copied my appearance, but the shoes you're wearing are still your own. You must have my memories of what I was wearing when I came to the Nest today — they're in your head, aren't they? Look down. Think about it. Do the clothes in your memory match what's actually on your body?"

"Sydney Ginn" blinked, and — incredibly — actually looked down at her clothes.

Even a Resident of the Nest couldn't go around naked; they always had something on.

This one, perhaps because it was a Vulture — always ready to take someone else's shape at a moment's notice — wore plainly practical, versatile black trousers and black shoes. You couldn't really blame Sydney Ginn for never having noticed; when a face identical to your own surfaces out of the darkness, you don't tend to pay much attention to what shoes it has on.

"You're right, actually," it said when it raised its head again, and its voice was clear and composed: "When I enter the Nest at night, I always wear all black so I won't draw attention. If you thought you could trick me with that, it's almost funny."

It swung the fire axe loosely at its side and gave a small, light kick with the toe of one shoe.

"I can even tell you that I bought these shoes on sale at Bloomingdale's — because I thought, anything I wear into the Nest just needs to hold up, there's no point paying full price for something that looks good."

Now it was Sydney Ginn's turn to freeze. That logic was unmistakably, purely her own. She could even recall several pieces of clothing she had bought for exactly the same reason.

"And you?" The Resident smiled at her. A strand of hair caught on its lips, framing its teeth. "If you really have my memories, you'll find that it's your clothes that don't add up."

Sydney Ginn looked down involuntarily, her gaze dropping to the khaki joggers she was wearing.

She remembered pulling on these very trousers before she climbed out the window... but where had they come from?

Most people could more or less remember where they'd bought their own clothes — but these joggers felt as though they had been pulled onto her by someone else just a few seconds ago, so unfamiliar they left her mind blank.

Why was there no memory of ever buying them?

"It seems that after a Resident replicates its original, it smooths and polishes the memories — touches up any details that don't match reality, papers over the cracks... That's why you're so utterly convinced that you're the real me."

While she stood there with her head bowed, staring blankly at the trousers, the other "Sydney Ginn" had been slowly closing in; its voice, its warmth, its smell, and those feet in their black shoes were steadily encroaching on her existence.

"Residents can't be killed — I've heard that."

It said quietly, "But I'll feel better once I've taken away your ability to move first... I'd imagine that copying a human form has a time limit for you, doesn't it? When the time runs out and you still haven't gone to Blackmoor City to replace me, you'll revert back to your Resident form, won't you?"

Wait — what was it saying?

Something stirred deep in her mind, like a quiet needle-prick, and a grain-of-rice speck of light broke through — but the light only flickered for an instant before heavier, more urgent shadows closed over it again.

She neither heard nor saw it coming — it was something beyond the five senses, some instinct entirely her own, that made Sydney Ginn suddenly duck low and lunge forward in the same heartbeat the fire axe swung down toward her skull, wrapping her arms around the Resident and driving it clean off its feet.

The Resident's arm, coiled with the full force of its swing, came down hard across her ear and the side of her head; but the axe itself — the part that would have killed her — scraped past her shoulder at last and spun away, clattering onto the floor tiles a short distance off.

The two of them crashed down together, and the back of the Resident's head struck the floor with a sound that clenched every organ in Sydney Ginn's body.

"You copied my form," it still managed to force out, struggling, "so you too —"

Before it could finish the sentence, Sydney Ginn had already yanked the towel she'd tucked into the back waistband of her trousers and crammed it at its mouth.

The Resident twisted its head left and right to avoid it; the towel didn't make it in cleanly, but it did stop the sentence from being completed.

Sydney Ginn didn't dare let go. Gritting her teeth, she absorbed punch after punch landing on her body, both hands holding the long towel taut — and when the Resident's lips parted for just an instant, she shoved it deep into its mouth. The towel stretched like a rope across her other self's cheek, forcing its tongue back into the depths of its throat, leaving it capable of nothing but muffled, wordless moaning.

"I think... I think I understand now..." She stared at the face distorted beneath the towel and said quietly: "I think I've figured out your attack pattern. You really are the Resident."

Yesterday I got to the hotel, finished dinner, typed for a while longer, and then simply couldn't hold on any longer and fell asleep... Got up early this morning to keep going, otherwise I'd feel guilty all day.

This hotel stay was basically mooching off Qidian — you know how they had that promotional event for the Joy of Life drama production? Nothing to do with me, but I sort of snuck along for the ride, kind of like a stowaway situation... I keep getting this vague, nervous feeling that someone's going to audit the books afterward and make me pay for my room. Someone from Qidian told me Maoni was staying there too, and — rounding up in the boldest possible way — that puts you and Maoni in the same league.

Rounding up with strides that wide, you could step from the Huangpu River all the way to Tokyo in one go...

Chapter 30 — The Way Sydney Ginn Fights, and Proving Who's Real

Looking back now, it was probably because of the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion that Sydney Ginn had almost never truly fought a Resident face-to-face — let alone fought one to the death.

It wasn't until she was released back from death itself that she finally arrived at a theory.

Every Resident had its own way of surviving and its own method of attack — that much she knew.

But "method of attack" was still a vague and sweeping phrase: a punch to the face was an attack, and a single sentence that split your throat open was also an attack — so too, then, was crowding out your very existence, inch by inch, one sliver at a time.

"You said it yourself — Residents alter the details of memories, patching over gaps and inconsistencies. That's why a Resident is absolutely, unshakably convinced that it is the original."

Sydney Ginn was barely keeping the towel in place. If the strength the Resident was now using to thrash beneath her was actually her own strength — well, all those years of working out had clearly paid off, because right now her teeth were clenched, her arms were trembling, and she had no idea how much longer she could hold on before she got thrown off.

But there were things that still needed to be said, and not a single word of them could be skipped.

There could only ever be one Sydney Ginn in this world — the Resident was right about that.

"But when I look back at myself, I find that I'm not like that. Ever since I discovered there was another 'Sydney Ginn,' I haven't been able to shake the self-doubt — especially after I died and came back. I can't explain why I copied your wounds, or why I couldn't remember where I bought my pants. If I were the Resident, I should have had a smooth answer ready for all of those questions long ago."

The towel was jammed deep into "Sydney Ginn's" mouth. Her lips were pressed into two long, thin, taut lines; teeth half-showing, half-hidden; saliva, spit, retching sounds, and her tongue all writhing and churning together in the depths of her throat as though she was still trying to speak — her own face reduced to this, and it was almost unbearable to look at.

Sydney Ginn knew what it wanted to say.

"You're going to say that it's precisely because I'm the Resident that, when faced with questions I can't answer, I turn them into proof that I'm the real one — right?"

A muffled moan came from its throat, something that sounded like an angry "Yes."

"Impressive — no matter what challenge I raise, you can twist it into doubt I'm casting on myself."

The Resident drove a fist into her side, and for one instant it felt as though it had punched the air and the light right out of the room.

Dark spots bloomed across Sydney Ginn's vision. She forced through the pain, kept bearing down with everything she had, and managed only to wrench her body sideways and curl her legs up, using her thighs as a barricade to absorb the pounding blows — while her other knee still had to pin down its other arm. Her muscles were screaming.

"This is your attack pattern, isn't it?"

She had to say it out loud. Only by saying it out loud was there any hope at all. "Between the two of us, you're the one with absolute, unshakable certainty, and I'm the one full of fear and doubt. It's that tiny seed of doubt in my heart that gives your words their killing power — that's what makes them real."

Her throat hadn't been split open by a single sentence because she was a Resident; it had been split open because of that tiny, tiny seed of doubt inside her.

A Resident's weapon was language — but its mode of attack was like wielding a syringe loaded with poison: it had to pierce the skin before the venom could take effect.

And that tiny shred of self-doubt was the opening in the skin — without that opening, a Resident's verbal assault would never land.

If the Resident had said the exact same words to Anthony, his throat would never have so much as cracked, because his sense of who he was was crystal clear, with no connection whatsoever to being a "Resident."

"...Your instinct is to crowd out my existence. So you kept reminding me, pointing out problem after problem, flaw after flaw, trying to make me believe that I was the Resident. 'Sydney

Ginn' is a seat. If I die — or if I disappear — the seat opens up, and only then can you sit in it forever, and truly become Sydney Ginn.

"To that end, you split my throat with a single sentence, and then you tried to tell me that a Resident's 'copy' has a time limit — even if no such thing exists, now that you've said it out loud, before long I'll gradually start to turn into a Resident myself. Won't I?"

That tiny seed of doubt she'd felt just moments ago had already served as the opening, letting those words seep inside. Time was running out for Sydney Ginn.

If she couldn't deal with the Resident in front of her soon, she might very well begin to take its place and become the Resident herself...

Even though she was sure she had thought it all through clearly, the moment that thought surfaced, a small voice rose from somewhere deep inside her: Are you sure?

When that moment comes, will you be "replacing" it as the Resident — or will you be "reverting" to what you always were?

...No. This wasn't the time for that. She was already barely holding "Sydney Ginn" down.

Sydney Ginn shoved the voice back into the depths of her mind and picked up her pace, trying to pour out everything she needed to say before the window closed.

"The moment you said there was a time limit on 'Residents' — that was actually the beginning of me seeing the truth. Because the real 'Sydney Ginn' has absolutely no idea that this information exists. I'm not even sure the information is real. Did you make it up on the spot, just to turn me into the Resident in your place?"

The final syllable stretched out and cracked into a broken note.

The Resident lunged with a sudden, violent surge, clawing out more room to move — and its fist connected with Sydney Ginn's temple. Through the ringing crash and the burst of white sparks, when her vision finally cleared again, she found herself on the floor without knowing when she'd been thrown there.

"Sydney Ginn" was climbing to her feet, coughing drily. The long towel, soaked through with saliva and heavy with it, lay slumped on the floor nearby.

"You're wrong," it said.

Its voice was rough and raw, as though its lips and tongue were still thick and numb and refusing to obey. "...The real Sydney Ginn does know this. Last month, when I was listening to the radio, the host mentioned it in passing as a rumor. I remembered it..."

Fire axe — three words dropped into Sydney Ginn's mind like a stone.

She couldn't let it get the fire axe.

She couldn't stand. She pushed herself onto all fours and crawled, swaying, toward the fire axe. The Resident clearly saw where she was heading; it let out a soft, contemptuous laugh, pivoted, and made as if to kick her — and just as Sydney Ginn scrambled frantically aside and landed hard on her backside, the Resident turned and strode toward the fire axe.

There seemed to be only one way left to slow it down.

Even just a few seconds' delay would be enough — just enough to let herself catch her breath.

Staring at her other self walking briskly away toward the fire axe, Sydney Ginn called out in a hoarse cry:

"Then why don't I?"

The other "Sydney Ginn" stopped dead in her tracks. She turned her eyes and looked down at Sydney Ginn from beneath her lids.

"You said the real Sydney Ginn knows this piece of information — right? If you're the original and I'm the copy, then by that logic, the information should be in my head too."

Sydney Ginn let out a low, dry laugh at her other self. Her throat felt like it had just been rolled through gravel and come out coated in a fine layer of grit.

"...The moment you said it, I suddenly realized — it's not there. I don't have it. I'm not the copy. You are."

The Resident stood there blankly, as if it had no idea how to react.

"And don't forget — there's one more key point."

Sydney Ginn didn't dare crawl any closer toward the fire axe; she was afraid of jolting the Resident out of its daze. The more confused it was, the better for her. "...Residents can't be killed, right? But I died once. Didn't I?"

The Resident lowered its head and shook it — hard, several times.

"No — you could be lying to me. You could know perfectly well, and just claim you don't. Wouldn't that be the simplest thing in the world?"

It spoke in a voice that was almost a murmur.

If a voice could take a shape, this one would have been a long, burrowing worm, drilling endlessly toward the dark, never turning its face toward the light. "The idea that Residents can't be killed has always just been a rumor. Before today, before trying to kill you, I had never actually attempted to kill a Resident myself... The truth of it was always up for debate."

"You see," Sydney Ginn said with a small, breathless laugh, "a Resident really will find every excuse and reason to shore up its own memories and logic — to convince itself that it's the real person."

The words fell away, and the gallery held a silence of one or two seconds.

She watched herself slowly lift her head toward her.

A person is not very familiar with their own expressions — not unless they spend every waking moment in front of a mirror — so Sydney Ginn found it difficult to describe what that fleeting look on the face across from her truly meant. If she had to describe it, it was as though something that had always hung suspended in "Sydney Ginn's" mind had, in that instant, come crashing down.

The next moment, she understood.

"It doesn't matter which one of us is the Resident," that face — her own face — said, twisting just slightly. "If I kill you, I naturally become the real Sydney Ginn."

Before the last word had even left its mouth, it had already lunged forward, snatching up the fire axe in one swift motion, and swung its gaze back toward Sydney Ginn — Sydney Ginn cursed under her breath, yanked off her other sock, scrambled to her feet, and ran.

No wonder it was a copy of her. Faced with the same problem, it had arrived at exactly the same answer.

Sydney Ginn had assumed that once she punctured the Resident's confidence and made it doubt itself, things would take a turn — but whether the Resident felt confident or not, it was still coming to kill her. Hadn't the situation stayed exactly the same at its core?

And the worst of it was: she couldn't kill the Resident, but the Resident could kill her. Could she even win this fight?

The exhibition hall was large enough — but when someone behind you was swinging an axe, it suddenly felt far too small.

Sydney Ginn was barefoot. She couldn't run toward the carpet of wood splinters on the floor — if a splinter drove itself into her foot and she couldn't run, she was as good as dead. That left her only one direction to run: toward the enormous candle.

...And toward the small, dancing flames at its base.

The Resident hadn't put out the fire. It hadn't let the candle solidify either — the thought leapt into Sydney Ginn's mind.

When she'd been watching from a distance just now, she had noticed that the section it had melted seemed to be not far from the period when she'd first met Anthony — which was to say, roughly six months ago.

Wait — if the section from six months ago could be melted, then—

Sydney Ginn's thoughts hadn't finished turning when her feet slowed without her realizing it, because she was thinking.

A blow — heavy and razor-sharp — severed both her train of thought and her shoulder at once.

Friends, I'm so sorry — I was completely wiped out yesterday. I'm a massive introvert, but these past couple of days I have unexpectedly transformed into a social butterfly that has physically bloated from all of it (I really have gotten bigger — haven't managed more than a few proper meals, and I'm already up to 125 jin now). Yesterday I essentially died face-down on my bed.

But today I rallied with every ounce of fighting spirit I had — and you'll never guess where I ended up finishing this chapter...

I opened a passage, entered the Yuewen Nest, and finished it at their headquarters...

How do I put this — the pressure was very real, but hey, pressure gets chapters written... After all, tomorrow I have to, you know, get on another plane, so a little pressure was exactly what I needed...

(Honestly, this Shanghai trip has completely spiraled into a whole other storyline. I never expected to have my cover blown like this — once I have a moment, I'll fill you all in on everything.)